Iudicium et Rationem (Of Judgement and Reason)

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Iudicium et Rationem (Of Judgement and Reason)

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Summary

The world of Etheria has always been full of secrets. Some, darker than others. But most importantly, there has been a very delicate balance keeping the world from falling into a bloody war for the past few centuries. The people privy to such secrets usually learnt very quickly why they had to keep their mouths shut. And so, for decades, Etheria had been in relative peace…

However, rumours began circulating five years ago. People spoke about vampires and hunters; the names “Horde” and “Alliance” started floating around, and now, Bright Moon's Police Chief has finally found out the truth. The rumors *are true*, and the hunters can no longer be allowed to execute vampires at will; they must be stopped and tried for their crimes.

With her aid, a young vampire working for the Court and a former vampire vampire-hunter will do everything in their power to bring justice and security to Etheria's people.

Notes

Welcome everyone!!
If you’ve read my last spop anniversary big bang fic, welcome back, I have what you’ve been asking for! XD
If not, don’t worry! This “second part” can be read as a standalone and then, if you like it, you can go to the first part (Fidem et Proditionem) to see what the heck happened to arrive at this point lol

Also, keep in mind a little thing: The first ~~3~~ 2 chapters* will be posted one after the other, one each day, but then the updates will be weekly on Wednesdays :D

And second, I’d like to clarify this, to make sure my way of writing is clear enough. I don’t write in the English format.
That would be:
"Character's direct speech" narration.
E.g.: "Hello!" they said.

Instead, I write in the Spanish format.
Which would be:
—Character's direct speech— narration.
E.g.: —Hello— they said.

I hope everyone can read it with no problems :)

Finally, I’m really excited about this this year! I got two amazing artists drawing for me TT^TT and the came up with such cool stuff for our vampires, you have no idea!

*there was an incident™ and I couldn't post yesterday, namely an almost final-destination-ish event… it's the Ao3 curse, guys… so yeah, just posting the first 2 chapters…

So! Without further ado, ENJOY!

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Catra felt simply insane.

It hadn't even been that long since this mess began, and yet…

Everything was those hunters' fault.

If they hadn't used that weird device, if she hadn't attacked Adora and get shot in return, Adora would still be blissfully unaware of everything.

Now she wants to take the whole Alliance to justice!?

If that woman hadn't talked her out of it, she would have already acted, so -she'd be damned- she had to thank Shadow Weaver at some point…

Sure, she would…

Ah… What did it matter now!?

A month of no progress made Adora restless and now she wanted to take matters into her hands again.

And then there was Sparkles to deal with!

Alright, first things first.

Recap. She had to recap.

So… One night, the hunters set up that device some blocks away from her home, and both she and Adora happened to cross paths within its range. Catra had attacked her, got shot in return, and obviously Adora freaked out when she found the lounge full of blood.

From there, everything went downhill.

First, she had to explain everything, fearing Adora would feel betrayed.

Second, Glimmer told them Bow had become a hunter too, which meant now the three of them were keeping stuff from Sparkles…

Third, just a month or so in, and she got captured!

Finally all secrets were out, Glimmer learnt her own parents had been lying to her, as well as her fiancé, and her best friends… And everyone else learnt Shadow Weaver, the most feared hunter, was also a vampire! Whom they had captured along with Catra!

Seriously… Insane.

And now… Well, now things felt a bit normal again.

After Adora and Castaspella went to save them, Shadow Weaver erased everyone's memories…

Catra shivered every time she recalled that night…

But for how long would this normality remain?

A month had been by since that awful night; she had taken Adora to speak with her boss, Hordak, *a Vulture*, and he revealed some sort of prophecy that would fulfill again… A prophecy Adora is part of, along with that physician, Castaspella.

Oh, right, it was almost time for her turning too.

Catra was a bit unsure about that.

Letting her, of all people, be turned… Her brother is a *hunter*. And after what he did when they captured Shadow Weaver, his own Master, Catra feared what he would do if he found out his sister will become a vampire too…

And then again, she had been helping Adora build a case against the Alliance of hunters, but they couldn't do much with the information Castaspella gathered… As long as they remain free, the physician will be in great danger.

Well, they all were in great danger, but Castaspella was Catra's responsibility since Hordak assigned her to protect the physician! It was her duty to make sure nothing happened to her!

—Catra?

—Dor… Uh, sorry, was I spacing out?

—Yeah, a bit. Are you alright?

—Yes, of course. Just… thinking.

—About?

—Well… I-It's not the first time I witness someone being turned but, like, I can't stop thinking this isn't a good idea. Not *yet*.

—You're worried about Castaspella's safety, right?

—Yes— Catra sighed. —I'm sorry, Love, but you haven't been able to take the hunters into custody yet. You have a lot of evidence yet it's not enough— she pointed out. —So it's seriously a bad idea to do this *now* while they are still out.

—I- Ah… Yeah, I know— Adora nodded. —But Castaspella insisted she made all preparations and wants to do this.

—Can't we talk her out of it?

—I don’t think so— a deep voice interrupted. —Judge Hordak is waiting for you, Catra.

—Aren’t you worried about Castaspella’s safety?

—That won’t be a problem.

—Explain— Catra demanded, sneering at Shadow Weaver.

—You’ll soon know…

—Ugh…

—Come on, now.

—I should wait here, right?

—Yes, Dor, better stay here— Catra nodded, offering her a kiss before following Shadow Weaver into Hordak’s office.

Inside, a stretcher had already been prepared for Castaspella.

The physician didn’t look scared.

She was a bit too serious, actually.

—Alright— the Judge let out, once the door closed behind Catra. —With us as witnesses, Shadow Weaver, you can begin— he ordered.

Catra was expecting Castaspella to gasp and open her eyes in surprise when the old vampire bit her, but she didn’t.

Her serious expression barely twitched and her eyes closed as if she were focusing on not making a sound.

Some people didn’t really mind the process; some even enjoyed it.

The physician, on the other hand, seemed to be… struggling not to enjoy it while also making an effort to keep something at bay, perhaps fear.

Whatever it was had to be far from hesitation.

Catra had seen people hesitant to be turned. It was normal.

This!? This wasn’t normal.

Or perhaps it was in this particular situation…

She would pay to know what went on inside Castaspella’s head right now.

After a long, tense moment, Hordak cleared his throat and gestured at Catra to make Shadow Weaver stop.

—That's enough— Catra verbalized, only to earn a snarl in return.

—If you don't stop now, you will kill her— the Judge clarified.

—Right…

She finally complied, albeit reluctant and angrily.

—Feed her your blood now— he ordered.

—It'll be easier if you offer her your wrist, already opened— Catra suggested.

Shadow Weaver clearly didn't like it one bit when she ordered her around, but it could certainly be worse, so she preferred to keep it civil for now and didn't react to the old vampire's growling.

Fortunately, she silently complied and bit her own wrist to offer it to Castaspella.

Semi-conscious, the young woman reached for it, pulled it towards her mouth, and slowly began drinking.

Catra couldn't shake the feeling that this wasn't a typical turning. Something felt *wrong* but she couldn't pin-point what.

It wasn't long before Castaspella, seemingly satisfied, let go of Shadow Weaver's wrist and laid back on the stretcher, unconscious.

—Now what?— the old vampire asked, using a healing spell on her wrist.

—Now we wait— Hordak replied, serious. —There are plenty of matters to discuss, after all.

—Like what?

—Your duties: you haven't fulfilled them…

—I can't do much for you while pretending to be a hunter, you know?— Shadow Weaver scoffed. —But you needn't worry, Judge, that will change today.

—What?— Catra let out, confused.

—Yes, I know. But that's exactly why we have to discuss the consequences of not fulfilling your duties from now on.

—So you're going to threaten me?

—By no means— he assured her, smirking. —But a fair warning is always welcome. Or is that not the case for you?

—Right… Sure…

—In that case- Huh?— Hordak interrupted himself, his ears twitching as he apparently caught a weak sound. —She's waking up— he noticed.

—Casta— Shadow Weaver called.

It sounded strangely soft…

—I… What…

The physician made an effort to open her eyes, barely moved her left hand, which the vampire quickly grabbed, but before she could utter another word, she passed out again.

—What happened?

—Hmm… Let me take a look— Hordak requested, approaching. He carefully examined the physician, checking her mouth, eyes, and then ordered —Move her closer to the sun.

—*What*?

—Catra— he insisted.

—Yes— she quickly nodded, just as confused as Shadow Weaver but trusting he had a reason to order that.

Taking a deep breath and unsure of what to expect, Catra dragged the stretcher to the closest window and, careful not to be touched by the sun herself, partially exposed Castaspella's leg to the sunlight.

She seemed bothered but… unaffected.

What!? *How*!?

—I don't understand— Shadow Weaver uttered.

—I do— Hordak smiled. —Short fangs, barely any difference in her eyes, which in humans tends to be significant, and of course, just a slight increase in sunlight sensitivity but nothing noticeable — he enumerated. —She hardly moved and has no burns whatsoever.

—How is that possible?— Catra asked, mirroring the old vampire's astonishment.

—She's a *lesser* vampire— he finally revealed. —As she was turned by a vampire instead of a vulture like me, she's far weaker than either of you, but… that means her vulnerabilities are also weaker— he explained. —She will have no problem with the sun, likely won't struggle to keep her fangs hidden, may not be as fast or strong as you, but that means she can easily pass as a human…

—So… She's not- She's a vampire but not fully?

—She's still immortal, if that's what you're asking— Hordak replied, nodding at Shadow Weaver. —And that's what mattered the most to her, isn't it?

—Right— she nodded too.

—Is that also why she woke up but fainted again?— Catra dared ask.

—Possibly… But she's still not responding— he noticed. —Fetch Entrapta. I'll need her to run a few tests to monitor Castaspella's condition until it's normalized.

—Right away— Catra nodded, immediately leaving the office. —I knew something was wrong… — she muttered, rushing to the front desk.

—Catra! Wait— Adora called, joining her. —What happened?

—Castaspella isn't waking up. And she's not a vampire like me, but rather… a *lesser* vampire.

—Is she alright?

—We don't know. I have to get Entrapta— Catra explained. As they reached the desk where Lonnie handled a few administrative documents, she knocked on the table to call her attention and requested —Can you tell Entrapta that Hordak needs her in his office? It's an emergency.

—Sure, let me call her to the workshop— Lonnie nodded. After a few seconds on the phone, she said —Excuse me, Princess, the boss needs you at the office.

—Sometimes I forget she's a princess— Catra chuckled.

—She'll be there.

—Thanks— the vampire nodded, before heading back to the office.

—A-aren't you waiting for Entrapta?

—What? Oh, no, she has a way to move around the court way faster than us— Catra laughed. —She'll be there before I get back inside.

—Oh… A-alright— Adora sighed. —I'll keep waiting here, then.

—Thanks, Love— she replied, squeezing one of her hands before entering the office.

As expected, Entrapta was already there, checking Castaspella's vitals.

—I'll be right back!— she exclaimed, before disappearing into some small passage on the wall.

—So?

—Nothing to worry about. It's just taking more time than usual, but once Entrapta provides her body with the necessary help, she should wake up— Hordak explained.

—She better— Shadow Weaver warned him.

—She *will*.

—A-alright— Catra stammered. —What now?

—Now, you will stay here and keep an eye on Castaspella while we go to speak with Chief Adora — Hordak ordered.

—What? Why?

—Because we have certain matters to discuss with her— Shadow Weaver explained, without really saying much.

—Right, sure.

—You will know in due time— he assured her, the warning about leaving the matter there implicit in his tone.

—Yes, Boss— she complied, lowering her ears.

—In that case, we should get going— Hordak decided, gesturing at the old vampire to leave the office.

Right as he left behind her and closed the door, Entrapta reappeared out of nowhere with a bunch of medical gadgets.

—Alright! I'm back! Catra, help me attach this to her— she requested.

—Sure…

Shadow Weaver

She had always been quite selfish.

Everything she'd do was to keep herself safe.

She stayed with the hunters to save her skin.

She made sure the Queen wouldn't ever recruit She-Ra to remain safe.

Everything she always did was solely to save *her own skin*.

No one else ever mattered to her.

Until Castaspella made her way into her hollow heart and crafted her pretty little nest right there…

Disgusting.

But now she was in quite deep, and she wouldn't let any harm come to her either.

So now she had to keep hers and Castaspella's skins safe.

Just great.

That's what the new deal with Judge Hordak was for.

She'd be her underling in exchange for full protection for the physician.

But, of course, that wasn't all…

During the past month, Castaspella had been making preparations to be turned too.

She'd become a vampire…

Shadow Weaver had had more than enough time to come to terms with it, and yet… she was still hesitant right now, moments before starting the process.

Which was frankly insane since they had practiced for this!

The young woman was afraid of how she'd react when Shadow Weaver drained her since she wasn't used to her actually biting her for blood, so she had insisted on preparing for it.

How exactly? Well, she stopped extracting the blood for her and instead had her drink directly from her neck; it was an exercise of restraint for both, and she had been *so right* to practice like that…

When Shadow Weaver finally began the process now, in front of Hordak, she could feel Castaspella put all their practice into work…

The first time she bit her, the young woman had been unable to hold back a moan, and she most definitely didn't want that to happen in front of anyone else. Now, she remained calm and collected, perhaps unnaturally so.

The first time, the old vampire had had some trouble stopping, but with practice she had gained control over her thirst, meaning they knew she would stop when told, even if that upset her a bit.

In any case, now that she was draining Castaspella of almost all her blood, they both trusted themselves and each other to the fullest.

They were ready.

But so much blood was… getting a bit intoxicating.

—That's enough— she suddenly heard.

Orders from the voice of that vampire girl weren't something she liked in the slightest; that had been a problem the past month…

As she snarled in return, the Judge intervened —If you don't stop now, you will kill her.

—Right…

She had to comply; reluctant and angrily she stood up straight again, licking her lips, but continued to hold Castaspella with her right hand, sitting up on the stretcher.

If she let go, the woman would fall limp and half-dead…

—Feed her your blood now— he ordered.

—It'll be easier if you offer her your wrist, already opened— Catra interceded again, much to her annoyance.

But she was right… which she liked *even less*.

Growling lowly but getting no reaction in return, Shadow Weaver had no choice but to follow the orders.

She bit her left wrist to open it for Castaspella, and offered it to the semi-conscious woman, who sloppily reached for it, pulled it closer, and slowly began drinking.

Now, this part, they hadn't practiced it.

The old vampire wasn't expecting it to be so… arousing too.

But she did a good job of keeping it hidden.

However, she was so focused on not letting it be noticed, that she almost missed it when Castaspella let go of her wrist, seemingly satisfied. Carefully, she helped her lay down on the stretcher as she finally lost consciousness.

Alright… There was no turning back now.

This was happening…

Shadow Weaver looked at her wrist for a second before starting to heal it with a spell.

—Now what?

—Now we wait— Hordak replied, serious. —There are plenty of matters to discuss, after all.

—Like what?— she scoffed.

—Your duties: you haven't fulfilled them…

Oh, not that shit again!

—I can't do much for you while pretending to be a hunter, you know?— she scoffed, rolling her eyes. —But you needn't worry, Judge, that will change today— she reminded him, leaving what they both knew implicit.

—What?— Catra let out, confused.

—Yes, I know. But that's exactly why we have to discuss the consequences of not fulfilling your duties from now on— he pointed out with a serious look.

—So you're going to threaten me?

Was he really going to blackmail her!?

This couldn't be!

This is the kind of weakness Shadow Weaver feared so much when it came to *love*.

Now that he knew how much she cares for Castaspella, was he really going to threaten her security to keep her obedient!?

—By no means— he assured her, extracting her from those thoughts. —But a fair warning is always welcome. Or is that not the case for you?

—Right… Sure…— she sighed, hoping he hadn't noticed her anxious spiraling.

—In that case- Huh?— Hordak interrupted himself, his ears twitching as he apparently caught a weak sound. And she heard it too. —She's waking up— he noticed.

She immediately turned to look at her and softly called —Casta.

—I… What…— the physician weakly uttered.

She was alive.

Shadow Weaver hadn't even noticed that looming fear that she might not survive… But she did.

She could now breathe easy.

She made an effort to open her eyes and barely moved her left hand, which the vampire wrapped between hers, but before she could utter another word, she passed out again.

—What happened?— she let out, without thinking.

—Hmm… Let me take a look— Hordak requested, approaching. A feeling of unease settled in the pit of her stomach as he closed in and started to carefully examine Castaspella. Oh, the vile that crawled up her throat when he dared touch her mouth, even if for a second to check her fangs. But then he also touched her face to open her eyes and take a look; it was really a test of Shadow Weaver's patience and self-restraint. Finally, the cherry on top was when the Judge ordered — Move her closer to the sun.

—*What*?

Had he gone insane!?

—Catra— he insisted, ignoring Shadow Weaver's indignation.

—Yes— she quickly nodded, at least having the decency to share her confusion.

But she still obeyed him without asking questions!

The old vampire instinctively held her breath as Catra dragged the stretcher under the sunlight, partially exposing Castaspella to it but careful not to be touched too.

She was so ready to hear the physician scream in pain…

But it didn't happen.

She was… unaffected. Only moved her leg a bit as if the sun bothered her, but there were no burns…

How!?

—I don't understand.

—I do— Hordak smiled. —Short fangs, barely any difference in her eyes, which in humans tends to be significant, and of course, just a slight increase in sunlight sensitivity but nothing noticeable — he enumerated. —She hardly moved and has no burns whatsoever.

—How is that possible?

Catra's question was exactly what Shadow Weaver wanted to ask but couldn't due to the shock.

—She's a lesser vampire— he finally revealed. A *what* now!? —As she was turned by a vampire instead of a vulture like me, she's far weaker than either of you, but… that means her vulnerabilities are also weaker— he further explained. But that meant… —She will have no problem with the sun, likely won't struggle to keep her fangs hidden, may not be as fast or strong as you, but that means she can easily pass as a human…

How- But- There was no way…

This was actually *so good*!

Unless this meant her life-span would also be shorter?

Now she was… more worried about Castaspella's reaction.

—So… She's not- She's a vampire but not fully?

—She's still immortal, if that's what you're asking— Hordak replied with a nod. —And that's what mattered the most to her, isn't it?— he added, perfectly guessing what she was thinking.

—Right— she nodded back.

—Is that also why she woke up but fainted again?— Catra then asked.

Right, she was still there.

—Possibly… But she's still not responding— he noticed. —Fetch Entrapta. I'll need her to run a few tests to monitor Castaspella's condition until it's normalized.

—Right away— she immediately nodded, before leaving the office.

—Well… In the meantime…— the Judge began, while Shadow Weaver wanted nothing but to focus on the physician. —We have matters to discuss.

—Yes, I *know*. So, let me guess: you will only keep her safe as long as I remain your obedient lackey, no?

He chuckled.

And shook his head.

—Far from it, Beatrix. I have my own reasons to want Castaspella safe and sound— he assured her, smirking ominously. —Unfortunately, that means the consequences of disobeying me will be far more than you can hope to withstand.

—Speak.

—So *now* you're interested— he mocked her. —Very well: To put it simply, any task *you* fail to complete, will be transferred to her.

—Excuse me!?

—You're free to refuse any orders I give, but know that it will only be reassingned to her— he clarified.

—You can't do that…

—Oh, but I can. And I *know* she won't refuse.

—You disgusting…

—I'm here!— Princess Entrapta suddenly interrupted, before Shadow Weaver could fully spell out her insult.

That scared her half to death…

—Thank you, Entrapta. Check on this woman, if you would…

—Of course! Did you just turn her?

—Not me, she did.

—Oh, that's unusual— the Princess realized. —Give me a moment to check her vitals then!

—Careful…— Shadow Weaver growled.

—It's alright, I won't hurt her— Entrapta assured her, her movements more slow and deliberate now. Far less invasive than Hordak, she checked Castaspella's pulse and who-knows-what-else. Once she had seen enough, she stepped back and, right as Catra walked back into the office, the Princess exclaimed —I'll be right back!

And just like that, Entrapta disappeared into a small passage on the wall.

Must have come through there in the first place…

Charming.

—So?— Catra asked.

—Nothing to worry about. It's just taking more time than usual, but once Entrapta provides her body with the necessary help, she should wake up— Hordak casually explained.

A bit too casual.

—She better— Shadow Weaver warned him, her tone hinting a threat.

—She *will*.

Oh, he would be *sorry* otherwise. She'd make sure of it.

—A-alright— Catra stammered. —What now?

—Now, you will stay here and keep an eye on Castaspella while we go to speak with Chief Adora — Hordak ordered.

—What? Why?— she asked, more scared than confused.

—Because we have certain matters to discuss with her— the old vampire decided to explain, as ominously as possible.

—Right, sure.

—You will know in due time— he assured her, in a seemingly warning tone.

Oh, so he didn't want to reveal it either?

—Yes, Boss— she complied, lowering her ears.

That was almost pathetic.

—In that case, we should get going— Hordak decided, gesturing at Shadow Weaver to leave the office.

They didn't lose time and went immediately to find Adora, who looked quite nervous, pacing around the reception.

—Oh, i-is it done?

—Chief, rest assured, everything is fine— the Judge began. —We have our own matters to discuss now so, if you don't mind, follow me into somewhere more private— he requested, going straight to the point.

—A-alright— she nodded, complying. The three went into a smaller office to the right of the court, which looked more like an archive than an office, and she didn't wait a second to ask —I suppose this is about the deal? What exactly do you mean? If it's about the case I'm trying to build, I haven't made much progress but I *promise* I will!

—Calm down, Chief. No need to be so anxious— Hordak smirked. —On the contrary, you should be glad.

—What do you mean?

—Your wish came true, Adora. You have your case— Shadow Weaver proudly told her. —You can take the Alliance to justice.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed this first chapter!!
The art will be coming soon, I promise!

See you tomorrow!! :D

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

It took a while for Castaspella to wake up.

But still, neither her boss nor Shadow Weaver had returned.

At first, Castaspella didn't mind but, once she felt well enough to stand from the stretcher, she became a bit impatient.

Besides, they had run out of topics to discuss after Catra explained what Hordak had said.

She couldn't blame her for being so restless.

—I-I mean, they must still be talking, discussing something important…

—But you want to go for her?

—Maybe…— Castaspella admitted, sighing. —I would have preferred it if she stayed with me until I woke up…

—Yeah, that was kinda weird— Catra agreed. —She looked pretty over-protective. Whatever they went to discuss with Adora must be just as important… Or… you know, it may be something for you— she considered. —It's the only explanation.

—They didn't mention what it was, and Adora probably doesn't know anything either, right?

—Mhm…

—Did they say anything else?

—Nah… Only- I mean, Shadow Weaver said something about no longer being a hunter… And Hordak was going to tell her about the consequences of not following his orders…

—Hold on- She won't be a hunter any more!? Are you sure that's what she said?

—Well, yeah… She told Hordak she wasn't fulfilling her duties due to having to pretend to be a hunter still, but then said he didn't have to worry about that from now on, something like that— Catra explained.

—Oh, shit…

—What?

—She's turning herself in!— Castaspella exclaimed, clutching her head with both hands. —That *bitch*!

—Wait, wait, what do you mean!?

—Since she and Bow have failed to take down the Alliance from inside, and so have Adora and I failed to put together enough viable evidence to take them to court, she will… she *has* made a deal with your boss and will testify against them, essentially supporting the whole case, in exchange for… house arrest, I reckon.

—You're kidding me…

—No— Castaspella apologetically replied, giving Catra a pained look. —Sorry, Adora will be quite busy for a while…

—Don't apologize— Catra muttered. —It's not like she didn't want to do exactly that…

Arms folded, she turned around, jaw clenched, telling herself not to take out her rage on Castaspella.

—Should we go find them?

—You know what? Sure. Either they are still here in the court or back at the Police Station, but we should find them. I think… I'm sure they'll want to know you're awake— Catra finally said.

—Thank you— the physician gently smiled.

—Yeah— she replied, unable to keep herself from smiling back.

Well, Catra was right, after all.

Adora and Shadow Weaver had gone to the Police Station where the old vampire was giving her testimony, while Judge Hordak went to define the terms of the arrangement with the prosecutor.

Right, the prosecutor. It could only be one person…

This wasn't going to be fun for the hunters.

At all.

Once at the station, Catra had Castaspella wait seated while she got into the room next to interrogation's. She knew Adora would be there.

—Hey… Catra?— she let out, surprised.

—Hey, Adora… How's the interrogation going?

—Incredible. I have my people taking Shadow Weaver's testimony and I'm waiting for the Judge to send the prosecutor.

—You don't know them yet, right?

—Nope.

—Then I won't say anything— Catra smirked.

—Anyways! Shouldn't you be with Castaspella!?

—Yeah, well, she woke up a while ago and *really* wants to see Shadow Weaver, so she's outside, waiting for her.

—This doesn't look like it will end soon. She should probably wait for her at home.

—You tell her— Catra scoffed. —I don't think she's moving from that chair any time soon— she laughed.

—No, I mean it— Adora insisted. —Ah… I'll go talk to her.

—Yeah, you probably should.

—Come with me, please. You should accompany her home, actually. That's part of the arrangement— the Chief pointed out.

Right, that… makes sense.

—O-of course.

—Hey, Castaspella— Adora called, once they were close enough.

—Oh, Chief! Good, uh… afternoon. It's the afternoon, right? I forgot to check…

—Yeah, it is— Adora giggled. —But you should be resting.

—I would like to see Bea- Shadow Weaver.

—I know, but she's… giving her testimony for my agents to write it down. This will take… a *really* long while— she apologetically explained.

Castaspella briefly looked at Catra with a hopeless expression.

—But… I-I can't leave alone…

—She will accompany you, don't worry.

—I trust Catra, but I mean…

—She doesn't want to *be* alone right now, dummy— Catra clarified.

—Oh, I see…

—Please, can I wait here, Chief?

—I mean… I- Uh, yes?

—I'll bring her something to eat— Catra offered.

—*Something*?— Adora asked back, brow raised.

She knew what her partner meant to ask…

—Yeah, something totally suitable to eat in public— Catra mocked her.

—Alright… I'll let you wait here, then— Adora sighed.

—Thank you— Castaspella weakly smiled. —Both of you.

—Of course.

—Be right back— Catra promised.

A few hours passed.

Then a few more.

People walked in and out of the interrogation room and the one next to it.

At some point, even Detective Trouble showed up.

But Castaspella had fallen asleep by then.

And before she knew it, Catra dozed off too.

When she woke up, slowly recovering her senses, there was a hand gently holding her shoulder.

—Catra?

—Huh?

—Are you alright?

—I am… I'm awake… What-what happened?

—You fell asleep— Adora giggled. —Castaspella is still sleeping.

—Please tell me you're done with the interrogation.

—Yeah.

—Great.

—But, it's like… Six in the morning.

—*What*!?

—Yeah, I know— Adora apologetically replied. —We're going home soon, though. I finally spoke with the Prosecutor. She and the Judge discussed the arrangement for Shadow Weaver, and then she took the written testimony and a copy for him.

—Does that mean…

—This is only starting. But it's *finally* starting.

—Wait- A-are you going to take the regents into custody!?

—I won't do so personally. My teams will— Adora sighed. —I can't do it myself due to my close relationship with them and Glimmer…

—I see…

—So, uh… Well, they gave me the day off— she smiled. —So let's go home.

—I still have to accompany Castaspella until she reaches her place.

—Of course, we can take them first— Adora nodded. —But, uh, I wouldn't… mention the anklet.

The *what*!?

—Oh- Ah, I see…— Catra let out, realizing what she meant. —She's probably far from happy to have that…

—Yeah…

—Alright. Should I wake Castaspella up?

—Nah, let Shadow Weaver do it— Adora chuckled. —She's in a bad mood, and probably holding it together only for her.

—Ah, I get it. She'd be looking for any excuse to take her rage out on someone…

—Mhm…

—Alright, I'll go to the bathroom to wash my face then…

—Of course. Go, I'll wait here.

Catra gave her a faint smile and took a deep breath as she headed for the bathroom.

Once inside, she took a look at her reflection and sighed. It was obvious she had been sleeping until just now…

Then, she took a look out of the small window. The sun wasn't up yet but the sky was clearing already.

Goodness… She couldn't even begin to imagine how tired Adora had to be.

And how busy she would be from now on… for quite a long while…

After all, the trials would soon begin.

The regents- The *hunters* would fall.

And Catra knew Adora would see it all through.

No rest until it’s done.

No rest until everyone is *safe*.

Shadow Weaver

She could see Adora’s struggle to keep herself from celebrating.

And she couldn’t blame her…

After a month of useless work to bring the captors of her fiancée to justice… It was only expected.

But the Chief was too nice and probably thought it would be a show of disrespect.

After all… Shadow Weaver was literally turning herself in.

—Alright, I- Uh- So… We should probably go to the Station to get the declaration written down, I mean, your whole testimony about, well, *everything* the hunters- the Alliance has been doing— Adora nervously began. —And, I suppose you, Judge, have to sign the arrangement? Oh, wait, the Prosecutor! Who…

—Calm down, Chief— Hordak calmly stopped her.

—Sorry…

—No need to apologize. I understand this is quite a big moment for you, and since this case will be the people against the Regents of Bright Moon, not just any Prosecutor will take the case— he considered. —I will find one suitable, that I can promise, and if any modifications need to be made to the arrangement, we’ll discuss them and you both will be updated on them.

—Sounds fair, as long as I still remain *out* of jail.

—Of course— Hordak nodded. —Allow me to make the necessary preparations then. You can get started with the written testimony.

—Tha-thank you, Judge Hordak— Adora nodded. She then gave Shadow Weaver a questioning look and told her —The sooner we begin, the sooner we’ll be done with it.

—Right, Chief. Much as I would like to wait until Castaspella wakes up, I know for a fact writing everything down will take… quite some time.

Oh, she *hated* this.

She absolutely didn't want to leave her alone right now… she wanted to be there when she woke up.

But she needed the police to take the regents into custody as soon as possible, so she had to do this *now*.

Once they arrived at the police station, Shadow Weaver was led to an interrogation room.

It was quite spacious, had a table, a couple of chairs, and a mirror. She figured the other side of the mirror was see-through, which meant the Chief would likely stay on that side… most likely.

As expected, someone else appeared to question her and write down her every word. It was a bulky blond man with a gentle expression, perhaps too gentle.

He was probably nothing more than someone who handled administrative duties.

Was he actually fit to conduct an interrogation?

He soon proved to be.

—So, what you're saying is that the Library has a secret area at the back full of hunter's supplies and such?

—Precisely. The "forbidden section".

—Alright. So that's it for the Head Quarters. Let's move on to your colleagues.

—You mean those with the same rank as me or just everyone in general?

—Can you begin by enumerating the ranks, first?

—Of course— she sighed. —As you can imagine, the one on top of the organization is Queen Angella. She's not an active hunter, only assigns missions and handles most administrative work.

—Why isn't she an active hunter?

—Her powers would call civilians' attention. To put it simply, vampires are *lucky* she decided to take such precautions, or there would be no vampires left anymore.

—Are her powers that strong?

—She can shoot pure light from her hands, akin to sunlight.

—I see.

—Right under her, you have experienced hunters like me, King Micah, and several generals who serve in Bright Moon's palace— she explained.

—I will need all their names, Shadow Weaver.

—Of course…

A few more hours passed.

The old vampire went through many topics, explained the archiving system of the Alliance, enumerated the different weapons and gadgets normally used, described some of the most relevant protocols, and explained how she had become a vampire yet remained a hunter as it was more advantageous for herself.

And, of course, she mentioned hers and Catra's capture and… her torture.

At some point, a detective named Double Trouble showed up to ask a few more questions, most of them regarding the case of the Butcher Brothers, and took her testimony for what would be her trial for double murder in self-defense.

And finally the prosecutor showed up, carrying a large folder.

—Good evening, Shadow Weaver. My name is Netossa, I'll be the lawyer in charge of taking the Alliance to justice, but first, the matter of your trial for murder has to be settled. Meaning I'll also be the prosecutor accusing you— she explained. —As per our laws, you have been granted the opportunity to get only house arrest if you plead guilty, fulfilling the arrangement offered by Judge Hordak. Is that understood?

—It is— she nodded. —But I must ask: does that mean the trial will be private? Revealing my status as a vampire to the public before the trial against the regents would be a mistake— she explained, serious yet slightly condescending.

She couldn't help it.

—Correct. Since you're pleading guilty, the trial would be a mere formality for the books and nothing more— Netossa nodded. —Now…— she sighed, taking a seat in front of Shadow Weaver. —With your testimony, not only can we take the regents into custody this same day, or tomorrow morning, at this point, but also, we can get an order to register the Library in search for this secret room where all hard evidence would be hidden— she summarized. —Anything you need to tell us about this before the orders are issued?

—Only one thing: I spoke about my capture and torture, yet there's nothing to prove either me or Catra were captured since, a month ago, my partner made sure to get rid of all the information and intel the hunters had about us— she explained. —And I wiped their memories, so they don't even know any of that happened.

—Let me check something…— Netossa muttered, opening the folder and quickly going through several folios. —Ah, here it is: the case Chief Adora had been putting together before now, which didn't have enough weight to get the regents arrested, includes several pieces of evidence submitted by… Castaspella— she read. —I'll venture that's your partner since some of the items among it include reports on you and Catra signed by Angella herself.

Wait…

She did *not*…

—Of course she did— Shadow Weaver hissed between gritted teeth. —Alright, that may be useful, supposing it is admissible.

—Well, it seems to be— Netossa confirmed, looking surprised herself. —Apparently there's a bit of a technicism… It may cause some trouble with the defense attourney, but I'm sure it can be

used.

—I see— the vampire nodded. —Then the problem would be proving the torture.

—Not really— Netossa chuckled, amused at whatever she was reading.

Now what!?

—It says here there's a detailed report on your wounds, including pictures even.

—When did she… Ah… I recall— Shadow Weaver realized. —She mentioned it could be useful for the case, but I wasn't expecting her to write a whole report— she let out, in utter disbelief.

—Well, she did. And before you ask, it *is* admissible since she's a certified physician; there are absolutely no laws about these reports being written by someone related to the patient— Netossa quickly clarified.

—Almost as if you read my mind, Prosecutor.

—It's only my job to take all these things into consideration— she smiled, proud. —And I pay a *lot* of attention.

Well, Hordak certainly chose a suitable attourney for the job.

Shadow Weaver was almost sure she had spent all night revising the details of her testimony with Adora's subordinates and the prosecutor.

And she was right.

Once everything seemed in order, and after checking the anklet was working properly, the old vampire was allowed to leave the interrogation room.

No sunlight came through the windows yet, but she could see the sky turning light blue already.

With a deep sigh, Shadow Weaver followed the path she had walked when the Chief brought her, and finally found Adora and Castaspella.

It was no surprise to find the physician asleep.

—Oh, there you are— the Chief said, relieved. —I was about to go for you.

—I wasn't lost, Adora, I just had this… thing checked before I could leave.

—Of course— she nodded. —Well, then, as soon as Catra returns from the bathroom, I'm taking you both home.

—We can walk— Shadow Weaver pointed out.

—I- No, well, you can't walk around without vigilance, even… with the anklet. I'm sorry— Adora apologized. —Besides, Castaspella may be too sleepy to walk, wouldn't you say?

—Right— the vampire huffed. —Then I should wake her up already.

Gently, despite knowing Adora was looking, Shadow Weaver brushed back the physician's hair and cupped her cheek. Caressing it with her thumb was usually enough as she's a really light sleeper, but it wasn't this time.

Noticing no reaction, the old vampire changed strategies, shifted her grasp from her face to the back of her neck, and made Castaspella face the bright lights of the station.

—Ugh…— she weakly groaned.

—That's better— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—What- Bea?— the physician let out, brushing her eyes. With a gasp, she finally opened her eyes wide and jumped to embrace her, exclaiming —You're finally back!

—Yes, yes. I'm not going anywhere…

—I was so worried— Castaspella sobbed. —I didn't think you'd be doing this so soon…

—I needed them to arrest Micah and Angella before they had a chance to cross paths with you again now that…

—Now that I'm a vampire?

—A *lesser* vampire— Shadow Weaver clarified, as Castaspella slowly released her. —Please tell me someone has explained everything to you…

—Yes, Catra already did.

—Good.

—I did what?

—Oh, you're back!— Adora smiled. —We can get going then.

—Of course— Shadow Weaver nodded, offering Castaspella her hand to follow the Chief and her fiancée. —Let's go home.

Chapter End Notes

Hehe! Fun's about to start!
Since I had An Incident™, next chapter that was supposed to go out today won't, you'll have to wait until next Wednesday 😅 oops…

But I sure hope you're hooked enough to wait a few days 🫣

ANYWAYS! First piece of art is up already, and there's more to come!
So see you next Wednesday and thank you so much for reading!

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

The ride to Shadow Weaver's home was silent at first. Catra could see Castaspella kept dozing off on the old vampire's shoulder, only to be jolted awake by sudden moves of the patrol car.

—Hey…— she decided to say, after the physician woke up again. —There is something I just… realized and you two should probably discuss that as soon as possible.

—What is it?— Shadow Weaver inquired, serious.

—You can't be Head Physician anymore. And as your successor would be Micah… the position will be vacant still— Catra explained. —In a few hours the news about your deal and the regents' arrest will be out. So you should probably get ready for that.

—Then who could be… Head Physician?— Castaspella asked, interrupted by a yawn.

—How do you normally chose the candidates for the position?

—Merit. Knowledge. Years of work…

—Well, uh… better think about putting together a list— Catra suggested.

—Alright. Thanks for the reminder— Castaspella weakly smiled.

—We're here, right?— Adora then asked, slowing down next to an imponent house.

—Yup…

—Thank you for the ride, Chief— the physician nodded, while Shadow Weaver silently got off the car and offered her a helping hand. —I hope it wasn't much trouble— she apologetically said from outside.

—Of course not. I can take the patrol car sometimes— Adora smirked. —Have a good day, and… good luck.

—Thank you. And please rest— Castaspella replied.

Right after, Adora slowly drove off, looking through the mirror to make sure the women had entered the house, and only then picked up some speed.

—Oh, I *really* need to rest— she finally sighed. —I hope there will be good news when I wake up.

—I hope so too— Catra admitted. She wasn't sure about sharing her concerns with her, but… she's her fiancée after all. —I, uh… wanted to ask… will you be alright?

—About what?

—All of this. I mean… you just ordered the arrest of our best friend's parents.

—I think Glimmer will understand. I'm just doing my job, and she's aware of what they've done. I'm sure she'll be relieved to know her parents will at least have a fair trial and won't get killed by vampires seeking revenge, don't you think?

—That's a good point— Catra had to admit. —And I guess she wouldn't want them out killing more of us either— she then thought.

—Exactly. At least they will be safe. And so will you.

—What will happen with Bow?

—I'm sure he can get a deal too if he agrees to testify against the regents like Shadow Weaver will.

—Ugh… I certainly hope he will— Catra huffed, brushing her hands down her face. —I wouldn't want him to… you know…

—He wouldn't betray us. I-I mean… you heard him? He said King Micah had convinced him it's what he had to do if he wanted to marry Glimmer!

—What if he…

—I know what you're thinking— Adora interrupted. —But I don't think he will be able to threaten Bow in any way, much less simply convince him.

—I… hope so.

—Trust him, Catra— she smiled, reaching for her hand.

After arriving home, they both went to take a bath before having a well-deserved nap, even if it was around seven in the morning.

Catra fell asleep pretty quickly, but her dreams, or rather nightmares, were filled with screams, blood, and eerie shadows.

However, she didn't wake up suddenly, startled. Instead, she slowly returned to reality as she opened her eyes, groggy.

—Dor?— she called, turning around to find herself alone in bed. —Dor?— she repeated, now louder.

—I'm cooking!— Adora replied, presumably from the kitchen. —I'll be there soon! Don't worry!

Ah… Yeah, she could eat something right now.

Catra rested back on the bed again, looking at the roof, and suddenly remembered the horrors of her dreams.

She never liked admitting it, but she was scared.

Very scared.

It had been a while since she last had nightmares with that torture she witnessed… But now it was *worse*.

She was the one being tortured.

No, not just her…

Adora too.

And Glimmer…

If she kept thinking about it, she'd probably come to the realization that everyone she knows and cares about was being tortured in those nightmares.

She could hear the screams of them all.

But the hunters… They would soon be behind bars. She *knew it*.

She hoped so…

—Ugh…— she finally groaned, sitting up. And right that moment, Adora showed up with a tray.
—Oh, that… smells so good.

—I'm glad. It's kind of a late lunch, I guess? But a bit of a breakfast too?

—It's a meal— Catra chuckled.

—Alright. Let's dig in— she laughed too, sitting on the bed. —I hope you like it.

—Of course, Dor— the vampire smiled.

Sliced fruit, toasts, scrambled eggs, coffee, cheese, jam, and bread for sandwiches… Even some rice with lentils.

Definitely a late brunch.

After eating in silence for a few minutes, Catra caught Adora gazing a few times at her and raised a questioning brow.

—Um… did you sleep well?

—Why'd you ask?

—You moved around a lot… I think you were having nightmares— she explained.

—Yeah, kinda— Catra admitted. —I don't really wanna talk about it, if I'm honest.

—It's alright. You don't have to— Adora reminded her. —Just… remember I'm here if you need anything.

—Of course.

—So, I was thinking…— she then changed subjects. —I'm kinda restless having no work to do, but I probably should chill with you while I can, so… do you want to do anything special together?

—Oh, uh, like what?

—I don't know… We could maybe go to the movies. We haven't in a while— she proposed.

The calm before the storm.

Adora was right. They should enjoy it.

—Yeah, of course— she smiled. —I'm sure we can catch a good one this afternoon.

Her fiancée only smiled in response and kept eating her breakfast.

The calm before the storm…

Catra could hide her unease as much as she wanted, yet she was so troubled inside she knew she wouldn't be able to enjoy the movie.

But it couldn't hurt. And it would certainly help Adora unwind too.

So she would definitely make the most of their afternoon, before they both had to jump into the fire the next day.

Shadow Weaver

The old vampire found herself deep in thought.

She made it seem as if there was nothing wrong, as if she didn't care… Much like she tried after… the torture.

But she was far from that calm and collected façade.

Fortunately, the only one who'd be able to notice was drifting in and out of sleep on her shoulder.

This meant she could go through her thoughts in peace, without being questioned about "what's wrong" before knowing the answer herself.

So *much* was wrong! And she couldn't put it into words…

Her current condition… well, house arrest wasn't that bad, at least she'd retain some comfort albeit it meant her home would turn into a prison, and a golden cage is still a cage…

It felt so frustrating, however, because she *knew* she should be thankful about it, but she couldn't help focusing on the negative things.

She'd lose her job, her whole career- *both* her careers would simply crumble, her reputation would turn to ashes… And of course, she'd no longer be able to sustain her home.

And leaving everything to Castaspella felt wrong.

She couldn't make her *pay* for her place, things, food… However, without a job, Shadow Weaver knew her savings would soon deplete.

Her only "job" would be whatever tasks Hordak assigned her, and that's not exactly remunerated; she didn't even know what she could *possibly* do for him being locked up at home…

She remained deep within her thoughts until a voice forced her back.

How annoying… Shadow Weaver couldn't understand why Castaspella was so fond of that girl.

—Hey… There is something I just… realized and you two should probably discuss that as soon as possible— Catra hesitantly said, probably noticing the physician was awake again.

—What is it?— she briskly replied.

—You can't be Head Physician anymore. And as your successor would be Micah… the position will be vacant still— she pointed out. As if the old vampire wasn't already aware… In any case, she didn't say anything and let her continue —In a few hours the news about your deal and the regents' arrest will be out. So you should probably get ready for that.

Oh, great… Keep stating the obvious…

—Then who could be… Head Physician?— Castaspella asked, interrupted by a yawn.

Alright… Maybe not obvious enough? Whatever, she was sleeping anyways, probably hardly thought about work since learning she had turned herself in and all…

—How do you normally chose the candidates for the position?— Catra asked, seemingly confused.

—Merit. Knowledge. Years of work…— Shadow Weaver enumerated.

—Well, uh… better think about putting together a list.

Not really, but well…

—Alright. Thanks for the reminder— Castaspella weakly smiled.

She *really* liked that girl, didn't she?

The old vampire had no time to say anything as they slowed down and Adora asked —We're here, right?

—Yup…— Catra nodded, reminding Shadow Weaver that *many* people know where she lives.

Yes, home.

Her new prison.

Hopefully she wouldn't grow to hate it…

She silently got off the car and then offered Castaspella a helping hand while she cordially thanked Adora.

—I hope it wasn't much trouble— she apologetically added, once outside.

—Of course not. I can take the patrol car sometimes— Adora smirked. —Have a good day, and… good luck.

—Thank you. And please rest— Castaspella replied.

Always so nice…

Shadow Weaver didn't say anything, even though she should have probably thanked them for the ride or something.

But it didn't matter to her.

She simply turned and headed for the door, knowing she had to be inside as soon as possible.

—I need a drink— she sighed, as soon as she unlocked the door.

—Bea…— Castaspella called behind her, but she didn't turn. This wasn't a great moment. —Beatrix.

Full name? That's not good…

—What?— she spat, looking back with obvious annoyance.

—Are you seriously just going to get drunk right now?

—I just need *a* drink. Not planning on blacking out.

—I- Alright. One drink. But we need to talk in the meantime.

Oh, she *knew it*.

—That's why I need a drink— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—Can you stop being a bitch at least!? I-I know you're not in the best mood or anything, but…

—Casta. I know you need support right now, but *you know* I suck at being supportive. I can hear you out, but I'll certainly fail at making you feel better.

—What about making me feel *loved*?— she immediately shot back, expression sorrowful.

She simply could *not* bear that expression.

Shadow Weaver couldn't help letting out a soft sigh and a smile.

—That I hopefully can do, yes— she nodded. —But I still want that drink, and you should have one yourself too, so let's go to the kitchen… and we'll talk.

As she continued on her way, she could hear Castaspella take a deep breath and sigh. She was probably worse than she could imagine.

Little after, both were laying against the counter, each with their glass; Shadow Weaver had a cup of some deep red wine, while her partner held a shot of sake, seemingly hesitant to drink it.

—I'm sorry if I made you feel guilty— the physician suddenly let out. —I didn't mean to. I would like some support, yes, but I understand if you need your time too…

—You didn't make me feel guilty, alright? What's more, right now is *the* moment for you to be selfish, to think about yourself— she assured her. Castaspella looked back in confusion so she added —You care too much about everything; if you keep that up, you will *explode*. Not literally, of course, but you might wear yourself out and faint, for instance.

The young woman lowered her head, pensive for a moment.

—I just… I know my only brother will hate me, I don't know how my niece will treat me from now on, and I'm- I am not- I hardly understand who I am!— the physician expressed, seemingly about to cry. Shadow Weaver looked away, kept silent, and slowly put down her cup. She understood what she meant. —If at least I'm reminded that you love me, that *someone* still loves me, then maybe it won't matter who I am. But what if…

—No "what if"— the old vampire interrupted, approaching to embrace her. —Of course I still love you. I've already given up on resisting it, Casta. I *know* I can be the worst sometimes, but never, not for one second, doubt that I love you— she firmly told her, tilting Castaspella's face to look into her eyes.

—Thank you— she sobbed, resting her head under Shadow Weaver's chin.

The old vampire hesitated a moment but finally kissed the top of her head and released her to let her drink the shot.

She'd need it.

Chapter End Notes

:D

See you next week!!!!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

:D Guess what begins today!?
Yes! The trials!! Wooohh!!

I'm so excited! >v<

You'll meet the defense attourney, you'll get the first glimpse at Etheria's law system… and well, this is just the beginning… there's more to come <("^_^)

Anyways!! I hope you enjoy the chapter!! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

Catra clutched her head with both hands.

This shit was worse than she could have imagined, and she was having a panic attack, gasping for air.

Everything was so… so *overwhelming*!

She had locked herself up in the closest bathroom.

It was supposed to be just another day at the court but… everyone had so many questions! Since *when* is she the Court's representative, huh!?

Ugh, she had to calm down.

Calm… down.

At the beginning of the week, Adora's people had arrested the Queen and the King, while they both took Shadow Weaver back home. They had their last day of peace, and then… the process began.

These were the moments when she was thankful to know the laws of Etheria so well.

But even so, she felt pretty unprepared.

The whole fucking kingdom was in panic since the regents' arrest. Adora made a great job of keeping the public controlled, but Catra could hear it when asked what happened, how things would proceed from now on, or when people echoed the police's commands to keep calm: everyone was in a panic, unsure, and most certainly needed a resolution *now*.

The problem she had was the fact that the “public opinion” called for the regents’ immediate restoration to power.

No one wanted to see the trial.

No one wanted it to even begin.

Catra had tried to explain the charges to several reporters, but… it was getting frustrating.

People simply didn’t understand!

And she couldn’t hide in the bathroom forever…

Taking another deep breath, Catra brushed her hair back and prepared to step outside and face the reporters again.

Shadow Weaver’s trial, which everyone knew to be a mere formality, had just finished. It was quick and private, the criminal case documents about it were sealed as per Hordak’s orders, and no reporters were allowed to get information, arguing it was to protect a cooperating witness for the upcoming trial.

And yet, that was revealing enough for the media to cause an uproar.

The problem Catra had was that she kept being overwhelmed by the speculations about why the Head Physician of Mystacor not only would be a protected witness for the regents’ trial, but also had been tried as a criminal.

She was in charge of shutting down the rumours, and answering for the Court, *on top of* protecting Castaspella!

She had tried to speak to Hordak but he argued no one else was fit for the job like her.

Fantastic.

So now, once again, she was in the middle of a crowd of reporters, trying to answer questions without getting hit by the microphones being shoved in front of her.

—I’ll repeat it once again: no information can be disclosed about the closed trial or the upcoming one!— she exclaimed, loud and clear. She was aware her statements were being broadcast on several radio stations, so she had to measure her words. —The Court will keep the documents of the closed hearing sealed, but you’ll be able to attend the regents’ trial next week.

—So that one *will* be public?

—Yes, of course.

—Why are the Queen and King retained!?

—That has already been answered— she reminded the reporter. —It is considered there’s risk of them fleeing. There is also proof that they could be dangerous.

—Dangerous how!?

—That cannot be disclosed before the trial— Catra insisted. —Now, please, everyone, clear the area and leave. I'm not taking further questions.

All reporters began complaining at the same time, but as soon as she nodded at the security guards standing nearby, they all complied.

She could breathe easy now.

—Are you alright?— a voice suddenly asked, startling her enough to make her jump back.

—Oh, damn. Sorry, yes, I'm fine— Catra nodded, apologizing to Castaspella for the reaction. —You haven't left?

—I reckoned it'd be easier for you if I waited, so you wouldn't have to track me down— she chuckled.

—Thanks— she smiled, touched by the gesture. —Has Shadow Weaver been escorted back already?

—Yes, yes. I… didn't like leaving her alone, but I have to go to Mystacor anyways, so…

—Oh, of course. Let's get going, then.

As they walked into the medical institution, Castaspella let out a deep sigh.

—It's still so strange being here without my brother or Bea…

—I was gonna ask how you're adjusting— Catra admitted.

—I'd like to say "well", but not much is going smoothly— she denied.

—Well, yeah, that little surprise may have upset a few— Catra recalled. —Why did Shadow Weaver keep it from you?

—That she made preparations for me to be Head Physician? Or that it would be so much damned work? Because I have no answer for either…

—I meant the first one, but, uh, yeah…— she sighed. —It's kinda fucked up.

—It is, mostly because everyone thinks I *don't* deserve this position— Castaspella lamented.

—I think you do— Catra shrugged. —Following you around all day for months has kinda given me some idea of how this place works and all… You already handled so much; you were practically running the place.

—Save for the paperwork— the physician scoffed. —Thanks for the vote of confidence.

—Of course.

—Tell me something: Do you think it will be possible to ever get some special permissions to let Bea- Shadow Weaver operate if we ever had a complicated patient?— Castaspella then asked. —The only ones with enough level of skill are her and my brother, after all… I *can* keep training and studying, but in practice I've never been that skilled.

—I… suppose after the trials are done, if it were that urgent, yeah, it can probably be petitioned formally to escort her to Mystacor, let her operate, and then return— Catra confirmed.

—That's a relief.

—But let's hope it's not necessary until the trials finish— she added. —The Judge and the Prosecutor probably should have considered that in the original deal.

—I suppose it didn't occur to any of them— the physician sighed. —And speaking of the trials, how long do you think it will take?

—A while. Months, hopefully not many— she supposed. —With Shadow Weaver's testimony it may be quicker than usual, but I can't make any promises.

—It's alright, don't worry. I suppose I'm just a bit restless— Castaspella admitted.

—We all are— Catra nodded. —It'd be strange if you weren't, actually.

Right then, they arrived at the Head Physician's office and she considered for a moment what to do.

—You can come in and chill if you want. I have several files to process and should get it done before lunch.

—Oh, uh, sure! Thanks.

Hours later, as Catra accompanied Castaspella back home, they couldn't help discussing a rather sensitive matter.

—I've been meaning to ask… Have either you or Adora spoken to my niece?

—Not really; we haven't heard from either her or Bow— she denied, sorrowful. —And I take it you haven't either…

—Not a word— Castaspella sighed. —I can't blame her, of course, but… unless Bow makes a deal too, he might go down with the rest of the Hunters Alliance.

—He hasn't even been seen since the regents and some of their generals got arrested after Shadow Weaver named them— Catra explained. —I want to trust he'll make the right choice, like he did back then.

—I hope so— the physician smiled.

—Alright, we're here— the vampire said, halting in front of the front door. —As usual, Rogelio will be patrolling around, so if anything happens, don't hesitate to call for help.

—Thank you. Good night— Castaspella farewelled, and headed inside.

Alright, that was all for the day.

She looked up, observed the beautiful sky for a moment, shades of orange and red slowly turning dark, and lowered her hood, now safe from the sunlight.

Time to get going.

The day of the first trial was hectic for everyone.

Adora and her team were in charge of security and escorting the accused and witnesses, Catra still had to handle the reporters, and the rest of her co-workers had twice as much work as usual.

Soon, the trial room was filled with reporters, some audience, and those involved in the case.

It was the first time since the arrest of her parents that Glimmer left the castle and appeared in public.

Bow, however, was nowhere to be seen.

Neither was Shadow Weaver, who was probably on her way there.

Castaspella, on the other hand, was already sitting there behind the prosecutor's side, speaking to Netossa.

Catra observed from a distance but could hear them clearly.

—I'll call you second or third, likely near the end of today's hearing. If not, you'll be the first one for the next session— the prosecutor explained.

—Of course, I understand.

—We'll do as we practiced. I'll ask you a series of questions and you just answer truthfully. Then the defense attourney will have a chance to question you as well, and will likely attack you and try to discredit you— Netossa warned her. —Remember to keep calm and stick to the truth. That's all we need.

—I know you said I won't get in trouble for the… stalking, but I'm still unsure about that.

—Don't lie about it; if you do and the defense manages to make you admit it later, *then* you'll be in trouble.

—A-alright— Castaspella finally nodded, notoriously nervous.

Right after, as if on cue, the doors opened and the regents walked in, escorted by several of Adora's officers.

Both looked proud, chin up, avoiding eye-contact with absolutely everyone.

Catra instinctively looked at Glimmer and her darkened expression made her chest hurt. She wanted nothing more than to comfort her, but she had to remain in place.

On the other hand, Castaspella's expression revealed tumultuous feelings; there was a hint of rage, but also deep sorrow.

Finally, mere minutes later, Judge Hordak entered the courtroom.

—Order on Court— Catra called, announcing his arrival. —The court's in session— she then declared, as soon as he sat down.

—Is everyone in attendance?— he first asked.

—Some of my witnesses are still on their way, but we may commence with introductions— Netossa replied, standing for a moment.

—Your Honor, if said witnesses don't arrive in time, I request for the case be dismissed— the defense attourney said, standing up too.

—They will arrive shortly— the prosecutor immediately confirmed, side-eyeing her opposite.

—We shall begin introductions, but if the witnesses fail to arrive in time, the motion of the defense will be granted.

—Thank you, Your Honor.

—Then allow me to begin by clarifying something: Are the defendants aware of their attourney's relationship with the prosecutor?

—We are aware— Angella replied, standing up, without consulting her lawyer. —However, we trust that they are professional enough to separate their private life from their jobs— she concluded, and sat down again.

—In that case, Counsellor Spinnerella will be allowed to represent you.

Oh, right… Catra had forgotten for a brief moment that they were *married*.

But she knew exactly why the regents "didn't mind" and still wanted her: She's the best defense attourney in the kingdom.

With that settled, introductions began and proceeded according to protocol, fortunately taking long enough for Shadow Weaver to arrive in time.

What a relief…

Adora would probably have a word with the officers escorting her.

Murmurs rose among the public and Judge Hordak had to call for order in the courtroom.

—The prosecutor's office now calls our first witness: Beatrix, also known as Shadow Weaver— Netossa declared.

Catra took a deep breath as she observed the old vampire walk towards the witness stand, and prepared to begin.

She approached, stood next to the stand, and calmly asked —Do you swear to speak only the truth, under the penalty of perjury, respecting the laws of Etheria's Court?

—I swear.

Perfect.

With that, Catra returned to her place and Netossa moved forward.

Now the questioning could begin.

—For the record, state your name, occupation, and how you know the parties in the case— the prosecutor ordered, as soon as she sat down.

—My name is Beatrix, although most know me as Shadow Weaver, former Head Physician of Mystacor's Health Institution— she began. After a pause, she smirked almost imperceptibly before adding —I know the regents because Micah was my pupil, and Angella, my superior in the Alliance of Vampire Hunters.

Shadow Weaver

Her trial went smoothly.

It was just a formality, she knew it, but it still took a few days to be done with and it annoyed her.

But *nothing* could be as annoying as the reporters waiting outside the trial room.

The Court shouldn't let them in, she considered, but apparently they did…

—Alright, time to go back— Shadow Weaver sighed.

—I won't go— Castaspella replied. —I mean, I should go to Mystacor and get some work done; there's a lot to process, and I'd already be clocking in late.

—The Head Physician has no fixed schedule— she reminded her.

—Don't get me started— her partner warned her. —Just… Go. I'll see you later.

—Of course— Shadow Weaver accepted.

With a quick kiss, they farewelled and a police officer from Chief Adora's crew escorted her back home.

It was time to find *something* to do before she died of boredom.

The old vampire heard the radio for a while, read a book or two, even considered borrowing Castaspella's knitting stuff to try it… All before lunchtime.

Who would have thought having so much free time would be this annoying?

As she laid on the couch, looking at the ceiling and almost falling asleep, a knock on the door called her attention.

No, not the door. The damned window.

—Hi-hi— a shy blonde boy stammered when she opened. Well, not a boy, just a young man that spoke a lot like a boy. —So-sorry for the, uh, the weird approach.

—What the heck are you doing here?

—Judge Hordak se-sent me— he explained. —I have a-an assignment for you. Bu-but I shouldn't be, uh, seen.

—So that's why you didn't come through the front door.

—Yeah— he admitted, rubbing the back of his neck. —He-here's the file with all the information — he then recalled.

As she received the large envelope, she asked —What's your name, Kid?

—I-I'm Kyle. I handle these deliveries.

—Vampire?

—No-no.

—Then better get going before someone sees you— she pointed out.

—Ye-yes!— he nodded. —Oh, but, I-I have to return for it tonight if possible.

—I'll see what this is and try to get it done— she accepted, rolling her eyes.

—Thank you— he smiled. —I'll go now.

Well, it wasn't that bad…

When Shadow Weaver finally checked what she had been assigned, it turned out to be pretty much within her capabilities, and a good way to keep her busy.

Hordak had sent a few reports on some blood slaves that weren't feeling well and potential new ones, with their corresponding blood-exams' reports and all.

That people… Much as they want to gain some powers in exchange for their blood, it sometimes could have undesired side effects or become a problem if the individual didn't take good care of their health, after all.

So this was both familiar and entertaining for her.

She got to continue her work, just… unofficially.

And fortunately for the poor Kyle, she did have it all ready by the time he returned.

He was one of the individuals in the report, one becoming a blood slave for the first time.

—Listen, Kid— she began, before letting him go. —What you want to do may not be worth it. The promise of power is enticing, but you're a bit small to be giving out your blood— she pointed out.

—I-I don't want to do it for the powers— he clarified. —It's for my friends— he shyly admitted. —I was supposed to be turned too, but chickened out, so I want to do this, at least.

—I see…— she sighed. —It's quite noble, but you should still prioritize your health.

—I know…

—Now, go, Hordak is probably waiting for that.

—Yeah! I- yes. Uh, thank you for the advice— he smiled, and finally run away under the cover of the night.

It wasn't long before Castaspella finally returned from work, and Shadow Weaver realized just how relieved she was to see her again.

That was… new.

—Welcome back— she smirked. —Productive day?

—Kind of, yes— she sighed.

—What's wrong?

As they approached each other, finally meeting in the middle of the lounge, Castaspella explained —I'm just- I asked Catra about Glimmer… She and Adora haven't seen her since the arrest, she hasn't left the palace… I'm worried.

—Have you ever visited her personally like I suggested?

—No… I'm sure she'd refuse to see me, and I don't think I can bear the pain— she admitted, looking away.

—While I think you're probably wrong, and that there's a chance she would accept your visit, I suppose giving her time to process everything isn't a bad idea either.

—You're right… Yeah. I'm sure she'll show up next week at the first hearing— the physician nodded. —Or as soon as she's ready, of course.

—That's better— she smirked. —Now we should prepare dinner.

—Of course— her partner smiled. —Why don't you tell me what you did today?

—Well, today I received and completed my first task for the Horde.

—Really!? What did Hordak assign you?

—Just an evaluation of some blood slaves, and potential candidates. I wrote my conclusions based on the reports I got for each of them— she explained. —Felt pretty much like being back at work.

—You sound quite happy with that— Castaspella chuckled.

—Oddly enough, I suppose I am— she admitted, feeling strange inside.

—I'm glad, my Love.

The day of the first trial arrived soon.

The women woke up early, had a quick breakfast, and after kissing her goodbye, the physician left for the Court.

Shadow Weaver was left to wait for the police officers that had to escort her… and they took quite some time.

The damned cops… They'd be *late* if they delayed any longer!

As soon as she heard knocking on the door, she rushed to receive them in the worst mood.

—Are you insane!? We should have been early, not *late*!

—We-we know, apologies, bu-but the patrol car broke do-down and…

—Save it— she spat, interrupting the stammering officer. —Let's get going. We can call a cab if needed.

—Yes, yes! We should do that— the other officer nodded.

—You came *on foot*?

—Yes…— they both admitted, looking down.

—Pathetic.

Fortunately, they didn't lose any more time and headed for the Court as fast as possible, albeit having to pay a little extra to the driver…

But it seemed like they were just in time.

She could see it in the defense attourney's face.

Oh, wait, she knew that face… The *wife* of the prosecutor.

This would be quite interesting…

Shadow Weaver continued forward as Netossa called her to declare, ignoring the murmurs sparked by her arrival, and focused on following the procedures as practiced. Honest answers, timely reveals… Basically using her skills with words for a good cause this time.

—Order!— Judge Hordak called, trying to quiet the reporters that kept muttering among themselves.

They both could hear their every word and it was *so* annoying.

Focus now.

It was time.

Before she sat on the stand, Catra approached solemnly and asked —Do you swear to speak only the truth, under the penalty of perjury, respecting the laws of Etheria's Court?

—I swear.

For once, she meant it.

It was time for Netossa now to lead the show.

—For the record, state your name, occupation, and how you know the parties in the case— the prosecutor ordered, as soon as she sat down.

—My name is Beatrix, although most know me as Shadow Weaver, former Head Physician of Mystacor's Health Institution— she began, feigning innocence. After a purposeful pause, she tried to hold back a smirk as she added —I know the regents because Micah was my pupil, and Angella, my superior in the Alliance of Vampire Hunters.

Uproar.

Just as expected.

—Order! *Order*!

—Vampires!?

—They can't be real… right?

—There is no way…

—I knew it, I wasn't *crazy*!

—Order!— Hordak insisted, briefly glancing at Shadow Weaver.

That was a warning.

—Let it be clear that the prosecution's office is, in fact, accusing the regents of running an illegal organization of hunters under the cover of the supposed Princess Alliance— Netossa declared, voice loud and firm. —May I remind you the witness was *not* present when it the criminal charges were read.

—It has been acknowledged— the Judge accepted. —Please continue the questioning.

—Of course— Netossa nodded. —Can you describe the activities you were ordered to carry out under Angella's orders?

—Since becoming a high-ranking hunter, most of my activities included tracking down vampires, eliminating them, no questions asked, and filling out the pertinent reports.

—Yes, the reports— the prosecutor nodded. —Your Honor, you will find among the evidence provided a large collection of the reports found in the forbidden, or should I say *secret* section of the library— she declared. —Now, how exactly would you judge whether someone should be "eliminated"?— she went on, facing Shadow Weaver.

—There was hardly any fixed criteria. If there was any suspicion someone could be a vampire, it was cause enough to follow and kill, at the hunter's discretion— she replied, a bit too aloof for… everyone's comfort, she could notice.

—Just like that!?— a reporter murmured.

—That's unfair. What if they were wrong?

—Supposing vampires are real to begin with!— another whispered.

Shadow Weaver could hear their every word but had to bite her tongue not to comment.

Fortunately, Netossa's next question was —Was there no proper judging system?

—Not at all. And even if they weren't killed on the spot, the only other possibility would be to take them back to the library for "especial interrogation"?

—Can you clarify what that means?

—Torture.

Collective gasps raised once more.

—Order! Order!

—We did not…— Angella began complaining, but Spinnerella promptly stopped her.

—Objection, your Honor.

—What are you objecting, attourney? There are charges for torture among the many your clients are facing.

—Well, there's a reason we plead innocence, your Honor. I apologize for my client's outburst but it should be clear evidence of it.

—You'll have time to cross-examine the witness and discredit her, but unless there's something else, I have no reason to grant your objection— Hordak insisted.

—Then I'll take it back until I can properly question the witness— Spinnerella accepted, sitting down again.

—Proceed, Prosecutor.

—Thank you, your Honor— she nodded. —Would you please explain what you meant when you said Micah was your pupil?

—It means I taught him everything he knows, both as physician… and as hunter.

—Was he under your orders?

—No— she denied. —Hunters are recruited personally by Angella… or by Micah, since some years after he joined. I was introduced to the Alliance only a year or so before Micah met Angella, and he joined even before they married— Shadow Weaver explained. —Since he was already my pupil at Mystacor's Health Institution, it was only logical to take him under my tutelage in the Alliance too; I didn't want him to get killed.

—Alright, then, one more question: When exactly did you change your mind about being a hunter?

Her lips twitched. She wanted to smirk but held back.

—Recently— she began. —After properly meeting Castaspella, Micah's sister, I eventually got involved; she had been aware for a while of my activities as a hunter, also of her brother's, and while she wanted us to be safe, she never approved of the hunting itself. I won't pretend to have any morals above those of the regents. It was her, and only her, who convinced me to change my mind, shift my thinking. She's the reason why I am now here, testifying— she admitted, making of point of ignoring Micah's look of betrayal.

—She convinced you to turn your back on the Alliance?

—She convinced me to make the right *choice*. And this is the only way to keep her safe— Shadow Weaver added.

—Safe how? From whom?

—From the menace of the hunters— she scoffed. —I cannot trust Micah won't hurt her if he so much as *suspects* of her. Just like he has done with many over the past few decades… there would be no mercy— she declared, now looking at him dead in the eyes.

—Thank you. No further questions— Netossa said, walking back to her spot.

—Your witness, Counsellor— Hordak told Spinnerella, who promptly stood up to approach the stand.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that's all for today

I hope you read that "pathetic" with the appropriate tone XD

Sorry, I'm so silly sometimes >v<

AHEM! So!! As I said before, this is just the beginning! There will be more chapters about this trial, and then… well, second plot-point will take over XD

So, I hope you enjoyed the chapter, thank you so much for reading, and see you next week!!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

Welcome back!!
Today I bring you: more of the actual trial! Testimonies! And a bit of an angsty moment, courtesy of Bow! <("^_^)

I don't think I have anything else to say, so… I hope you enjoy this chapter!!! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

Catra knew this trial would be insane, but… it was somehow way over her expectations.

Shadow Weaver describing the hunters activities with such aloofness made her sick, which was far from surprising.

However, it was part of their strategy. Declaring the facts in such manner made for a raw testimony that would emphasize the most abhorrent aspects of the secret Alliance.

And, of course, the old vampire had yet to reveal the most shocking facts. The torture *she* suffered. Being a vampire herself… It made Catra wonder what the Prosecutor's full strategy was…

But it was now time for the defense attourney to question Shadow Weaver.

—Let me begin with a simple yes or no question: Did you or did you *not* accept a deal with the Court to declare against my clients?

—I did.

—And what is your end of the deal? I mean, besides declaring as witness, of course.

—I pleaded guilty of double-murder charges in self-defense— the old vampire admitted, without hesitation or shame.

Indignant gasps from the public immediately filled the room.

Obviously.

Fortunately, they were all so curious, it seemed, that they shut up without Judge Hordak calling to order.

—Sounds convenient for you. Convenient enough to *lie*— Spinnerella pressed.

—If I were to lie, it'd be to cover my own crimes, which I'm fully disclosing right now— Shadow Weaver scoffed. —But I would rather keep incriminating myself than let them walk away free; I'm not lying because I don't need to, I don't want to, not because I swore not to.

—Have you ever lied for them?

—Lying is the most innocent thing I've done for them— she smirked.

Oh, shit…

—Please elaborate— the defense attourney requested.

—Hunting and killing alleged vampires was basically the whole deal of the secret Alliance Angella led. But since we're being honest, one of *my* specific duties was to handle anyone who discovered us.

—How exactly?

—Wiping their memory— she smirked again. —It may not constitute a crime according to our laws, but it is technically forbidden sorcery— she added, a bit cocky.

That woman is insane.

—Hunting, killing, using forbidden magic… It hardly makes any sense that you would suddenly turn against them— Spinnerella remarked.

—Is there a question, Counsellor?— Hordak inquired, raising a brow.

—Yes: you said you are doing this to protect your partner, sister of one of my clients, and called her brother a "threat". Why?

—It's a fact.

—How can you be so sure?

—Vampire hunters are the opposite of this Court, serving so-called "justice" without proper evidence or right to defend yourself. All hunters, including myself, are a *threat*.

—But you're free.

—No, I have an anklet for a reason, I'm under constant vigilance and can't leave my home without police escort; not for *my* safety but for that of others.

—I see… but let's go back a bit. Specifically, you said there would be no mercy if they so much as suspected Castaspella to be a vampire, ignoring they are family. What evidence is there to support your claims?

Using her own words against her would normally work like a charm for the defense.

But in this case, Catra couldn't help mirroring Shadow Weaver's smirk as Spinnerella fell right into their trap.

—Your clients do not remember this because I wiped their memories, but…— she began, pausing for a moment. —A bit over a month ago, Angella issued two capture orders, under suspicion of vampirism. One of them against me— she began, raising her head. Catra glanced at the regents and saw absolute confusion, not a hint of realization. They really couldn't recall a thing. Good… —Micah, my own pupil, not only captured me in front of his sister, dismissing her pleas to stop and letting his fellow hunters physically assault her, but also had no qualms about torturing me— she finally revealed.

—That can't be!— Micah immediately exclaimed, standing up.

—Order!— Hordak pronounced once. —Control your client, Counsellor.

—Of course— she nodded, giving him a look that made him sit down again. —Let me see if I understand: you claim that my client would mercilessly hurt his own sister if he suspected her, because that's what he did to you?

—Correct.

—However you wiped their memories. Did you also get rid of any hard evidence that they had issued the capture order you mentioned?

—Yes. We took from them the reports that led to the presumption of vampirism, hence, the capture orders— she nodded.

—I request a motion to dismiss the witness' testimony since there is no evidence to back up such claims— Spinnerella promptly said.

—Prosecutor, if this is true, I will have to grant the motion— the Judge told Netossa.

—Excuse me, your Honor, but the witness may have forgotten I *told her* of the evidence submitted by the police— she clarified, standing up. Catra briefly glanced at Shadow Weaver in time to see her face-palm. So she really forgot? Incredible… —I believe the defense hasn't properly reviewed the evidence either, or forgot too, since there are, in fact, folders with the aforementioned reports, as well as a detailed assessment of the witness' wounds from the torture she went through— Netossa pointed out, raising a page from the long list of evidence submitted.

—Lawyers, approach— Hordak ordered.

Oh, damn, this would be interesting.

Despite whispering, Catra could perfectly hear the discussion.

—Your Honor, the evidence referred to by the prosecutor should be inadmissible— Spinnerella argued.

—Why?

—The report on the wounds was written by the witness' partner, and the folders that even *she* didn't know still existed, were *also* provided by her partner. I must doubt of its validity since the reports may have been tampered with, if not entirely made up, as well as the assessment!

—Excuse me, *Counsellor*, but all this evidence has been reviewed by expert forensics who determined they have not been tampered with: the handwriting is unmistakably Angella's and Micah's— Netossa interrupted. —As for the assessment, Castaspella is a competent physician, and her written report is accompanied by photographic evidence— she then added.

Oh, so the physician kept the folders and even took pictures of the wounds!?

She had to give it to her: Castaspella could be dangerously smart.

—But…— Spinnerella tried to argue, yet interrupted herself, probably realizing she'd get nowhere fighting this.

However, Netossa still added —Plus we have an eye witness of the torture.

Ah, shit. That's why she asked her to testify if necessary.

—Alright, I take back the motion— the defense attourney sighed, notoriously bitter.

—Return to your places then— the Judge ordered. —You can finish your questioning, Counsellor.

—I'll ask one more question, then— Spinnerella decided. —Shadow Weaver: Why were you part of this secret Alliance of vampire hunters?

—My Master back then, the Head Physician before me, invited me to speak with Angella; she convinced me there was a real, very dire threat assailing Etheria. And I believed her— she replied, expression darkening. —Her words were convincing enough that even after I- Even after learning there was no such threat, I still considered it safer for me to remain with the hunters.

—So you admit my client may have legitimate reasons for her actions?

—I know she *thinks* so— Shadow Weaver clarified.

—I see. No further questions.

Shadow Weaver

She knew she wouldn't exactly enjoy the trial, of course, but she didn't expect it to be so, *so* slow!

By the time the defense attourney finished her questioning and Shadow Weaver could finally go sit next to her partner, she felt exhausted. And she knew it hadn't even been two hours…

—You did well— Castaspella muttered, before briefly kissing her cheek.

—If you say so… I did forget that the Prosecutor told me of the evidence you submitted. Why didn't *you* tell me you kept the reports?

—I knew we'd need them but you'll be mad that I didn't really get rid of them. So… have some trust in the process.

The old vampire only nodded, keeping her eyes on the front.

—I would like to call my second witness now, Bow— Netossa sentenced.

Castaspella immediately looked back and she followed her sight towards Glimmer, sitting on the other side of the room, close to the doors.

—Is your witness present, Prosecutor?

—He- I-I was told he was.

—Do you have other relevant witnesses if he isn't here?— Hordak asked.

—Yes, I do.

—Then I'm giving you five minutes to get your witness into the stand, or you'll have to call your next one— he decided.

Huh… Did the boy get cold feet?

—If he made a deal like me, he better show up— Shadow Weaver muttered.

As soon as she said that, she saw Glimmer stand up and go for the door, even before Netossa reached it. By the time the Prosecutor arrived at the door, the Princess was back, dragging her fiancé with her.

Oh…

Well, she could be sure Castaspella would want to talk to her niece after this…

—I- Thank you, your Majesty— Netossa stammered, before facing Bow. —Is there a problem?

—N-no.

—Then please go to the witness stand— she requested.

As each went to their respective spot in the room, the old vampire let out a breath she didn't know she was holding.

—Any problems with your witness, Prosecutor?

—Not that I know of, no.

—Anything you need to tell me, young man?— Hordak then asked Bow, in a low tone many probably couldn't hear.

—I… don't know.

—Have you been threatened by anyone?

—Yes, your Honor.

—Lawyers, approach— Judge Hordak called, serious, giving Catra a look to stay in place. As Spinnerella and Netossa reached his desk, he squinted and severely stated, in a low tone, —The

witness is afraid to testify and admits he was threatened. If either of you know anything, now is the time to speak.

—Threats!? But…— the defense attourney began, exchanging a confused glance with her wife.

—He had been previously threatened by Micah. I don't know if they have had contact since the arrest— Netossa admitted.

—No, no. My clients… They haven't- They *couldn't* have…

—Speak to your clients, Counsellor. Reassure this man he can testify with the truth, or I'll have to add more charges to them.

—Of course, Judge, excuse me.

Well, that was interesting…

—I couldn't catch it all, what happened?— Castaspella asked.

—Somehow, your dear brother, or his wife, threatened the boy. Hordak wants the defense attourney to speak to them and reassure him he has nothing to fear for saying the truth.

—Excuse me— a voice called from behind them. —Are you saying our boy was threatened!?

—Oh, these are Bow's fathers— Castaspella explained. —George and Lance.

—Pleased to meet you. Bow is quite talented.

—Oh, he's always been good with handicrafts and such… But do you know why he was called to testify?— George asked.

—How long has it been since he left his job at the academy with you?— the physician asked back.

—Some months? Half a year?

—He was invited by Micah to join the secret Alliance, to become a *hunter*. He graduated something around two months ago.

—Our Bow!? A vampire hunter!? There's no way!— Lance exclaimed, but keeping his voice down. —He wouldn't hurt a fly!

—Your Honor— Spinnerella began, that same moment, interrupting their conversation. —My clients would like to make it clear that they are in no way threatening or intimidating the witness. They will not take any action, and are sure there would be no reasons for it, either— she said.

—Are you ready now, young man?— Hordak asked him.

—There's security here, right?

—Yes.

—Alright. I'll speak.

Noticiably relieved, Judge Hordak nodded at Catra, who appraoched the stand.

—Do you swear to speak only the truth, under the penalty of perjury, respecting the laws of Etheria's Court?

—I swear.

—Prosecutor, you may begin— the Judge ordered, as Catra returned to her place.

—Alright, Bow. Let's start with something simple: How do you know the parties involved?

—I- Uh, yeah, I know the regents because I'm engaged to their daughter, Princess Glimmer, with whom I've been friends for almost all my life— he began, looking away shyly. —Bu-but they are also- Recently I joined the Alliance of hunters and they are- were my superiors— he then added, stirring murmurs among the public, as expected.

—So you are a hunter.

—*Was*. I never wanted to, but… I had to. And the last month, despite wanting to quit, I stayed to… to try to take the Alliance down from within— he admitted.

Oh, what wouldn't Shadow Weaver give to see Micah's face right now.

—You say you *had to*, what do you mean?

—The Ki- Micah said it was necessary. That if I wanted to marry Glimmer, it was my duty to join the hunters and make the kingdom safe for her…— Bow explained.

—Did he threaten you in any way?— Netossa pressed on.

—I-I don't know. It-it felt like he meant… that they wouldn't allow me to marry Glim if I didn't join them.

—This will be a hard question, Bow, but I need you to answer honestly: Have you killed any alleged vampires?

—I…— he first hesitated. —Almost— he sighed. —The-the night the Butcher Brothers died- were killed, I was leading the party— he confessed, ashamed. —I almost died too, but escaped right in time… I later learnt Castaspella helped me, otherwise I would be missing a leg— he breathlessly chuckled. —And… some time later, I was following someone suspicious one night, then another figure distracted me to let my original target escape, and I almost…— he went on, but interrupted himself. Finally, he looked up at Netossa and admitted —Without even checking for proof of it, I was ready to shot my arrows. But I got hurt before I could, and Chief Adora found me before I had another chance.

—Do you know who those were?

—Not at the time. I learnt later the first one was… Shadow Weaver, since she admitted to having killed the Butcher Brothers; I can confirm it was in self-defense because we attacked first, from the shadows, without a warning— he nervously began, taking deep breaths but looking determined to say it all. —And the second one, whom I was closer to killing, turned out to be… one of my best friends— he concluded, eyes shining with unshed tears.

The old vampire couldn't help the eye-roll… She should have expected him to cry, though.

—Thank you, Bow. One final question: Why did you join Shadow Weaver in testifying against the Alliance? Why did you decide to boycott them?

—Because, if they could send me to kill one of our own without clear proof, only vague suspicions, and then capture and try to kill one of my best friends, someone they had recieved in the palace and invited for a meal… all without hesitation, then what kind of people had I joined? They told me I would be protecting the kingdom, my friends and family… But *we* were the real threat.

—No further questions— Netossa concluded.

—Your witness, Counsellor— Hordak ordered, gesturing at Spinnerella to cross-examine him.

—Thank you, your Honor— she began. —Bow, once again I want to assure you that you can speak freely, without fear. My clients insist they wouldn't hurt you, alright?

—I'd hope so, but… I saw the wounds on Shadow Weaver. If Micah could do that to his own Master, I…

—Did you see him inflict those wounds?

—No— he denied. —But I heard the screams. I had seen him take her down to the holding cells, and when I saw her afterwards, I knew what he had done. And when I saw Catra too, I realized he could have done the same to her— Bow explained, swallowing hard and looking down with a furrowed brow.

Right, she hadn't thought about it, but her screams probably filled the entire forbidden section.

—I see. So, not only had you been sent to kill them before, but also knew they had been captured under the suspicion of vampirism. Would you say those suspicions were actually true?— Spinnerella asked, looking at him with a determined look.

Oh, he better be careful. It's not yet time to reveal it, and Netossa made it clear to them.

—How is that relevant? I didn't even know who I was sent to kill, and those suspicions had no hard proof. There has never been any hard proof of someone being a vampire *before* killing them — Bow argued.

—But, in your opinion…

—Objection— Netossa immediately interrupted. —As the witness expressed, how is this relevant? They aren't the ones on trial, and even if they were, their nature is irrelevant to the charges held against the regents.

—Lawyer…— Hordak began, but Spinnerella quickly backed down.

—Right, I take back the question— she accepted.

—Alright. Please continue, and keep your questions *relevant*.

—Yes, Your Honor. Bow, you've already told us that you haven't killed any vampires since you failed when you had the chance. But is it true that you crafted special devices with the intention of affecting them?— the defense attourney asked, making him go pale.

Oh, so that's how they are doing this…

Merciless, indeed.

—I- We-well… Yeah, but… I-I was told… They said it was just to… to make them reveal themselves— Bow stammered.

—Was that not the case?

—No! The devices made them go feral and… *blind*! They weren't- It made vampires go wild instead, kill whatever was closer, or try to…— he desperately explained. —It just made it seem *justified* to kill them, even when they- even if they were actually innocent.

—And how exactly do you know this?

—Be-because… The first two I made were tested… One, was found by the police where Adora was attacked. The other was… found in Mystacor, even if there were no reports of an attack— he explained. —I only know Micah took the one that appeared in Mystacor, the other was placed by the Butcher Brothers. Adora was attacked because of it. I-it was my fault.

—And you don't know who attacked her?

—The device malfunctioned and burnt; the Butcher Brothers said they didn't see who attacked Chief Adora.

—So you weren't there— Spinnerella estated. —Well, according to the regents, there was a third device, was there not?

—Ye-yeah— he nodded, looking down. —I fried it when-when they tried to use it the night they captured Catra and Shadow Weaver. After Adora and Castaspella showed up, two hunter-trainees from my group said there was something happening and… when we came out of the forbidden section, I saw the regents threatening to kill Catra.

—If you didn't know whether either of them was a vampire, why did you fry your device?

Shit.

This could be a problem for him.

Unless the boy had something prepared?

—I told you: the device makes vampires kill whatever is closer. My friends were- If *anyone* in the library was a vampire, *everyone* would be in danger. I don't know why you want me so bad to confirm or deny whether they are vampires!— he finally complained.

Huh… not bad.

He was close to commiting perjury.

—This time, it’s relevant— the defense attourney insisted.

—No, it is not. The relevant part is that the regents wanted me to kill my friend, in front of her fiancée, once again arguing it’s my duty!

—Alright. I see— Spinnerella accepted. —No further questions.

Shadow Weaver let out a relieved sigh.

That was worse than testifying herself.

—Your Honor, I would like to call now my third witness. Castaspella— Netossa expressed, standing up.

—I understand, Prosecutor, but that will have to wait until the next hearing— he explained. —Next week, we’ll start at nine in the morning, with Castaspella’s testimony. Session dismissed— he declared, standing up.

The old vampire finally relaxed.

That was when she noticed, not only the tightness in her chest, but also that, at some point, she had grabbed Castaspella’s hand.

Chapter End Notes

Ngl, I feel a bit sorry for Spinnerella in this chapter, BUT ALSO gotta admire her and Netossa's marriage strength to be able to go through this without ending… bad.

Oh! Btw, I can't wait to post the chapter with Casta's testimony!!! And not for her testimony itself, but rather for what happens right before she's done XD (ch 7 btw, not ch 6)

ALSO you'll get to learn what the public thinks of the Hunters!!! Trust me, you want to read that >v<

Finally, uh, see you next week!! I hope you enjoyed, and thank you for reading!!!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

Welcome back!
A little breather chapter this time before :3 the next one, hehe

Also, some important revelations about *stuff* from the previous chapter :D

Finally, uh, some well overdue Glimmer-Casta interactions (#^_^#)

I hope you enjoy :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

With the session dismissed, Catra knew Adora would now have to handle her officers taking all witnesses back, so she didn't even bother trying to find her among the mass of people leaving the courtroom.

However, she wanted to find Glimmer; she needed to talk to her and Bow.

But it was impossible. She saw her the second before she teleported away taking him with her.

She now wondered what deal Bow had made that he could stay home without even a monitoring anklet like Shadow Weaver.

In any case, his "crimes" weren't as severe, so maybe he had been given prison time but just paid the bail?

She had been excluded from everything related to him specifically due to their friendship, so she was pretty much in the dark.

Ah… She was starting to feel so guilty.

The bitterness in her throat didn't recede the rest of the afternoon, and Catra arrived home in the worst mood.

Little after, a storm suddenly broke out, raging outside almost violently.

Adora arrived under heavy rain and the door blew open when she tried to get in.

—Woah! It's really dangerous out there!— Catra noticed, struggling to close the door even with her extra strength. —Are you alright, Dor?

—I'm fine— she gasped, taking off her jacket. —How about you?

—The storm didn't catch me…

—I'm not… talking about the storm.

—Oh, uh, yeah… I kinda… I'm okay— she stammered.

However, Adora's look said enough.

She didn't believe her.

—Please, talk to me.

—It's just- It's about Glimmer again— she finally sighed, taking the jacket from her to hang it on a chair. —We're her friends, but she's avoiding us. I don't know if she hates us, or if she just needs time. I can't help thinking she stright up hates us.

—Of course she doesn't! I'm sure it's just the stress of having to deal with this whole mess, the weight of her parents' choices, and… we-well… if they are found guilty, she will have to take the vacant crown— Adora reminded her. —That's a lot of feelings to process.

—Yeah, you're right— Catra nodded, looking down. —I just wish she'd let us help her process all that.

—When she's ready, she'll come to us.

—I… hope so. Thanks, Dor— she finally said, smiling sadly at her.

—Of course— Adora replied, hugging her. Catra leant onto her and started purring despite the fact that her fiancée was literally drenched. Some water wasn't as bad when she was held in such an embrace. —Sorry for soaking you— she then giggled, when they broke the hug. —So, uh, what will happen in the meantime, until next week's hearing?

—Well, we'll probably handle other trials, of course… Those things can *really* take a long while — Catra explained, heading towards the bathroom for a towel. When she returned, she offered it to Adora. —Besides, we'll probably have to handle the outcome of all the reporters' articles coming out.

—Wasn't the trial broadcast?

—Yeah, well, many people probably tuned in later, so they are likely to read the news about it— she first said. —However, there's also the tiny detail of the *bias* some of those articles may present. Like… they are likely to be more or less supportive of the regents, which will cause quite a divide…

—Oh, I see— she sighed, trying to dry her hair.

—And it will likely attract more espectators for the next hearing, which means we'll have to prepare for it; larger courtroom, more available seats, more security…

—That's… Yeah, of course— Adora nodded. —With the testimonies we heard today, it's probably going to be… *a thing*.

—Yeah. If it wasn't "interesting" before, it will surely be now— Catra smirked. —I mean, I'm sure most people thought this would end quickly with the charges being dismissed or whatever… But now that everything is out, or almost everything, the regents are in quite a tought position, so more people might be curious.

—Absolutely— her fiancée sighed, looking down and hanging the towel from the nearest chair.

—Listen, Dor— she then began, taking a deep breath. —I don't know what will happen from now on, but… try to stay safe, okay? I have a bad feeling, and I know it's your duty to protect the witnesses and all, yet your life is also important, so don't do anything stupid. Please— she pleaded.

—I'm just doing my work, Love. I take precautions, wear a vest, I have training… And… you know, there's She-Ra. As long as I transform in secret, I can heal— she reminded her.

—I know.

—Then let's prepare dinner already— Adora suggested.

—Yeah, good idea— Catra accepted. —Hopefully we can eat without the roof getting blown away — she then joked.

—Oh, please, I really hope this storm won't cause us much trouble.

Fortunately for them, it didn't.

A radiant sun shone the next morning.

It was a problem for Catra, but a relief regardless.

The couple woke up early and had a quick breakfast, got dressed, and soon head out of their home.

After the hearing of the previous day, Adora wanted to check on Shadow Weaver, make sure there were no issues with her anklet, and of course, check in with Castaspella, who probably felt nervous about the following week.

—What if they aren't awake yet?— Catra asked, as Adora knocked on the door.

—I supposed they would be, since they both work, or worked, in Mystacor's Health Institution…

—Ah, yeah, you're right— she nodded. —Castaspella did mention that Shadow Weaver wakes up insanely early— she chuckled.

Right then, the door opened and the physician recieved them with a cheerful —Girls! Good morning! Come in…

—Thanks. Good morning to you too— Adora smiled, as they both stepped in.

—G-guys!?

—Glimmer!?— they both said in unison, shocked, not only to find her there, but also because of the absolutely-not-hers clothes she was wearing.

As the Princess rushed to hug them, Castaspella moved aside and the three hugged tightly for a moment.

Then, Catra looked up and saw Bow looking quite dispirited, *also* wearing lent clothes, and called —Won't you join us, Arrow Boy?

—Sorry, he's a bit… You can imagine— Glimmer apologized, letting go of them. —We both are, to be honest, but I'm… I'm so sorry, guys— she sobbed.

—Why don't you sit at the table? Finish your breakfast and you can keep talking— her aunt suggested, gentle.

—Yeah- I- Yes, you're right, Auntie— the Princess nodded.

—Do you want anything to drink or eat, girls?

—No, we're fine— Catra replied.

—Yeah, we already had breakfast, don't worry.

It was a bit awkward to sit at the same table as Shadow Weaver; Catra had eaten with her friends plenty, and many times shared lunch with Castaspella since having to protect her… But with that- well, she was no longer a hunter, but she still *felt* like one to her. And it gave her goosebumps.

But it didn't matter now.

Pushing away the feeling of unease before anyone could notice, she focused on Glimmer.

That did matter.

—I'm so sorry I've been distant, guys— the Princess began. —It was difficult, watching how my parents were taken away. A-and I was overwhelmed with reporters afterwards, so I didn't want to leave the palace— she explained, looking down. —I was scared of losing Bow too, so I begged him to stay hidden with me until the trial.

—It's okay, Glim— Adora gently smiled. —We knew you needed time. But please don't be afraid to ask us for help next time you need it— she assured her. —It's alright if you aren't ready to talk yet.

—No, no. I think it's already time. Especially with what happened last night— she sighed.

—If you had to come here in the middle of the storm, I can't imagine what happened— Catra pointed out, already anticipating how bad it could be.

—How do you know…

—You're wearing lent clothes, Sparkles. Doesn't sound like you planned to visit your aunt… but rather that you two came here in a rush and got soaked— she replied.

—Yeah. That's correct.

—It's all my fault— Bow interrupted.

—No, it's not. I should have been more proactive— Glimmer immediately denied, placing a hand on his. —I'm proud of you.

—But you shouldn't have bailed me out— he insisted. —You would have been safer.

—Safer?— Catra let out, feeling a sudden chill.

—Ah… It's been a few hard days, a-and we've been getting anonymous messages, hinting at…

—Remember how I admitted I got threatened?— Bow interrupted again, probably because of how hesitant Glimmer was. He looked so serious… —It wasn't exactly the regents, as they thought. The hunters that remain free were trying to make sure I'd skip the trial or lie— he revealed. —That's why I hesitated to walk in. But we had decided I would still testify, and we'd face the consequences together. It's just that, after returning home yesterday, we got a more serious threat.

Catra's chills only got worse. She glanced briefly at Adora, both sharing the same thought.

—Someone sneaked in and left an explicit threat, nothing like the previous ones— Glimmer went on. —I got scared, a-and started to panic. Bow suggested going with someone, but I didn't want to put anyone else in danger.

—Why come here, then?— Shadow Weaver interrupted, scoffing a bit. —They may be targeting me too. Both of us here only simplifies things for them.

—I considered that, but with your sorcery… I don't know, I felt like it'd be safer— the Princess explained.

—What about us?— Adora asked.

Just what Catra was wondering.

Except that she had an idea.

—We would have been in worse danger— she began, before they could reply. —I'm a vampire, their weapons are designed to kill me. And you can't use… *that* without risking burning me— she then added. —On the contrary, Shadow Weaver is a more experienced hunter, I bet dealing with the rookies that haven't been taken into custody is child's play.

—Correct— the old vampire smirked.

—And with Casta's defense spells, you can be sure they'd be safe— she concluded.

—Yeah— Glimmer nodded. —That's what we thought.

—Travelling under the rain was still dangerous— Castaspella reminded them.

—Oh, no, I just teleported us to the door— the Princess chuckled sheepishly.

—How long were you- But you were *soaked*!

—We still had some doubts, Auntie. So we didn’t knock right away.

Of course. Expected from them.

—Alright— Adora sighed. —I think you should fill a report at the Station. Harassment and threats are punishable. Especially targeting the Princess. And it will be on the record to catch the remaining hunters before they can cause any harm.

—You’re right— Glimmer nodded. —We should do that.

—You can assign them officers to protect them too, right?— Catra asked.

—With the report, yes.

—I’ll get the threats and go to the Station today then.

Shadow Weaver

She was so grateful to be done at last.

Ugh… so much people in the court, so easy to surprise…

It was getting on her nerves.

—Will you return home with me or should you wait for Catra?

—Oh, n-no, um… I think I can return with you since there’s the police escort— Castaspella replied.

—Then let’s get going. I need some peace and quiet— Shadow Weaver grunted, making her giggle, oddly enough.

—You definitely need a rest— she smiled.

These instances when Castaspella behaved so gently and considerately always made the old vampire wonder how it was possible to really be in a relationship with her.

They are just so… *opposite*.

Ah… who cares?

Pushing away that thought, Shadow Weaver placed a hand on Castaspella’s back and both headed for the exit.

Yet she couldn’t help sparing a glance back at the regents.

Micah was very purposely avoiding her gaze. Angella, on the other hand, held it proudly, with a scorn. Smirking back at her, she lowered her hand on Castaspella's back and held her by the waist.

That was enough of a message, she was sure.

—Afternoon. We were assigned to take you back to your residence— an officer met them, as soon as they walked out of the door.

—Good afternoon, and thank you— the physician replied. —Do you have the address?

—Yes— the policeman nodded. —Please, follow me.

—Sure— Shadow Weaver sighed.

The trip back was uneventful.

There were surprisingly few people outside, most of them reporters, and they showed no intentions of trying to get comments from anyone leaving the Court.

Odd.

Perhaps they were overwhelmed by the recent revelations?

Did that mean the next time there *would* be more attendance!?

Ugh… the sole possibility sapped all her mental energy.

To distract herself, she decided to discuss with Castaspella what to cook for dinner, and soon, they were finally home.

—Hmm… The sky looks quite dark— the physician noticed, peeking through the window while washing the dishes. —And the wind is getting stronger.

—Storm incoming?

—I'm sure.

—Should we go to sleep early?— she then asked.

—Sleep?— Castaspella asked back, raising a brow with half a smile.

Oh…

—Of course. What else could we do?

She liked some good tease sometimes, and this seemed like the perfect time for it.

—Let me think, uh…— she began, stepping closer. —Why don't we go to your room, make sure your windows are well closed, and take off these clothes we've been using all day?

Now.

—Naturally. We can't sleep wearing this— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—Bea!— she complained, playfully slapping her chest. —Come on! You know what I mean!

—Hmm… I don't know. You'll have to show me— she pressed on.

—I absolutely will.

How enjoyable.

Whatever doubts Shadow Weaver had had earlier were now gone.

Why was Castaspella with her? Because she wanted to.

Did she deserve her? Most surely no.

Did either of them care? Not in the slightest.

Despite everything, they felt like they were made for each other. And that feeling was only enhanced when making out half naked, of course.

However, an untimely knock on the door interrupted them.

—Ugh… who on Etheria could be out with this rain?

—Should I check?

—It's too suspicious. Could be a trap— Shadow Weaver warned her.

—Or it could be something so important that whoever is out there had to brave the storm!— her partner argued. —I'll check through the window, don't worry.

—Sure, but better cover yourself first— she smirked, tracing a finger down the middle of Castaspella's bare chest.

—Enough of that. I'll be right back— she decided, getting off the old vampire's lap.

What an awful timing!

And still, it felt suspicious, so she couldn't help covering herself too and going to the doorframe, ready to act if necessary.

However, as soon as the physician moved the curtain to check outside, she gasped and rushed to open the door.

—So-sorry for the time, but-but…

—Shh, just come in— Castaspella interrupted her niece, ushering her inside. —You're drenched! Bea, bring some towels, please!

The Princess and her fiancé!?

Unbelievable.

The vampire didn't hesitate to use her full speed to get the towels, and passed one to the physician and the other to Bow.

—I'll get you some clean clothes— she sighed, watching as Castaspella helped Glimmer dry off.

—Tha-thanks— she heard Bow stammer as she walked back into the room.

Alright.

She was right, it was obviously something urgent.

But what exactly?

The vampire pondered in silence as she browsed through the last laundry batch for something, whatever, that could fit those two.

Well, a baggy jumper for Bow probably would work. And any of their shirts would probably be too long for the Princess, but… better than nothing.

—Here you go— she told them, offering each the piece of clothing she had picked. —Unfortunately, this will have to do— she added, noticing their hesitation.

—O-of course. It's perfect— Glimmer accepted, with a sad smile.

—What happened?

—Ca-can we tell you in the morning?

As if on instinct, she glanced at Castaspella, who looked worried but even more sorrowful.

—Sure, Princess— Shadow Weaver sighed, shaking her head. —I'll open the sofa for you.

—It…

—Turns into a bed, yes— Castaspella gently told her, turning on the lamp next to it.

After moving away the small table, the vampire struggled a bit with the damned sofa until she could extend it. Without a word, she went for a pair of pillows and a large blanket.

—Here— she uttered, offering it to them. —But tomorrow you better explain yourselves.

—Of course. Yes. We will— Bow assured her with a military-like tone, as if she were still his superior in the Alliance.

With that, she returned to her room, massaging her temples.

—I left a drying spell on the kitchen table. You can lay your clothes there. Rest well— she heard Castaspella farewell, before turning off the main lights. Once inside too, she closed the door and sighed —I can't believe this.

—Me neither.

—They look so scared, Bea…

—And I’m letting them stay, even without explaining what happened. What else do you want me to do?

—I-I’m not… complaining. Thank you for that. I’m just a bit concerned now.

—A bit?— she reproached her, raising a brow.

—Fine. *Very* concerned.

—I realize— Shadow Weaver sighed. —Come on, let’s go to sleep. They promised to tell us in the morning, we gave them clothes and a bed, so there’s nothing else we can do.

—I hope I can sleep— Castaspella uttered, taking a deep breath and following her to the bed.

—I’ll try to help— the vampire smirked, enveloping her in an embrace.

—Thank you…

The storm raged on all night, but when morning arrived, no one would have guessed that had been the case.

Even when the rays of sunlight can’t enter the room, it is still brightly illuminated every morning, so Castaspella and Shadow Weaver woke up quite early.

—Hmm… Morning.

—Good morning, my love.

—Not good until I have coffee— the old vampire grunted.

—Right— the physician giggled. —I’ll prepare breakfast.

—First, wake them up— Shadow Weaver suggested. —Give them time to brush away sleep before we have to restore the sofa and the table.

—Oh, right! I hadn’t thought about it— she admitted, apologetic.

—Then go.

She made a show of pretending to return to sleep, but actually got up right after Castaspella and followed her up to the doorframe, from where she observed as the young physician gently sat next to her niece.

Glimmer and Bow looked… small. Fragile. *Scared*.

Castaspella was right about them.

Whatever had happened must have been severe.

Well, they would soon explain it all, fortunately.

Once Glimmer yawned and agreed to get up, the physician finally stood up and went to the kitchen. Shadow Weaver decided to help her out and, between the both of them, they soon put together a hearty breakfast.

—Oh, you've tidied up the sofa and table already, wonderful— Castaspella noticed, carrying the tray of food into the living-room. —Even folded the blanket.

—Ye-yeah, we- Um, thanks. For everything. You really didn't have to— the Princess stammered.

—Nonsense. You're my niece, I wouldn't leave you to freeze under the rain. Neither of you.

—Well, yeah, but…

—No buts. Sit and have breakfast now— she insisted. —I certainly hope you won't catch a cold after last night…

—We'll be fine, Auntie— Glimmer smiled, grateful.

—Alright, time to tell us what happened— Shadow Weaver decided to interrupt.

—Bea!

—No, no… she's right. We should— the Princess nodded. —We got… a threat last night.

—Of course you did— the old vampire scoffed. —Can't believe you weren't expecting it and had to come running for safety…

—Stop being a jerk, will you?— Castaspella chastised her. —It's alright. I'm glad you came and are safe— she assured them. —You don't need to explain anything else.

—Oh… Thanks, Auntie.

Always so nice… Yeah, those are her niece and future nephew-in-law, but still, she *should* want proper explanations.

As they continued eating, there was a long moment of silence.

Until Bow decided to speak up.

—I should apologize— he said. —Shadow Weaver.

That… was certainly a surprise.

—What for?

—When I first- When I took the Butcher Brothers to attack you, they- you were gravely wounded. I couldn't see you but… I heard you.

—Please, I *killed* them. What is there to apologize for?

—If I had taken the trainees with me, as I was originally tasked to, you would have escaped unscathed.

—Or I would have killed them instead *and* you.

—I'm sure we would have fled at the first sign of danger.

—Forget it— Shadow Weaver finally laughed, dismissive. —In any case, you did right. You were sent to lead the team, if you asked for the Butcher Brothers instead, it's because you *knew* your fellows wouldn't be up to the task. You were *responsible*— she assured him, sipping her coffee. —Besides, those idiotic brothers had it coming.

—What do you mean?— Glimmer asked, confused.

—Oh, I… think she means their reputation as the most cruel and bloody hunters.

—Correct— she smirked, briefly looking at Bow. —Furthermore, they were extremely hard to control and defied my authority plenty. Obedient? Sure, but not with everyone. I wouldn't discard the possibility that they recognized me and wanted to kill me even more.

Oh, how she hated them…

—That's… Oh— the Princess sighed. —I understand.

Sudden knocking on the door startled them before Glimmer could say anything else.

—Fuck— Castaspella muttered, placing a hand on her chest. —I'll check— she told them, standing from the table.

After briefly looking through the window, her expression completely changed and she cheerfully opened the door.

Chief Adora and Catra.

What where they doing here this early in the morning?

How strange.

Well, it looked like it was time for the *touching* reunion. As soon as the Princess realized it was them, she rushed to hug them.

Frankly *far* from what she wanted to see while having breakfast.

Why do people enjoy such public depictions of love!?

Way to tell everyone how much you care, making the people you "love" the main target for anyone who wants to harm you…

If Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes any harder, she'd get a headache.

As Castaspella invited them to join the table, she decided to focus on her meal while they talked.

They explained in more detail how they had been threatened, that Bow's hesitation at the trial was due to that, and how they went to hide with Shadow Weaver and Castaspella fearing they'd be in danger.

Sometimes these kids don't really think.

—Why come here, then? They may be targeting me too. Both of us here only simplifies things for them.

—I considered that, but with your sorcery… I don't know, I felt like it'd be safer— the Princess explained, not daring to make eye-contact.

—What about us?— the Chief asked.

Huh… she sounded pretty betrayed.

—We would have been in worse danger— Catra began, before they could reply. It surprised Shadow Weaver, but also interested her that she'd so confidently say that. —I'm a vampire, their weapons are designed to kill me. And you can't use… *that* without risking burning me— she then added. —On the contrary, Shadow Weaver is a more experienced hunter, I bet dealing with the rookies that haven't been taken into custody is child's play.

—Correct— the old vampire smirked.

Hah! So even she admitted it.

Strange to be praised by that girl, but she probably didn't say it as a praise.

—And with Casta's defense spells, you can be sure they'd be safe— Catra concluded.

—Yeah— Glimmer nodded. —That's what we thought.

—Travelling under the rain was still dangerous— Castaspella reminded them.

—Oh, no, I just teleported us to the door— her niece chuckled sheepishly.

—How long were you- But you were *soaked*!

—We still had some doubts, Auntie. So we didn't knock right away.

Those idiots… If the Princess ended up with a flu, she'd never hear the end of it from Castaspella…

—Alright— Adora sighed, conclusive. —I think you should fill a report at the Station. Harassment and threats are punishable. Especially targeting the Princess. And it will be on the record to catch the remaining hunters before they can cause any harm.

Smart.

—You're right— Glimmer nodded. —We should do that.

—You can assign them officers to protect them too, right?— Catra asked.

—With the report, yes.

—I'll get the threats and go to the Station today then— the Princess promised.

Chapter End Notes

And that was all for today!!

See you next week with *the* chapter I've been waiting to post UwU

Many thanks for reading :D

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

Hi hi!! Did u think I forgot to update?
~~Maybe… I did forget today was Wednesday~~

Anyways…
I've been waiting for this chapter!!! It's not super long, but this is like, an important chapter imo
There will be other important chapters in, like, the second arc of the fic, but for the first arc (aka, the trials), this chapter is !!!! in my humble opinion heh

Welp, without further comments, I'll let you read!! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

Then next hearing soon arrived.

Before they knew it, Catra had taken Castaspella's oath and they were now hearing her testimony.

—So, tell us: how exactly did you get ahold of all the evidence you gave the police?

—For a really long while, I followed both Shadow Weaver and Micah during my free time— she admitted, looking slightly ashamed.

—Why?— Netossa further asked.

—At first, I was curious. Once I knew what they were doing, I grew concerned, for them and for… potential victims.

—Did you ever interfere with their job?

—Yes.

—How exactly?

—When I knew who they were after, I would try to warn them. When they went in particularly dangerous missions, I would try to help them… Shadow Weaver did notice my presence, however, and tried to stop me because no one else was supposed to know I knew.

—No further questions— Netossa decided to conclude with a smile.

She had left *a lot* of things out, didn't make very obvious questions… But perhaps the idea was to have Spinnerella ask those and doom herself?

—Your witness— Judge Hordak said, gesturing at her to approach.

—Well, let me begin by asking the obvious, since it seems like the Prosecution Office isn't interested— she first said, a bit cocky. She surely thought she had them… What a shame for her. —Since *when* do you know about hunters and vampires?

—Oh, so that's relevant?— Castaspella asked back.

—Please answer the question.

—Sure…— the physician sighed. —I know since the night Chief Adora got attacked. Or should I said, the night *my brother* almost got me killed— she innocently replied, making the public start to murmur. —I know he had no idea, but what exactly made him think it was a good idea to set such a dangerous device in our workplace!? Knowing I was there! Please, Counsellor, do tell me if you know.

Wow.

Did Shadow Weaver train her for this!?

Probably.

—E-excuse me!? Ca-can you explain what you mean?

—Gladly— Castaspella smiled. —The night Chief Adora went to Mystacor with what looked like the nastiest wound on her arm, not long after, a vampire attacked me. I had to use sorcery to keep myself protected until I could knock the vampire down. I, of course, didn't know that's what it was, I thought some beast or monster was chasing me, couldn't give it much thought at the moment, but… Well, let's just say I had to start believing in vampires pretty quickly.

—A-Alright. But, what about the hunters?

—I just followed Shadow Weaver one night in which our shifts ended at the same time. I saw her meet Micah at the entrance of the library, followed them inside… It didn't take a genius to know what they were and what they meant. They don't exactly speak in code.

—So you admit you stalked your superior and you brother?

—Yes— Castaspella sighed. —I did. That's how I knew Bow and those… *brothers* were going for a vampire, and if I hadn't arrived in time, Bow would probably have died too…

—So you knew they were going for Shadow Weaver?

—Yes. And I…. found her about to pass out from bloodloss. I took her to my place, tended to her wounds…

While the physician spoke, Catra saw Angella call Spinnerella over and her ears perked up when she caught a word.

"Unknown"

—Excuse me, Castaspella— she started again. —My clients claim Bow had been sent on a mission to hunt an *unknown* vampire. In fact, Bow also declared he didn't know who was his target. So how did *you* know?

Oh, shit…

The physician going pale was not a good sign.

—Because… of the stalking. I was well aware where both, Shadow Weaver and Micah were. What she did in that alley is not *my* business to tell, but I knew she'd be there.

—Not your business to tell… Sounds like you don't want to admit that you *knew* she dealt for blood there…

—Is that a question?— Castaspella calmly asked.

Smart.

Perhaps this was part of the plan for the reveal?

Finally.

—I'll reformulate: Did you…— Spinnerella began, yet the doors suddenly burst open before she could finish, and a bulky individual strode in. —Who-who are you!?

—I come to serve real justice!— they yelled, pulling out something that looked like a baton at first, until it unfolded into a hand crossbow.

It was already loaded.

This guy was a *hunter*.

Catra saw it all in slow-motion.

The officers trying to stop them, the hunter aiming for Judge Hordak, and someone getting in the middle right when the damned shot was fired.

Next thing she knew, Catra was kneeling next to Castaspella, who had "caught" the arrow with her hand… Or rather, intercepted it.

—I feel… unwell— she uttered, looking about to throw up.

Shit.

It probably had holy water.

The physician was lucky to be just a lesser vampire.

Catra immediately snatched a trash bin from behind the Judge's desk and gave it to her so she wouldn't vomit on the floor.

—Come, we have to take you to the backroom— she gently told her, trying to help her up.

—What happened… with…

—The police got the hunter— Catra assured her, glancing back briefly to make sure they *did* get them.

She didn't wait for further approval and immediately took Castaspella to the chamber behind the court room.

The physician threw up a few more times with the arrow still stuck in her hand before Catra managed to have her sit and bear the pain as she removed it carefully.

—Ca-Catra, what happened!?— a voice asked behind her.

—Shit! Kyle! You scared me!— she exclaimed, jumping slightly. —*Bullshit* happened— she sneered. —Bring me some blood for her and the first aid kit.

—Right away!

Soon enough, she had finished bandaging Castaspella's hand after making sure the wound closed up with the blood donation Kyle brought for her.

—Rest for a bit— Catra recommended her, gesturing at her to lay on the sofa.

—Where's everyone?

—I'm sure they'll come here as soon as everything is handled outside.

—I need to let Bea know I'm fine— she insisted.

—She'll be brought here, don't worry— Catra promised.

—A-alright…

Fortunately, the physician complied and rest down until Hordak entered the backroom, followed by Shadow Weaver.

—Worry not, everything is now under control…— the Judge began, before being rudely pushed aside by the old vampire.

—Casta!— she exclaimed, rushing to kneel next to the couch.

—Relax, she's fine— Catra told her, earning a growl in return. Good thing Castaspella soon distracted her. —She already got a blood donation, I bandaged her hand, and she's recovering well. No one suspects a thing, right?

—It appears no one does, indeed— Hordak confirmed.

However, he then looked deep in thought and his ears kept twitching. Thinking or *hearing* something? The answer was clear soon enough as he went to turn on the radio sitting on a stand

on the wall.

—*“Let’s interview some more people. Hello, excuse me. Any words on the events we just witnessed?”*— a journalist was saying on the radio. —*“Yes, quite some! How is it possible that individuals like the one we saw are allowed to indiscriminately shoot at people!?”*— an indignant woman pointed out. —*“It doesn’t matter whether there really are vampires out there or not! That is* not *justice! We have no proof that the Judge is a vampire. But say he was, how can we allow someone to just kill him at a whim? If that is how hunters work, I do not want them roaming free!”*— she insisted. —*“They say they are protecting you”*— the journalist reminded her, his tone neutral. —*“Oh really? Until they decide I might be a vampire too and shoot me, no questions asked!”*— the woman countered, a scoff noticiable in her tone.

A loud laughter called their attention back to Castaspella, who was now sitting on the couch again.

—Oh, we really won the public opinion, didn’t we?— she sighed, relieved. —Their assassination attempt completely backfired.

—So it would appear— Hordak nodded.

—I must admit I’m worried about them somehow knowing that you, Judge, aren't mortal… But… maybe they don’t really know?— Castaspella then considered.

—They may suspect something, but can’t possibly know I’m a vulture— he smirked. —I must, of course, thank you for interceding. Otherwise, I would have been exposed— he then said, appraoching the physician and offering his hand to help her up.

—Move— Shadow Weaver barked, helping her herself instead. —We’re leaving.

—Wait until Adora…

—*We* are *leaving* right now!— the old vampire insisted.

—Bea, please, calm down.

She looked ready to say something else, but fortunately Adora walked in that exact moment.

—Hey, how’s Castaspella doing?— she asked, sighing deeply.

She sounds exhausted.

—I’m fine, Chief, no need to worry.

—That was an incredible catch, and I’m so sorry you had to do that— she began, flustered. —I was in charge of security yet this guy slipped past it like it was nothing, I don’t… know what happened.

—It’s alright, please don’t blame yourself— the physician insisted.

—No, it’s *not* alright at all. Anyone could have died!

—Chief— Hordak then called, before Catra could so much as extend a hand towards Adora to support her. —I understand your concern, but you must focus on the facts: no one died, you

caught the culprit, and the public opinion now definitely condemns the hunters.

—I-I… A-alright— Adora sighed, calming down.

—That's better— Catra smiled, taking her hand and squeezing briefly. —How bad is the situation out there?

—Bad enough that they will need protection— she replied, gesturing at Shadow Weaver and Castaspella.

—I'll keep protecting Casta, and I guess I can extend that to the old hag while they are together, but if they separate, I'm sticking to Casta— Catra explained.

—Then I guess…

—Forget it, Chief. I don't need "protection"— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—You *absolutely* need it— Adora scoffed. —Not only from the hunters that consider you a traitor, but also from the people who now hate the hunters! You have no idea how difficult it was to escort the regents away! The people outside were yelling and some even wanted to attack them… I-I'll drive you home myself and then we'll discuss your security— she finally decided.

—Ah… Alright— the old vampire finally accepted. —Shall we?

—O-of course— Castaspella nodded.

—Better take the day off today— Catra suggested, getting a hesitant nod in return.

—See you later— Adora farewelled, before leaving the backroom with the couple on tow.

Being left alone, she finally flopped down on the couch and looked at her boss.

—What now? How do we proceed?

—Isn't it obvious? Castaspella is right. The public opinion already favours us— Hordak began. —We must focus on strengthening security, maybe add some of our people to the police officers and, of course, continue this trial without public. Needless to say, it's imperative that we continue to proceed by the law if we don't want to be hypocrites and fall into the hunters' ways…

—Of course, Boss— she nodded, standing up. —I'll manage the security enforcement.

—Do so, and send extra security to Beatrix's place— he added. —I have a bad feeling about it. Might be nothing, but we can't risk it— he pointed out.

—Yes, Hordak. Right away— she accepted.

As she headed for the door, she brushed back her hair, trying to calm down the rising stress.

This day was already long, it was barely eleven in the morning…

Shadow Weaver

She could see Castaspella was still pretty nervous.

But she had prepared her.

With the prosecutor, they had agreed on a strategy; basically, Netossa would *not* ask very obvious questions, knowing Spinnerella would take that as an attempt to hide something, and that would make the defense dig its own grave when they asked Castaspella about it.

And it worked like a charm.

Even better with Shadow Weaver's tips on the *manner* of speech.

The key was always to sound innocent, and the physician is, for the most part, quite innocent.

Not in this case, but she made it work perfectly.

And with only a few days to practice!

Shadow Weaver had to hold back her laughter. Especially when she saw Micah turn to glare at her.

He noticed.

Better.

Then it was time for the reveal, at long last… But they got *interrupted*.

The old vampire took it "as a pathetic attempt" at disrupting the trial for exactly five seconds before she saw Castaspella catch a goddamned arrow with her hand! And one that was surely infused with holy water!

In a second, she was on the ground, so was the hunter, and then she saw her puke on a bin.

Yes, holy water.

She's lucky to be just a lesser vampire…

In any case, before she realized, she was on her feet and ready to tear someone apart, but both the prosecutor and Chief Adora rushed to her.

—Calm down.

—Please, don't do anything stupid.

—I won't just sit back and *wait*! That idiot could have killed her!— she barked. —You hear me, Micah!? You almost got your own sister *killed*! Still think you are not a threat to her!?— she yelled, glaring daggers at him above the officers pinning down the hunter. —Take away their coat, it likely has silver daggers, holy water vials, and who knows what else…

—Of course— Adora nodded. —I'll do that, you wait here for me, understood?

—Sure…

Still wary, she went to her people and ordered them to take away the coat and make sure they had nothing else at hand. The foldable crossbow had already been taken by the police, and the regents had been handcuffed, despite Spinnerella's pleas.

—Well, so much for the reveal…

—What now, Prosecutor?— she asked Netossa, sharing her disappointment.

—Now, I have a lot of paperwork to fill, and we'll see how we proceed. This *technically* makes things even easier for us, but at the same time it'll be a lot of documentation on my desk… So I have to deal with that first— she explained.

—I see. So the trials will continue next week?

—It may be a while before we have any more of these public trials, if any— she sighed. —They will remain in prison in the meantime, of course, but… Well, let's just say we must wait for the Court's decision.

—*Fantastic*. This will be neverending.

—It will take a long while, but I can promise you it won't be eternal. This is a serious matter.

—I know…

The Chief then briefly approached.

—Alright, I'll take the regents to the patrol cars and then we'll go to the backroom, okay?— Adora told Shadow Weaver, who nodded in silence.

The vampire saw her off and sat down again.

—Would you like me to wait with you?— Netossa hesitantly asked.

—No need, prosecutor. You can go.

It was better like that. Waiting without anyone arround to see her struggle.

She wanted to make them pay- *No*, she wanted them *dead*.

That wouldn't do, however.

She didn't have it in her to truly harm Micah, and who on their right mind would try to kill an angelic being?

But she wasn't in her right mind.

Castaspella could have died in front of her and she wouldn't have been able to do *anything*.

Fortunately, Chief Adora soon returned. She'll be able to see her partner soon.

She had to be alright…

—Excuse me, Shadow Weaver— Adora began. —We're having some trouble, so go to the backroom and I'll go afterwards. I'll take you both home soon.

—Alright— the vampire accepted, no questions asked. There was no point in asking now. —We'll wait there…

—Good. Thanks— she smiled, before running out of the court room.

—Shadow Weaver— the Judge called from behind his desk. —Coming?

—You bet— she smirked. —Waited long enough.

She rushed to catch up with him, walked into the backrrom behind Hordak, and immediately located Castaspella.

She was resting on the couch.

Was she still alive!?

—Worry not, everything is now under control…

—Casta!— she exclaimed, interrupting Hordak as she pushed him aside and rushed to kneel next to her partner.

—Relax, she's fine— Catra told her, to which she growled in return. Insolent little child. But she didn't have time to actually bark anything since Castaspella woke up. —She already got a blood donation, I bandaged her hand, and she's recovering well— she then explained, while Shadow Weaver focused on the physician. At least that girl is efficient. —No one suspects a thing, right?

—It appears no one does, indeed— Hordak confirmed.

Ah, who cared about that… The *really* important part was that Castaspella is fine.

She could breathe easy having her looking back and smiling, even if weakly.

She's fine. They were fine…

However, there was then a strange noise behind her and she realized someone had turned on the radio.

Hordak.

Why?

—*"Let's interview some more people. Hello, excuse me. Any words on the events we just witnessed?"*— a journalist was saying on the radio. —*"Yes, quite some! How is it possible that individuals like the one we saw are allowed to indiscriminately shoot at people!?"*— an indignant woman pointed out. —*"It doesn't matter whether there really are vampires out there or not! That is* not *justice! We have no proof that the Judge is a vampire. But say he was, how can we allow someone to just kill him at a whim? If that is how hunters work, I do not want them roaming free!"*— she insisted. —*"They say they are protecting you"*— the journalist reminded her, his

tone neutral. —*"Oh really? Until they decide I might be a vampire too and shoot me, no questions asked!"*— the woman countered, a scoff noticiable in her tone.

That woman was *not* wrong.

Shadow Weaver was ready to make a comment to Castaspella, but her sudden laughter caught her by surprise and she looked back to find her sitting on the couch.

—Oh, we really won the public opinion, didn't we?— she sighed, relieved. —Their assassination attempt completely backfired.

—So it would appear— Hordak nodded.

—I must admit I'm worried about them somehow knowing that you, Judge, aren't mortal… But… maybe they don't really know?— Castaspella then considered.

They couldn't possibly know…

—They may suspect something, but can't possibly know I'm a vulture— he smirked. —I must, of course, thank you for interceding. Otherwise, I would have been exposed— he then said, appraoching them.

As soon as he *chivalrously* offered Castaspella his hand to help her up, Shadow Weaver got in the middle.

She's *hers*.

—Move— she barked, helping the physician instead. —We're leaving.

—Wait until Adora…— Catra tried to say, but she did *not* care.

She needed to take Castaspella back to the safety of their place.

—*We* are *leaving* right now!

—Bea, please, calm down.

Like *fuck* she'd calm down!

And she was ready to make it clear yet Adora walked in that exact moment.

—Hey, how's Castaspella doing?— she asked, sighing deeply.

—I'm fine, Chief, no need to worry.

—That was an incredible catch, and I'm so sorry you had to do that— she began, flustered. —I was in charge of security yet this guy slipped past it like it was nothing, I don't… know what happened.

—It's alright, please don't blame yourself— the physician insisted.

As if! Of course she was to blame!

—No, it's *not* alright at all. Anyone could have died!— Adora rebuked.

Good to know she at least is concious of it.

—Chief— Hordak then called. —I understand your concern, but you must focus on the facts: no one died, you caught the culprit, and the public opinion now definitely condemns the hunters.

Ugh, sure, whatever… Shadow Weaver knew that was true, but if Castaspella hadn't recovered so easily, she'd be doing quite a scandal.

—I-I… A-alright— Adora sighed, calming down.

—That's better— Catra smiled, taking her hand. —How bad is the situation out there?

—Bad enough that they will need protection— she replied, gesturing in their general direction.

Oh, no. She was *not* getting any more escorts.

—I'll keep protecting Casta, and I guess I can extend that to the old hag while they are together, but if they separate, I'm sticking to Casta— Catra explained.

And that works fine.

—Then I guess…

—Forget it, Chief. I don't need "protection"— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—You *absolutely* need it— Adora scoffed. —Not only from the hunters that consider you a traitor, but also from the people who now hate the hunters! You have no idea how difficult it was to escort the regents away! The people outside were yelling and some even wanted to attack them… I-I'll drive you home myself and then we'll discuss your security— she finally decided.

The old vampire squinted at her but… she was right.

She hadn't considered that.

—Ah… Alright— she finally accepted. —Shall we?— she asked her partner.

—O-of course— Castaspella nodded.

—Better take the day off today— Catra suggested, getting a hesitant nod in return.

—See you later— Adora farewelled, before leaving the backroom with them on tow.

Soon they were out of the Court and, just as the Chief anticipated, most of the trial's public was still gathered around.

Whispering.

Oh, but Shadow Weaver heard every word.

—That's the physician that was testifying— one voice said.

—I heard she's the partner of that hunter…— another one added.

—The former Head Physician?— someone else asked.

—Yeah! I don't know *how* she can be with her— the previous one scoffed.

—Well, she *is* the King's sister— a low voice pointed out.

—But she's testifying *against him*!— the second voice reminded them. —So how can she be with a hunter?— they insisted.

—But Shadow Weaver has an anklet. Maybe she made a deal to testify against hunters?

—*Maybe*!? Didn't you hear the previous trial? She *did*. And pleaded guilty of *double-murder*!— a new voice chimed in, scandalized.

And right as they were getting into the patrol car, the old vampire managed to hear —I wonder how many people she killed…

With a grunt, Shadow Weaver closed the door and laid back on her seat, seething.

She hated it *so much* when people speculated about her.

But knowing they were also gossiping about Castaspella somehow felt *worse*.

—I caught some of that— the physician admitted, after a moment of silence.

—I'm… sorry— she uttered.

—What happened?— Adora innocently inquired, looking back at them through the rear-view mirror.

—Nothing important, Chief. Just some… annoying gossipers— Shadow Weaver dismissed her.

—Oh… I didn't hear anything. I'm so sorry— she lamented.

—You have nothing to be sorry about— Castaspella gently assured her. —People have… the right to speak their mind.

—They don't have to be such pieces of shit about it— the vampire scoffed.

—I'm just glad they didn't try anything against you— Adora admitted.

—You're right— the young physician weakly smiled. —She's right, Bea. Ignore what they said.

But it was quite hard to ignore.

Especially when they questioned the same thing she's so insecure about.

How can Castaspella be with her…

Chapter End Notes

That was all for today, folks! :D

There are some ✨details✨ from this chapter that will return to say hi in the future XD

Ahem, but well! Thank you very much for reading!! I hope you liked it >v<

See you next week!!

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

:D hi!! Welcome again, glad to have u back!

Today's chapter isn't very long, tbh, it's the second-shortest chapter, as a matter of fact <("^_^)

I hope you enjoy it! ~~And don't suffer too much for Casta, this is not the worst that will happen to her (/v\)~~

Ahem! That's all! See u at the end notes!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

Everyone thought the process would be easier after the assassination attempt; for the most part, the public and the reporters kept saying it was irrefutable proof of the danger the hunters represent and that there was no need for any more trials…

In reality, things were more *difficult* now, and the regents didn't lose their right to a fair trial, just to a public one.

Things were now more uncomfortable, more awkward, and of course, less flashy.

That was it.

So, while the hearings continued for months, the public was mostly unaware.

The defense attourney and the prosecutor called and interrogated their witnesses without anyone seeing, mostly went to the point, didn't really play any "games", and little by little, the evidence against the hunters was being processed.

In the meantime, the regents remained in jail.

However, since they hadn't been properly sentenced yet, they could still have visits. That *could* change later, so Castaspella insisted on visiting her brother while she could.

Catra would accompany her almost every week, and after a few months, she was almost sure the relationship between the siblings was getting better.

That was, until one day she saw Micah stand up and leave suddenly, while Castaspella desperately tried to stop him.

—Wait! Micah, please!— she began. —Please! Brother, let me explain!

—Nothing to explain— he spat, never turning to look at her and rushing the guard to let him return to his cell.

—No, please, I- it's not what you think, please!

—I'm *very* sure it is what I think.

—Brother, please!

—I am *not* your brother! My sister isn't… what you are— he seethed, hands tightly closed in fists. —Don't provoke me anymore. Leave me alone. *Don't* return.

—No, Micah, please!

—Open now!— he yelled at the guard, who still fumbled with the keys.

—Micah…— she sobbed once more, but he no longer replied.

Catra hesitantly approached, wanting to help somehow, but unable to figure out what to do.

—Casta?— she eventually called.

The physician was crying in silence. She had sat back on the bench in front of the table where they were talking and looked at the ground.

Or rather, it seemed like she wanted to pierce the ground with her eyes alone.

She was *far* from fine.

Castaspella's lower lip trembled, as if she intended to speak, but no words came out.

After a few minutes, Catra knelt in front of her, but the physician remained unresponsive, and the vampire didn't know what to do.

She was in shock, and she'd be damned if she knew how to get her out of this state.

For once in her life, Catra wished Shadow Weaver was there.

But maybe that was it. Only the old vampire could help her now, so she needed to take her back home.

Somehow…

—Why?— Castaspella finally uttered, her voice barely a whisper.

—Casta, please get up. We need to get you back home— Catra gently told her.

—No…

—Yes. You can't stay here. You shouldn't…

—Why?

—Because- Ah… You aren't really listening to me…— Catra then realized. —Come on, return, Casta. Please— the vampire begged, placing a hand on Castaspella's shoulder. —We need to get you back with Shadow Weaver.

—No…

—Oh Stars— Catra sighed, realizing how deep her shock ran. —Hey… Come on, get up— she insisted, gentle but starting to pull her up to get her moving. —I'm sure Shadow Weaver is getting nervous already— she tentatively said, trying whether repeating her name could somehow wake her up.

—Why?

—Oh shit… Alright, come on. Let's go.

—No…

—Yes, we're leaving this place now. I'll take you back home in a cab— Catra told her, despite knowing Castaspella was far from responsive still.

Fortunately, she managed to make her stand up, then slowly, very slowly, the two walked out of the prison and Catra stopped a cab outside. With some effort, she managed to get Castaspella inside, gave the driver the direction, and in about five minutes, they were there.

The trip was mostly silent, save for the physician's sporadic sobs.

—Why?— she repeated once more, but even the driver realized she wasn't speaking to them.

—Alright, we're here. Let's get out.

—Do you need help, Lass?

—It's fine, just give me ten minutes and I'll return.

—Sure thing— the driver accepted.

—Come on, Casta— she gently exhorted her. —You can rest soon.

—No…

—My Stars— she sighed, swallowing hard and trying to ignore the knot of anguish in her throat. —Hey! Shadow Weaver! It's us! Open!

Castaspella still looked at the ground, made no move to get her keys at all, or showed any recognition of the place.

She was so mentally gone, it was painful to watch.

—Why on Etheria didn't you open… Casta?

—She's not well. There was a problem.

—What happened?

—He knows.

—*What*!?— Shadow Weaver reacted, eyes wide open. —What did he do to her?

—Just…— Catra began, but interrupted herself and swallowed hard. —He told her she's not his sister. I… couldn't hear much, I don't know how it happened, but she's not listening anymore. I-I mean. She's… just saying "why?" and "no". That's it— Catra explained. —So be gentle, alright?

—I will.

—I mean it. She's fragile. If you're not careful…

—I understand— Shadow Weaver insisted, her demeanor serious. —Tha-thank you— she added, hesitant and apparently ashamed. —I'll take care of her, I swear.

—Good…— Catra nodded. —If she gets worse, let us know.

—I will.

The young vampire stared until the door closed, and then returned to the cab. She went back home, paid generously, and went straight to have a shower.

About an hour later, Adora arrived home and Catra was on the lounge, in a bathrobe, with a cup of tea.

—Good evening— her fiancée greeted her.

—Hey, Adora…

—Are you alright?

—Not really…

—What happened, Love?— she inquired, taking off her jacket and joining her on the couch.

—I-it was a bad day.

—How?

—I accompanied Castaspella to visit Micah again.

—I suppose it didn't go well?

—Far from it.

—What happened?

—He figured it out. I'm not sure how, but he did…

—Oh. Did he make a scandal?

—I wish— Catra scoffed. —That would have been easier to deal with— she admitted, her voice breaking. —But no. He just…

—What?

—He left her. He… abandoned her.

—*What*?

—He said she's not his sister, and doesn't want her to return.

—No…

—I know— she sniffed. —And Castaspella was… She broke down. And I mean, literally broke down. She didn't listen to me, only kept repeating "why?" and "no" and… it was super difficult to take her back home.

—She probably needs time.

—And care. And that old hag better give her that or I swear I…

—Alright, calm down— Adora gently smiled, leaning against her. —I'm sure she will. Castaspella will be fine, Love.

—I feel like I failed.

—Failed? You- I mean, you couldn't have done anything. I think you actually did the best for her: took her home, made sure she would be safe… What else could you have done?

—I should have convinced her to stop visiting him— Catra hissed. —But I wanted to believe their relationship was getting *better*.

—Love…

—I was so stupid, Dor…

—No, you were not. At all.

—I was…

—Stop that.

—But…

—Catra, please— Adora insisted. —You're not to blame. You did your job and more; she'll be fine. Trust that she will. Alright?

—Ah… Okay— she sighed, looking back at her fiancée with sorrow.

—Come on now, let's have dinner. I'm famished.

—Of course— she smiled, knocking back the rest of her tea. —I almost forgot about dinner.

—Anything you'd want tonight?

—Something simple. And that doesn't demand much time cleaning afterwards.

—Pizza?

—That sounds good— Catra smirked. —I'd love some pizza, yeah…

Seeing her in a better mood, Adora took a deep breath, relieved, and went to get the frozen pizza from the freezer and the mozzarella from the fridge. While Catra turned on the oven and washed her mug, her fiancée began preparing everything…

Shadow Weaver

The old vampire was alone at home once again as she waited for Castaspella to return from her visit to her brother.

She didn’t really understand why the physician kept visiting him. What did she expect to accomplish?

Well, she wouldn’t stop her anyways, so… Why should she question her?

She was, however, afraid of the day Micah finally gave her a reason to stop going.

Castaspella is so sentimental… She probably wouldn’t take it well.

Yet even after months, she kept going.

Not only were there no problems at all, it even seemed Micah was softening up.

The young woman was sure she’d manage to make him see how wrong his behaviour was…

She trusted he’d eventually understand whatever reason Angella had to lead the hunt was far from valid…

And while Shadow Weaver normally reveled in being right, this time she had really been hoping Castaspella would be right instead.

That hope died the moment she opened the door.

—Casta?

—She's not well. There was a problem— Catra told her, confirming her fear.

—What happened?

—He knows.

—*What*!?— Shadow Weaver reacted, eyes wide. A void opened in the pit of her stomach and she had to resist the urge to scream. —What did he do to her?— she asked, fearing the answer.

—Just…— Catra began, but interrupted herself and swallowed hard. —He told her she's not his sister. I… couldn't hear much, I don't know how it happened, but she's not listening anymore. I-I mean. She's… just saying "why?" and "no". That's it— Catra explained. —So be gentle, alright?

—I will.

—I mean it. She's fragile. If you're not careful…

—I understand— Shadow Weaver insisted, her demeanor serious. She really did, and for once, she appreciated Catra's insistence. —Tha-thank you— she added, hesitant and failing to hide her shame. —I'll take care of her, I swear.

—Good…— Catra nodded. —If she gets worse, let us know.

—I will— she promised.

Without another word, she held Castaspella by the shoulders and guided her inside, closing the door as soon as she could.

—Why?

—"Why" what?— Shadow Weaver asked, confused. But there was no reply. It took her a few minutes to get the physician to the bed, but once she was sitting down, she knelt in front of her and cupped her face with one hand. —Casta… Can you hear me?— she began. Once again, no reply. She sighed and looked around, trying to figure out what to do. She decided to make Castaspella more comfortable and removed her shoes. —Why don't you rest a bit?

—No…

—Aren't you tired?— the old vampire asked, before recalling what Catra said. —Oh, you're not listening… Right— she sighed. She moved on to remove Castaspella's sweater and left her just with the light shirt she had underneath. —Please… rest— she insisted, trying to look at her in the eyes but realizing they were unfocused. —Casta…— she called, feeling her eyes sting. —What do you need?— she asked. —Talk to me, Love— she insisted, cupping her face with both hands now. Then her tears began falling. —Please…

—Why?

Shadow Weaver wanted to be supporting, delicate, understanding. But this was becoming *impossible*. And her desperation grew.

—"Why" what!? Why he did that!? Because he's a jerk! Because he doesn't value you enough! Because he's blinded by his loyalty to his wife!— the vampire exclaimed, trying and failing to cause any reaction. —Because Micah was always a good kid, too good… and he believes he supports the right cause. Because he's an idiot who can't see he should stick to his family! He isn't- He doesn't hate you, Casta. He loves you but can't accept the truth of who you are now.

—No…

—Please. Listen to me, Casta— Shadow Weaver sobbed, voice broken. —You did nothing wrong. You're not wrong. He is… *He* is…

Sniffing and gasping for air, the old vampire finally gave up and picked Castaspella up. Holding her close, she kissed her forehead and took her to the bathroom.

Without another word, she helped the physician take a bath, or rather did it for her, then wrapped her in a towel and carried her back to the bed. She left her there, kissed her head gently, and left the room.

About an hour passed before Shadow Weaver returned to check on her.

Probably hearing the door open, Castaspella whined —Bea…

—Casta!

The old vampire rushed to her side and held her tight.

—Sorry.

—Don't. Don't apologize— she immediately replied. —You're back with me…

—I am…

—Are you feeling any better?

—Much— the physician sobbed. —And hungry— she admitted, with a sad smile.

—I imagined— Shadow Weaver sighed. —I made dinner already, don't worry.

—Thank you— she exhaled. —Can you… after eating, can you help me forget about today?— Castaspella begged, looking at her with teary eyes.

—I can— the old vampire nodded. —I will do anything you want— she promised.

—Thank you…

—Now, let's go. Get dressed— she exhorted her. —I made one of your favourites… Kafta.

—Really?— the physician smiled.

—Yes… I was going to make some suberek too, but didn't have time since I got another assignment from Hordak— she explained.

—It's alright.

—Had I known you'd be in this state, I would have left it for later and cooked the suberek anyways— Shadow Weaver lamented.

—It doesn't matter, Love— Castaspella assured her. —Kafta is enough for me.

—I'm glad.

The women had a quick dinner and then enjoyed a cup of coffee each, sitting together on the sofa.

The physician laid her head on the old vampire's shoulder and stared at the wall in front of them for a while before asking her to tell her something, anything.

—Just, speak to me— she requested.

—This is like asking me to speak another language. I have no idea what to say now— Shadow Weaver laughed.

—Sorry— Castaspella chuckled. —Uh, can you tell me what the assignment Hordak sent was about?

—Nothing too complicated. More blood analyses to process.

—Oh…

—Would you rather I pick up a book and read aloud to you?

—That would be nice, actually— she smiled.

—Choose whichever book you want.

—I know exactly which one— the physician excitedly said, using magic to fetch the book.

—Really? *Arabian Nights*?

—Please?

—Sure— Shadow Weaver smiled. —Any story in particular or should I start with the beginning?

—Yeah, start again.

—You know this book by heart now, don't you?

—Maybe…

—You're terrible— the old vampire laughed. —Alright then…

Chapter End Notes

So!
Probably not many read *Four Nights and a Week Later*, but this is the second time I make a reference to *Arabian Nights*, or *1001 Nights* in relation to castaweaver, because I LOVE it so much!
Anyways, I just wanted to point that out cause I can XD

Also, I hope this didn't feel too much like a filler chapter… I swear it's important to the plot :D

This and the next chapter will kickstart a few important events for the last part of the fic hehe

Also, I'll be a bit busy today, but I'll try to reply to comments ASAP!!

Many thanks for reading and see you next week!!

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

Ooooohhh it's the chapteeeeeerrrr!!!
I'm introducing someone today who will become kinda important quite fast, even tho she'll appear only sporadically...
More about this in the end note!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

The vampire was relieved to know Castaspella eventually recovered.

She still had her reservations about Shadow Weaver, but knowing she could really take care of her was something she could respect.

After so much time, Catra had grown really fond of the physician, but only now did she realize as much.

Which was why it pained her to see her hoplessly insisting on visiting her brother still, despite him refusing every time.

She couldn’t understand why, but she didn’t have the heart to tell her to give up either.

She discussed it with Adora several times, and always reached the conclusion she had to let her try until she gave up. It was, apparently, her form of seeking closure.

And, just as expected, it eventually happened.

Catra would always stand near the entrance to give her some privacy, so she didn’t hear what the guard told her, but… it couldn’t be good.

The moment he returned to his place, she saw Castaspella break down. Holding her head with both hands, resting her elbows on the table, she shook as she cried in silence.

She decided to give the physician a moment, until she punched the table hard enough to silence the room.

Maybe she should approach now, before the guards did.

—He-hey, easy…— she gently told her, not daring to touch her, seeing her so angry.

She had dented the table with that punch.

—I'm so stupid— Castaspella muttered, between gritted teeth. —Why did I even *think* this was worth it!?— she went on, tears falling down her cheeks. —Bea was right. This was a bad idea— she then said, standing up.

However, instead of stalking away, she hesitated for a moment, glaring at the ground.

Then she yelled and pushed the table away, or rather threw it to the side wall, as if it weighted nothing.

It was so sudden Catra was shocked for a moment, until she saw the guards approach, hands on their belts.

—Woh, hey, it's fine— she quickly told them, hands raised towards them. —I got it— she insisted. —Are you alright?— she then asked, facing the physician.

—I'm sorry. I-I don't know why I did that— Castaspella stammered.

—It's alright. You didn't hurt anyone. Let's just go.

—Yeah…— she accepted. —But let me speak with the woman at the reception window first.

—Sure.

As they both approached the window, the guards still kept their sight on them. So did the other visitors and prisoners, though with much more scared expressions.

—Excuse me— Castaspella called, knocking on the window.

—Yes?— the guard asked, as if nothing had happened.

Well, being the one who processes the visit solicitudes, she probably saw a lot…

—I understand my brother rejected my visit again, so I would like to ask if it's possible to pass a message.

—Written or spoken?

—Spoken. It's short— she replied. When the woman nodded, she said —I won't be visiting again. There's no point. So this is goodbye, although I would have preferred to do it face to face.

—Alright. I'll pass the message— the guard promised, skimming through some papers. —Oh, you're the kin- *former* king's sister— she finally realized.

—Yes.

—Then I must thank you for helping to put the hunters in jail— she seriously told her.

—Oh- Uh, any reason in particular?

—Well, yes…— the woman admitted, looking away, pained. —You see, seven years ago, my brother was turned— she began. —Then, two years later, he was- The hunters killed him and made it look like a robbery gone wrong— she explained, angry now. —I've been waiting for that trial for so long…

—I am so sorry I couldn't do something before— Castaspella apologized, looking away.

—You did now. And that's something— the guard insisted. —For that, I'm grateful.

Catra was left thinking all the way back to Castaspella's- well, Shadow Weaver's place, and considered how many people lost their family or friends and were getting closure thanks to the trials.

Adora and Castaspella had done good pushing so hard to make it happen.

—I should apologize again for what happened— Castaspella began, as soon as they reached the house. —It was- Well, I could have gotten us in trouble…

—It's alright. It wasn't that bad. I mean, I understand why you did that, even if it was… too much.

—Ah…— the physician sighed. —Would you like to come in for some tea?— she suddenly asked, probably as a way to apologize.

—Are you sure Shadow Weaver will be okay with that?

—Oh, of course— Castaspella assured her, gesturing dismissively with her hand.

As the physician opened the door, Catra decided to accept the cup of tea and followed her inside.

—Back already? Don't tell me… He didn't want to see you?— Shadow Weaver's voice mocked her from a different room, probably the kitchen.

—Very funny…— Castaspella scoffed. Without stopping, she continued to the room from where her voice came. —Yes, you were right. But that didn't stop me from throwing a table after being refused again. So either join us for some tea or shut up.

—Us? Oh… I see— the old vampire uttered, watching Catra halt at the doorway. She was sitting in front of a table on the kitchen, a whole lot of papers spread around. —There's hot water in the pot already.

—Good— the physician smiled.

Catra stared in shock as she simply busied herself making tea, no word about Shadow Weaver's taunting just a moment before.

And speaking of her… the old vampire was staring.

Judging.

Catra raised a brow, between confused and annoyed, and she finally spoke —So… a table. What happened? I suppose nothing, since you're both here, already…

Castaspella didn't reply.

In fact, she made a point of ignoring Shadow Weaver…

—N-no, yeah, nothing happened… The wall will be okay— Catra tried to joke. It didn't really get much of a reaction, so she quickly explained —Li-like she said, Micah rejected her visit again, and when the guard told her, she was crying, until… she hit the table, dented it. I approached, tried to tell her to leave, but… yeah… She threw the table to the side like it weighed nothing.

—At least no one was hurt, right?

—No.

—Good. One of us with house arrest is enough…— the old vampire scoffed.

—You're *so hilarious* today? Did you have clown for lunch or what?— Castaspella taunted her, setting a pair of steamy mugs on the table. —Catra, come sit. You don't need to stand there— she then said, chuckling.

—Oh, ri-right.

—But that wasn't all. I had a really interesting conversation with the guard who processes visitors — the physician went on. —Remember when you asked what I expected to achieve by kickstarting the trial to the hunters?

—I do…

—Well, if you had heard this woman, you would have understood immediately.

—You can ditch all this preface and just tell me— Shadow Weaver hissed, glaring at Castaspella.

—Rude— the physician rebuked, glaring back. —Why are you so cranky!?

—I am not cranky…

—You absolutely are— she scoffed. —If you have a problem because I invited Catra to have some tea, then go ahead and say it so I can tell you to fuck off and continue with the conversation.

—I have a problem with…

—Fuck off. Grow up.

—Then you say *I'm* the bitch…

—Cause you are!

Catra held her mug of tea tightly, with a mix of amusement and fear.

What the fuck was going on?

Should she say something?

Well, this bantering was going nowhere, and apparently it was her fault, so she risked saying — Look, I also thought the trial was a bad idea, but after what the guard said, I realized Casta and Adora were right.

The women stopped bickering and looked at her, surprised.

Maybe they forgot she was there.

Castaspella's bright smile soon appeared, as well as Shadow Weaver's scowl.

—Let's see, enlighten me… What did this guard say?

—She thanked me for putting the hunters in jail— the physician began, looking down at her tea. —She told us how, seven years ago, her brother was turned, and then… two years later the hunters killed him.

—So… five years ago…— the old vampire muttered, pensive. —Do you know the name of this guard?

—Uh…— Castaspella hesitated, looking back at Catra.

—The nametag said "Suarez", if I recall correctly— she said.

—That's an uncommon name here…— Shadow Weaver nodded. —As a matter of fact, I processed the paperwork for a "Nicolás Suarez".

—Wait, really!?

—I was on a scout mission that night, somewhere else, but I guess it wouldn't have made a difference if it had been assigned to me…— the old vampire began, looking a bit *too* nonchalant about it. —In any case, he was killed by the Butcher Brothers.

—Those bastards…— Catra muttered.

—Wait, so, there's… a file about him?— Castaspella realized.

—There must be. Among the evidence of the case, of course…

—I am *so sorry* to ask this, Catra, but is there *any* way to get a copy of the file?

—What- Oh, uh, actually, yeah!— she suddenly recalled. —Lonnie will hate me, but yeah. I recall she mentioned a lot of victims' relatives have been asking for copies of those files in the past few months. Recently, Hordak signed a permit to copy the hunters files submitted as evidence.

—Oh, that's fantastic!

—I'll fill in the request form for you and once the copy is ready, I'll let you know.

—Thank you so much— Castaspella sighed, finally taking a sip of her tea.

As promised, Catra soon had the copy of the file for her. They agreed to visit the prison one last time to hand it to the guard, and then that would be all.

—This is… about Nicolás?

—Yes. Um… to summarize it, the Butcher Brothers killed him. They are already dead so there's not much else that can be done, but… I thought you may want to know. You *should* know.

—Thank you— she replied, giving Castaspella a sorrowful look. —They got what they deserved…— she muttered, looking at the file. —And… it was your partner who killed them, so… thanks, I guess?

—She was still a hunter for the longest time… There's nothing to thank.

—I-in any case, I actually had to contact you today; you saved me a lot of effort by coming here yourself.

—Oh, what is it about?— Castaspella asked, curious.

—Well, the Quee- I mean, your sister-in-law has been requesting to see you— she explained. —You have no obligation to visit her, of course, but I had to let you know.

—I-I see. Thank you— the physician stammered. —I might see her another day.

A week.

It took Castaspella a week to decide.

No matter how much Catra tried to convince her it was a bad idea, she insisted she should consider it and, eventually, decided to go.

Catra was far from thrilled.

Like it or not, Angella was a menace, and even looking from afar, the vampire shivered at the thought of the former Queen's powers.

However, that was exactly why she remained there, vigilant, instead of waiting outside like Castaspella offered.

It was a wise choice.

After a few minutes of civil discussion, Catra saw their demeanours suddenly change.

She couldn't hear a word, but she didn't need to. she just *knew* she had to approach.

As a warning.

She wouldn't leave Castaspella alone.

—Is there a problem?— she asked, folding her arms and standing behind the physician.

—No, of course not. We are just *talking*, right Angella?

—No— the angelic being denied, in a suspicious tone. —We're *done* talking.

Then… it all happened too fast.

Catra instinctively stepped back when Angella stood up, sudden goosebumps making her shut her eyes, anticipating the hit.

Yet it didn’t come.

When she opened her eyes again, Castaspella was standing between them, arms raised.

She didn’t even think; as the guards rushed to catch Angella, Catra grabbed the physician by the shoulders and took her outside at great speed.

Castaspella immediately leant back against the wall and slowly slid down until she was sitting on the floor.

—Fu-fuck…— she uttered, shaking as she stared at her arms, burnt all the way up to her elbows.

—Calm down, breathe— Catra told her, kneeling in front of her. Producing a jug from an inner pocket, she offered it to Castaspella, and told her —Drink.

—I…

—Drink first. It will help.

And it did. The burn marks visibly improved in seconds.

—That hurt… so bad.

—Hurt? I- Ah… It could have *destroyed me*— Catra realized. —You’re lucky to be *alive*.

—Maybe being a lesser vampire isn’t that bad— Castaspella tried to joke.

She wasn’t wrong…

Before she could reply, a familiar guard showed up.

—Oh, goodness, please tell me you’re okay.

—I am— Castaspella assured her, trying to smile.

—I am so sorry for what happened, I should have- I don't know, I should have ordered to keep Angella in handcuffs, or requested more security…

—Please, it’s not your fault.

—It’s my responsibility to keep visitors safe.

—Listen… It’s alright— the physician insisted, making an effort to stand up on her own. —But thank you for worrying… uh, what’s your name?

—Oh, right. I’m Maria.

—Thank you. We’ll get going… I doubt we’ll return.

—For your own good, I hope you won’t return — Maria seriously said, hands closed in fists.

Catra didn’t say a word, only nodded respectfully and encouraged Castaspella to start walking.

Now, the vampire feared how Shadow Weaver would react upon seeing those burns, and with all due reason…

She cursed internally, feeling like she should have been able to do more, feeling guilty… but so incredibly thankful to the physician.

This was one of the moments when she inevitably thought about Adora, the last time she saw her, and whether she would have been ready to never see her again…

She wasn't.

She would never be.

Shadow Weaver

Shadow Weaver spent a week trying to convince Castaspella not to visit Angella.

She did *not* deserve it, she was *not* to trust… and it was very out of the blue.

Suspicious, even.

But that may have been exactly why Castaspella decided to visit her regardless.

So now, the old vampire awaited her return while sipping some coffee… barely ten minutes after her last cup of tea.

She was just holding back from uncorking a bottle of wine…

When she heard the door, her first instinct was to think Castaspella was back.

Then fear crept up her chest as she recalled the state she was in the last time the physician didn't open herself.

Finally, she considered Catra would be yelling like back then if that was the case, which meant this was a visitor.

In the span of three seconds, the vampire went through all those different feelings until, relieved, she forced herself to be polite and check who it was.

—Ah, your Majesty— she smirked, opening the door for Glimmer. —If you're looking for your aunt, I'll have to disappoint you.

—Oh, I- Yeah. I hoped she'd be back from visiting Mom already and wanted to ask… I don't know…

—I suppose you can always wait for her here— Shadow Weaver resignedly offered.

She could almost hear Castaspella's voice chastising her if she told her to return another time.

—Oh! Yes, please! Thank you!— Glimmer perked up, surprised. —I didn't interrupt anything, right?

—Of course not— the old vampire dismissed her. —I was having coffee by myself. And… I suppose I should ask if you'd want anything, your Majesty?

—You don't have to…

—Casta would.

—You're not Auntie.

—Regardless: Do you or do you not want something to drink?

—Yes, please. Some tea would be alright— Glimmer sighed.

—In a minute.

The young Queen could hardly hide her discomfort.

And Shadow Weaver mercilessly took advantage of it.

She teased her for about an hour before the door finally opened.

—Auntie!— Glimmer exclaimed, sounding obviously relieved.

—Glimmer?

—What are you doing here, Sparkles?

—I learnt Auntie was going to visit Mom and… I needed to talk to you— she explained, standing from the couch to approach them. However, when she was about to hug Castaspella, she spotted the burn marks and gasped. —What's that!? What happened!?

—Your mother happened… and that's not a joke, unfortunately— Catra hissed.

—What!?— Shadow Weaver reacted, standing from her seat too. —Show me.

—It's nothing, alright? A few healing spells should fix it— Castaspella tried to dismisss it.

—Do you want some blood?

—I already had, Bea. Just help me with the spells.

—Catra, please tell me what happened?— Glimmer begged, while the old vampire busied herself healing her partner's arms.

—I mean, everything was fine at first. Your Mom was having a civilized chat with your aunt… And then not anymore— she began. —I walked up to them, afraid your mother would hurt her and- Well, maybe it was a bad idea… approaching, I mean.

—Why? What happened?

—Casta tried to keep things peaceful and said everything was fine, but Angella didn't agree and tried to… shoot me.

—What!? She- Tha-that would have killed you!

—Yeah— Catra sighed. Shadow Weaver glanced at her for a second, in time to see her ashamed expression as she looked away. —If she hadn't gotten in the middle…

—I don't understand— Glimmer uttered, holding her head between her hands. —I don't know my parents anymore.

—I'm sorry, Sparkles— she apologized, sitting on the couch with her.

Right then, Shadow Weaver considered it was enough healing for Castaspella, as her arms looked much better and she dismissed the spells.

—Thank you, my Love— the physician smiled, giving her a quick peck. —And I'm sorry too, Glim. I wish I knew what's happening with your parents.

—I may have an idea— the old vampire casually commented, sitting back on the remaining couch.

Castaspella followed her and sat on the armrest next to her, giving her a curious look.

—Care to share?

—I believe something made Angella paranoid.

—How so?— Glimmer further inquired, confused.

—Well, you see: your mother is thousands of years old. She lived the time of the invasion of the original vampires— she began. —After much effort, Mara ensured the truce with the vampire clones, enough that most left Etheria and the ones who remained pledged not to harm innocent people ever. And yet, despite knowing that, despite *being there*, something must have triggered the former Queen recently— she went on. —And by recently I mean in the last couple of decades, of course. So she restored the hunters.

—Out of fear— Glimmer realized.

—Indeed— Shadow Weaver nodded. —Whatever she told Micah convinced him of the righteousness of the cause, just like she did with every single member of the Alliance— she explained. —That's why all the hunters are convinced they are doing the right thing.

—Oh…— the young Queen sighed.

—People really need to think for themselves— Catra scoffed.

—Wait— Castaspella then uttered. —How- I-if Angella knew the vampire clones, how hasn't she realized Hordak is one of them? It should be obvious to her that he must be the leader of the Horde!

—Oh, I may have an idea about that— Catra chimed in. —I learnt last year that, about a thousand years ago or so, he changed his appearance enough to look completely different. Like, he pretends to be a descendant of the vampire clone who made the truce with Mara. He changed his white hair to blue, green eyes to red, and even his skin is much darker than before. So he's believed to be mortal; long-lived, but mortal.

Huh… Interesting.

—Unless, of course, Angella has always known but either refuses to acknowledge it or preferred not to act on her suspicions without proof— Shadow Weaver considered.

—As far as we know, the assassination attempt was only because he was leading the trial, not because they discovered anything about his nature— Catra clarified.

—The arrow had holy water. I can tell you, that's not just “standard”— the old vampire pointed out.

—So maybe they know…

—I seriously hope they don’t, Sparkles— Catra muttered. —It’s not the time yet.

—Regardless— Shadow Weaver said, calling attention back to her. —The point remains: Angella is clearly afraid, out of her mind, and unless she *somehow* realizes how wrong she is, she cannot be trusted with freedom— she sentenced. —Look what she did with what little freedom she had today! It’s clear her time in prison will end before her life, but unless she snaps out of her current mindset, I wouldn’t trust her with a single second of freedom.

—I suppose you're right— Castaspella sighed. —As for Micah, I really hope there’s still a chance he’ll see how unfounded Angella’s paranoia is and… eventually, accepts that I made my choice to become a vampire yet remain his sister.

—I’m so sorry, Auntie— Glimmer sobbed, her sniffing cutting her speech as she began crying.

—You have nothing to be sorry about, Dear— the physician replied, gentle.

Meanwhile, Catra seemed at a loss for words and only hugged the young Queen tightly, probably fighting tears of her own.

Shadow Weaver was starting to get uncomfortable.

She can't deal with such overwhelming feelings…

And she guessed Castaspella would soon start crying too if this went on.

—I just- I'm hardly keeping it together anymore— Glimmer began. —Without Mom and Dad, I am… I'm not alone but I'm so- I'm so lost! I have no idea what I'm supposed to be doing, yet I feel so *betrayed* by them!— she went on, raging. —After what they did! What they tried to do to one of my best friends! I'm so torn! I feel guilty for missing them but I know they deserve to be in jail- I *want them* to be there and never get out! Ugh!

—Glim… It's normal. I feel the same way. Part of me wants them back, but I also want them to atone for what they have been doing…— her aunt comforted her.

—I just can't believe they have either ordered the murder of so many, or even killed themselves so many people! I can't forgive that they got Bow involved, kept me in the dark, and even tried to rope Adora in too!

—I know…— Catra muttered, still hugging her and letting Glimmer cry on her shoulder.

—I'm sorry, I'm so sorry— she kept sobbing.

And then Shadow Weaver noticed it.

The faint glow around the young Queen.

—Catra— she called. —Release her.

—Huh?

—Get away from her. Now.

—What the fuck are you on!?— the young vampire questioned her, before suddenly jumping back on her seat. —Oh, shit! That burns!

—You must calm down, Glimmer— Shadow Weaver ordered. —Your powers are lethal for us.

—I-I don't- How do I- Ho-how do I calm down!?— she asked, noticeably scared.

—Breathe, control yourself, relax. You're safe here.

—Bea…— Castaspella then called her, claiming her attention back. —I don't… feel so well— she expressed, her voice faint.

—What are you feeling?

—Dizzy. A-and my arms…— she began, yet seemed unable to speak anymore.

She stood up from the couch's armrest, took a step towards the room, and the old vampire hardly managed to catch her before she hit the ground.

Eyes gone white, the physician laid limp.

—Fuck!

Shadow Weaver immediately picked her up, took her to the bed, and returned to the lounge.

—Did I do that!?— Glimmer asked, brushing away her tears.

—I'd say, yes— the old vampire aggressively spat.

—Ho-how!?

—I think she was sensitive still because of Angella's hit— Catra chimed in. —But your skin is burning for real, Sparkles— she admitted.

—I'm sorry— she whined.

—Don't be— Shadow Weaver scoffed. —Focus on calming down first.

—But, Auntie…

—I'll take care of her until she wakes up— she promised. —She will wake up. But… might need time. I don't- I'll do a check-up after seeing you out.

—Right— Catra nodded. —We should go. Come on— she accepted, encouraging Glimmer to follow her.

—I am really sorry— she uttered one last time, standing from the couch.

Unfortunately for Shadow Weaver, her check-up only told her one thing: there was nothing she could do to wake Castaspella up.

All she could do, was wait.

As a lesser vampire, the young physician would be perfectly able to bear a few days without food.

But… that only gave her so long, of course.

Yet, without knowing exactly what made Castaspella faint, and she couldn't figure it out, there was no way of waking her up either.

Shadow Weaver considered a lot of theories.

The powers of the former Queen were quite ancient, so she sought out all the information there was in the library. She asked Catra to get her all the books she needed, interrogate Glimmer, and send a message to Mystacor's Health Institution that Castaspella was… indisposed.

But after many attempts at somehow waking up the young physician, she had to admit defeat.

The young Queen's panic grew as days passed, and the old vampire no longer knew what to do.

She, too, was panicking… It didn't help, of course, but she was hardly in control of her emotions.

Shadow Weaver hated love for many reasons… and the feeling of uselessness she was now experiencing only reinforced the idea that she was right to despise it.

Now more than ever, she needed Castaspella to give her a reason not to give up on everything.

Chapter End Notes

And so, with this chapter done, only the last three remain!!!!!!

I'm so excited!!!

Ahem, so! Maria! (mind u, that's my mother's name, I wanna see no comments about it being "too common of a name")
I don't know why the muse decided to introduce her to the story, but here she is!!!
Don't forget her!!
She'll be quite relevant for this last trio of chapters!!
-> "But, but, she only appeared like two paragraphs"
IMPORTANT, I SAID!! XD

And, uh, yeah, I'm warning u since now, but I'll repeat it next week, Ch 10's second part, aka, SW's part, is *heavy*. I mean it. The very last tag of this fic is for that chapter, and while that sounds like a spoiler, I rather spoil tiny details than hit u with that chapter out of the damned blue <("^_^)

~~Casually brushes over Castaspella's new ailment~~

Anyways!!!! See you next week! I hope u enjoyed! Bye!!!

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

Welcome back, everyone!

Well, today's chapter is *special*
Both in a good and a bad way, I guess…

Also, the art of Hordak from the art gallery is from the first scene :D
(a note on the art gallery, I'm still waiting for the remaining art, but I'm still giving the artist time to finish, there's no rush ^-^)

Also also, this is the chapter for which the last tag in the fic was added. So, I wanted to make it clear that SW's part is kinda dark but eases at the end 🙂

Now yes, without further ado, I hope u enjoy :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

It had been a few days already… She should have woken up, but didn't.

Catra felt like a failure.

—There has to be something, Boss— she insisted, pacing around Hordak's office. —What could have happened to her!? Are the former Queen's powers…

—Angella's powers aren't something I can tell you much about— he interrupted, speaking calmly as he stood from his chair behind his desk. —I know about Mara's powers, yes, because she explained them to me herself. But Angella never trusted me or my brothers…

—A-alright, but… there's no information about her powers in any books either!?

—Catra. Getting all worked up won't help Castaspella— he first said.

—I know!

—If there was anything I could do, I would have already done so— he insisted. —Remember that *I* put you in charge of keeping her safe.

—And I'm failing!

—Not yet— he denied. —I trust she will be fine; she's part of something bigger than any of us, after all— he pointed out. —And you have been fulfilling your job to the best of your capabilities. I am well aware.

—Tha-thank you, Judge.

—I am only stating facts. I can't ask from you more than you can do.

Catra swallowed hard, looking at the ground, and nodded.

She then cleared her throat and asked —So, what should I do now?

Hordak sighed deeply.

—There isn't much we can do.

—I am not giving up.

—Neither am I. There is only one thing I can think of when it comes to waking Castaspella up from the coma induced by Angella's powers… but I believe that won't be achievable right now.

—I don't understand.

—Mara had healing powers that once saved me…— he revealed, towering over her. —I am sure Adora would be able to do the same… if she knew how.

—A-Adora has been reading that old book non-stop since I told her what happened, precisely because she knows she can heal but not *how*.

—Then maybe there's still a chance.

—I wish, but she made no progress at all— Catra sighed.

—Give her time— Hordak smirked. —Chief Adora is Castaspella's counterpart. They are destined to repeat history, to go through a similar path to that of Mara and me.

—So… Should I maybe take Adora to see Casta?

—That could very well work, yes— he nodded, pensive. —But you must understand that the powers of She-Ra remain passively harmful for you.

—Well, yeah, but…

—Castaspella, as a lesser vampire, is immune, just like me. For us, being in the presence of She-Ra doesn't represent a risk. For you, it is. Only if Adora *wanted* to hurt us, would she do as much. But for you, she cannot control it.

—I know…

—I point this out because your involvement could get you killed— he insisted, severe. —You need to think clearly, with a level head. Trust Adora and Casta.

—I trust them.

—Good— he smirked.

Catra returned home for lunch and was surprised to find Adora cooking.

—Hey, Dor! What are you doing here?

—I took the day off— she sighed, stirring the boiling water of what looked like pasta. —I hoped you'd come home now, actually.

—Here I am— the vampire smirked. —Was there anything you needed me for?

—I want to visit Castaspella, if you don't mind.

—Oh- I actually spoke to the Judge today. He thinks you can heal her- that you're *destined* to do so, actually.

—Re-really?

—Well, yeah— she nodded, looking away. —She-Ra's power should be able to. You were right.

—But how?

—I don't know. He said you just needed time— Catra explained. —Maybe visiting her is a good idea.

—I'll take the book and try a few things… I'm just a bit scared of hurting her instead.

—Well, if you mean your passive power, don't worry. Hordak says Casta is immune to it since she's a lesser vampire.

—Just like him for being a vulture.

—Exactly.

—Well, but… I mean, I feel like She-Ra's power, like all the other princesses' powers, are basically *designed* to kill vampires. So, how can I trust healing powers won't make things worse?

—They are healing for a reason.

—O-of course, but…— Adora was arguing back, yet had to interrupt herself when the boiling water raised to the top of the pot. —Shit! One second.

—Let me help— Catra offered, smiling softly. —Just trust yourself, Dor— she gently muttered, holding the wooden spoon for her.

That afternoon, after lunch, the couple went to visit the physicians.

Catra wouldn’t admit it to Adora, but she was relieved to be accompanied this time.

Since Castaspella fell into that comatose state, she had been extremely uncomfortable alone with Shadow Weaver.

Yeah, she wasn’t a hunter anymore and whatever, but she was… so difficult to interact with!

So unpleasant, constantly trying to be the best, smartest person in the room.

She claimed not to be a threat anymore, but for the young vampire, she still felt like one.

Yet, perhaps, Catra had nothing to admit… after all, it seemed like Adora already knew.

The moment the door opened, her fiancée stood firmly between the vampires.

—Chief… Afternoon.

—Good afternoon, Shadow Weaver— she politely replied, nodding at her and sounding calm.

However, Catra could hear the tension in her voice, and noticed Adora's grip on her book tighten.

—To what do I owe the visit?

—Ah… I'm here to see Casta— she sighed.

—Of course— the vampire let out, albeit seemingly annoyed. —Come in— she finally invited them.

Catra took a deep breath and followed her fiancée inside, waited for Shadow Weaver to close the door, and then allowed her into the bedroom where Castaspella laid, as if asleep.

This was the first time that damned woman let her see the physician again.

—Alright, so… I've brought this book about my powers because I'm supposed to have healing magic but… I don't know how She-Ra works, I don't really know if those healing powers can wake her up, but Judge Hordak seems to think so, and… even if I still have no idea how to use them, I wanted to try— Adora explained, speaking quickly, as if afraid to be interrupted.

—That's quite *nice* of you, Chief. But it's been days and she remains unresponsive to absolutely everything.

—You can still let her *try*— Catra hissed, unable to believe Shadow Weaver was *rejecting* a potential cure.

—What if I don't want to?— the old vampire scoffed. —What if I refuse to let someone who is *not* in full control of her powers, *use* said powers on *my* unconscious partner!?

—Wait…

—She could *save her*.

—Catra…

—Or she could *kill her*.

—Hey!

—Hordak says she's immune to She-Ra's passive power…

—Guys!

—I couldn't give enough of a fuck about what Hordak says right now— Shadow Weaver spat.

—You're being stubborn!— Catra barked. —Casta protected me, even though it was *my* duty to protect *her*! This could save her and you'll refuse!?

—Love, you would have died on the spot!— Adora tried to remind her, despite being ignored the last four times she tried to interject.

—So you admit this is all your fault! You caused this, and I want you out of my house!

—Don't you think I fucking know!? I already feel guilty enough!— the young vampire yelled, voice almost breaking.

She just *had to*!

Of all the things she could say…

—Okay, you both, *I said stop*!— Adora finally managed to intervene, once again getting physically between them. —I am *not* letting you two tear each other apart! And, do I *really* have to remind you that Casta wouldn't want you two fighting!?

—I…

—Catra, you *need* to stop blaming yourself— she began, looking back at her. —You know Casta wouldn't blame you; she made the choice to protect you, and she *survived*. You wouldn't have!

—Ye-yeah, you're right, Dor…

—And you— she went on, sight fixed on Shadow Weaver now. —I understand you're *scared*, afraid that Casta won't wake up— she calmly told her.

—What could *you* possibly know!?

—Enough— Adora insisted. —I live in fear of something happening to Catra; I can't even imagine how *I* would be acting if I were in your place and my fiancée was the one unconscious— she elaborated, hardly disguising the anguish in her voice.

—Right…

—I am *so sorry* I don't know how to use my healing powers. I wish I could better understand this stupid book— she admitted, angry now. —But I don't, and you're right, it's dangerous. So I respect your decision of not… wanting to let me straight up experiment…

She couldn't really be… giving up!?

Shadow Weaver let out a long sigh, brushed her hands down her face, and sat down on the bed at Castaspella's feet.

She looked like she was considering it… and Catra certainly hoped she was.

At least she wasn't trying to kick her out anymore.

After a few tense, silent minutes, the old vampire sighed —Alright. Tell me more about those healing powers first.

—I only know She-Ra can heal. But… not how it works, regardless of what the book says.

—Can I see the book?

Adora hesitantly passed her the book, saying —It's all there. But I doubt you can read it…

Shadow Weaver looked incredulous until the moment she opened it at a random page.

—Fine. No, I can't— she admitted, looking away with the book still on her lap. —You'll have to read it to me.

—A-alright— Adora stammered. —What part?

—Anything about the source of your powers?

—Here… This chapter— she explained, quickly passing the pages. She then picked the book up, and read —"She-Ra's powers are granted by Etheria itself. They are the forces of nature. As such, they can only be controlled by a strong, unwavering will." So, basically, I'm not strong enough or something…

—No, no. That's not it— Shadow Weaver quickly denied, looking at the distance, pensive. —Your powers are… similar to that of the princesses… But without a runestone— she realized. —Etheria itself works as the runestone, Chief.

—A-alright? What does that mean? How do I control it?

Catra could see something shining in Shadow Weaver's eyes… and she didn't like it.

—It means, your powers may have the same lethal capacity as the princesses' against vampires, but just like with them, not all your powers are— she began, still lost in whatever mindscape she may be imagining. —Hence, to control it, you must focus on the right emotion…

—How!?— Adora insisted, anxious.

Finally, the old vampire looked back at her.

—It's not a destructive power, so you must remain calm. You have to be relaxed and focused on healing, not destroying— she explained, standing up from the bed and gesturing at Adora to approach Castaspella.

—O-okay? A-and is there any way…— she began asking, glancing back at Catra for a second, —To use that power without transforming?

—I doubt it— she denied. —You go ahead and transform… I'll keep your fiancée safe.

—Are you sure?

—Yes— she insisted. —I'll protect us with a spell to shield from the sun, and I know Casta will be fine since she's not affected by sunlight.

—Right— Adora finally accepted. —Ready?

Catra looked back at the old vampire just in time to see her subtly cast something, and felt a shiver run through her body.

Yes, that was definitely magic…

And she recalled this sensation from that night in the library.

—Yeah…

—Okay, here goes— Adora muttered, before focusing for a second.

Then a light flashed and She-Ra appeared in her place.

Without a word, Adora knelt next to the bed, a golden light enveloped her, then moved onto the physician, and lasted for a while.

Catra was holding her breath the whole time, not wanting to disrupt the process, and looking for signs of Castaspella waking up.

Eventually, the golden light receded.

—Di-did it work?

—I… think so— Adora said, transforming back and sighing in relief. —I felt something, like residual energy and… I think it's gone now.

—Then, why isn't she waking up?

—Because she's exhausted— Shadow Weaver explained, before Adora could. —She was fighting it, wasn't she?

—Kind of… I'm not sure what that was— Adora admitted. —But… She'll wake up soon, I'm sure.

She would wake up.

She would…

—Adora— Catra called. —You saved her.

—Yeah, I think…

—No, you- I mean, you didn't hurt her! She-Ra isn't just a vampire killer!— she explained, excited.

—Oh… *Oh*! You're right!

Adora rushed forward to hug Catra, and they both held each other tightly for a moment, unable to believe it.

—Angella was wrong, Dor.

—Yeah…

The relief that washed over them almost made them forget where they were.

Until they heard a whine.

—Casta!— the three of them exclaimed, just as the physician slowly opened her eyes.

Shadow Weaver

For the past few days, Shadow Weaver had been following standard routine to keep Castaspella in good condition.

It was getting tiring, and… more difficult to bear.

Early in the morning, she had connected a serum bag to the intravenous catheter she put on her a few days before, added a few drops of blood to the serum, and took her breakfast to the bed.

She liked to keep her company as much as possible…

But then again, this was getting more and more difficult.

She had also been using spells on her to keep the young physician clean but… she would need a real bath soon.

Shadow Weaver was really trying to focus on Castaspella, and yet she couldn't help thinking about herself in all of this.

She was…

She was *suffering*.

She had dreamt she spoke to Castaspella the previous night.

In the dream, her partner would tell her to take care of herself first. To let her sleep. That everything was fine.

But the old vampire knew it was *not* true.

As a physician, she had so many concerns other people wouldn't have…

As a physician, she didn't want to give up. She couldn't.

But as a partner, she felt… defeated.

Up to what point could she keep her alive, and when did it only become dragging the innevitable and torturing a dying woman?

She had been turned so this wouldn't happen…

Now this was happening *because* she had been turned…

This was her fault.

Shadow Weaver laid next to her after having breakfast and almost lost track of time.

She did nothing for hours other than stare at Castaspella, wondering what she'd say.

Would she speak like the vision in her dream?

No… there was no way.

But then…

It couldn't be, no. Shadow Weaver refused to give up, yet also refused to continue with this insanity.

She had to make a choice.

But maybe that could wait until she had lunch.

Since the old vampire had no energy to cook, she grabbed some leftovers and sat at the table this time.

She needed time alone to think. If she went to eat in the room, she'd probably lose her appetite.

So she slowly ate her lunch, considered Castaspella's situation carefully and objectively, and told herself to decide.

Until her feelings took over.

As reason was discarded in favour of sentimentality, her thoughts spiraled into despair.

Should she give up?

Could she abandon Castaspella?

Would it be abandoning her or a mercy?

Maybe she was suffering?

And what then?

Would she have the strength to live for eternity *without* her?

She considered joining Castaspella instead, but… would she have the courage to end her life?

Her pride wouldn't let her, for sure…

Besides, she wouldn't admit it, but that night Micah almost killed her, despite her defiance, she was genuinely afraid to die…

Yet it wasn't losing her life what scared her the most, but rather leaving Castaspella alone and exposed to the danger of the hunters.

It was her.

She had made her life worth living.

So maybe… it *was* time to give up, and go with her.

That was her decision.

Little after washing the dishes, Shadow Weaver began preparing.

She took the catheter off Castaspella's arm, threw the empty serum bag, laid next to her, and wrapped her arms around her.

She'd stop everything, wait for the inevitable to happen, and then end her own life.

Meanwhile, she'd have time to leave a note or something for the police to find. She'd walk into the sun unprotected, leaving her home, triggering her anklet so they would show up at her place…

That was the plan.

She was mentally going over it while hugging her partner when she heard knocking on the door.

How annoying…

Grunting, she got up and checked through the window.

Chief Adora and her fiancée.

How quaint.

Hoping she could get rid of them quickly, Shadow Weaver opened the door.

The first thing she noticed was the protective stance with which Adora had positioned herself in front of Catra.

—Chief… Afternoon— she briskly said, dismissing the thought.

—Good afternoon, Shadow Weaver— she politely replied, nodding at her calmly.

Barely sparing a look at the book the young woman carried, she asked —To what do I owe the visit?

—Ah… I'm here to see Casta— she sighed.

Just *great*…

—Of course. Come in— she finally invited them.

The old vampire moved aside, waited for them to walk into the lounge and then closed the door. Without a word, she gestured at the open door of the bedroom, and followed them inside.

It didn't escape her that Catra looked quite relieved… She hadn't let her see Castaspella the past few days, after all…

Finally, her attention was attracted by Chief Adora.

—Alright, so… I've brought this book about my powers because I'm supposed to have healing magic but… I don't know how She-Ra works, I don't really know if those healing powers can wake her up, but Judge Hordak seems to think so, and… even if I still have no idea how to use them, I wanted to try— she explained, speaking quickly as if afraid to be interrupted.

Well, it's a shame she already made a choice.

And this sounded too experimental for her taste.

—That's quite *nice* of you, Chief. But it's been days and she remains unresponsive to absolutely everything.

—You can still let her *try*— Catra hissed.

—What if I don't want to?— the old vampire scoffed. She was *not* going to tolerate this. —What if I refuse to let someone who is *not* in full control of her powers, *use* said powers on *my* unconscious partner!?

—Wait…

—She could *save her*.

—Catra…

—Or she could *kill her*.

—Hey!

—Hordak says she's immune to She-Ra's passive power…

—Guys!

—I couldn't give enough of a fuck about what Hordak says right now— Shadow Weaver spat, angry enough she could kick that girl out of the house if she said another word.

—You're being stubborn!— Catra barked back. How irreverent. —Casta protected me, even though it was *my* duty to protect *her*! This could save her and you'll refuse!?

—Love, you would have died on the spot!— Adora interceded, before Shadow Weaver could reply, still trying to defuse the situation despite all her failed attempts at calming them down.

But the old vampire was sick of Catra already.

—So you admit this is all your fault! You caused this, and I want you out of my house!

—Don’t you think I fucking know!? I already feel guilty enough!— the young vampire yelled, voice almost breaking.

So what? Would she cry now?

Pathetic.

—Okay, you both, *I said stop*!— Adora finally managed to intervene, once again getting physically between them. —I am *not* letting you two tear each other apart! And, do I *really* have to remind you that Casta wouldn’t want you two fighting!?

—I…— Catra hesitated, yet couldn’t say a thing.

This was getting annoying.

She had a plan already! Why did these two have to show up!?

—Catra, you *need* to stop blaming yourself— she began, looking back at her. —You know Casta wouldn’t blame you; she made the choice to protect you, and she *survived*. You wouldn’t have!

—Ye-yeah, you’re right, Dor…

—And you— she went on, sight fixed on Shadow Weaver now. —I understand you’re *scared*, afraid that Casta won’t wake up— she calmly told her.

How dared she- Scared!?

She loathed the feeling, but “scared” didn’t even begin to cover it.

—What could *you* possibly know!?

—Enough— Adora insisted. —I live in fear of something happening to Catra; I can’t even imagine how *I* would be acting if I were in your place and my fiancée was the one unconscious— she elaborated, hardly disguising the anguish in her voice.

—Right…

No, this kid had no idea… She couldn’t have.

—I am *so sorry* I don’t know how to use my healing powers. I wish I could better understand this stupid book— she admitted, angry now. —But I don’t, and you’re right, it’s dangerous. So I respect your decision of not… wanting to let me straight up experiment…

Good!

Now they should leave her in peace!

Alone…

To die with her partner…

Unless that book… had something she didn’t know about?

Shadow Weaver let out a long sigh, brushed her hands down her face, and sat down on the bed at Castaspella's feet.

What if- It could be nothing, but… what if it was?

It would be… *unwise* not to give this one last chance…

For Castaspella.

After a few tense, silent minutes, the old vampire sighed —Alright. Tell me more about those healing powers first.

—I only know She-Ra can heal. But… not how it works, regardless of what the book says.

Now she was curious.

—Can I see the book?

Adora hesitantly passed her the book, saying —It's all there. But I doubt you can read it…

Really? As if she were stupid…

Shadow Weaver looked incredulous until the moment she opened it at a random page.

She maybe was… a bit out of her league.

—Fine. No, I can't— she admitted, looking away with the book still on her lap. —You'll have to read it to me.

—A-alright— Adora stammered. —What part?

—Anything about the source of your powers?

—Here… This chapter— she explained, quickly passing the pages. She then picked the book up, and read —"She-Ra's powers are granted by Etheria itself. They are the forces of nature. As such, they can only be controlled by a strong, unwavering will." So, basically, I'm not strong enough or something…

Oh, Adora had no idea, did she?

She almost wanted to laugh.

But she had to focus on what mattered now. This wasn't as much of a foreign magic as she had thought before.

This was something she could *work with*.

—No, no. That's not it— Shadow Weaver quickly denied, looking at the distance, pensive. —Your powers are… similar to that of the princesses… But without a runestone— she realized. —Etheria itself works as the runestone, Chief.

Which made her… incredibly *powerful*.

—A-alright? What does that mean? How do I control it?

—It means, your powers may have the same lethal capacity as the princesses' against vampires, but just like with them, not all your powers are— she began, thinking about all the things that could be done with such magic. —Hence, to control it, you must focus on the right emotion…

—How!?— Adora insisted, anxious.

Shadow Weaver finally looked back at her, returning to reality, and stood up from the bed.

She gestured at the Chief to approach the physician while explaining —It's not a destructive power, so you must remain calm. You have to be relaxed and focused on healing, not destroying.

—O-okay? A-and is there any way…— she began asking, glancing back at Catra for a second, —To use that power without transforming?

—I doubt it— she denied. —You go ahead and transform… I'll keep your fiancée safe.

—Are you sure?

—Yes— she insisted. Castaspella would kill her otherwise… supposing she could wake her up. —I'll protect us with a spell to shield from the sun, and I know Casta will be fine since she's not affected by sunlight.

—Right— Adora finally accepted. —Ready?

The young vampire looked back at Shadow Weaver just as she cast the little spell, and she could see her fur standing on end.

—Yeah…— Catra confirmed.

—Okay, here goes— Adora muttered, before focusing for a second.

Then a light flashed and She-Ra appeared in her place.

Without a word, Adora knelt next to the bed, a golden light enveloped her, then moved onto the physician, and lasted for a while.

What could she be doing?

It seemed like she was searching for something.

Was it working?

Hope suddenly took over her and she swallowed hard…

She really had been thinking about ending it all for the both of them.

She almost made a huge mistake.

Castaspella wasn't really suffering, was she?

She was *trying* to wake up.

Eventually, the golden light receded.

—Di-did it work?— Catra stammered.

—I… think so— Adora said, transforming back and sighing in relief. —I felt something, like residual energy and… I think it's gone now.

—Then, why isn't she waking up?

—Because she's exhausted— Shadow Weaver explained, before Adora could. —She was fighting it, wasn't she?

—Kind of… I'm not sure what that was— Adora admitted. —But… She'll wake up soon, I'm sure.

—Adora— Catra called. —You saved her.

—Yeah, I think…

—No, you- I mean, you didn't hurt her! She-Ra isn't just a vampire killer!— she explained, excited.

—Oh… *Oh*! You're right!

While the couple hugged, Shadow Weaver sat next to Castaspella, caressing her hair, her cheek.

She needed her to wake up.

The old vampire closed her eyes tightly, not wanting to cry, and then… opened them again as soon as she heard a whine.

—Casta!— the three of them exclaimed, just as the physician slowly opened her eyes.

She-Ra had… saved her.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that's all for today!! :D

I hope you liked the chapter, don't worry, Casta is fine now, and uh, hopefully u'll also like the next two chapters!! (ch 12 is half-way there, I promise)

ALSO! A bit of a funfact: today's Argentina's Independence Day!! Wooh!! So I'll be free all day, drink hot chocolate and eat traditional pastries :D
~~Well, maybe there aren't any more pastries left at the bakery by now :(~~

Anyways! The next two chapters will be LOADED, and I can't wait to post them!! But… see you next week :D

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

Hi, hi!!
So sorry for the delay, I normally post earlier *before* work, but this time I had ✨issues✨ and couldn't, so here I am now <("^_^)

I can't believe this is almost done!!! ~~And the end of Ch12 isn't TT-TT~~

Anyways, I hope you enjoy, and see you at the end notes!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

As the young vampire woke up, she found herself in Adora's embrace and happily rested for a little while longer.

She was comfortable and relaxed, which was rare lately.

Just a few weeks before, Adora had managed to somehow wake up Castaspella, proving that She-Ra is not a vampire killer only, and giving them much-needed hope.

Catra had been wondering what this could mean for them. Obviously it was good news, but what did it entail?

Well, perhaps she'd eventually find out.

Hopefully not the hard way…

But, for now, she could relax a bit.

Since Castaspella had returned to work almost immediately, to avoid suspicions for the most part, she had instead chosen to take the day off today, and that meant Catra could too!

Hence, she and Adora had planned to visit Glimmer at the palace and have lunch together with her and Bow.

Just like she wanted…

After having a light breakfast, the couple got changed and prepared everything to leave.

They hadn't visited the palace in a long time, almost two years, and it was bringing back memories…

They couldn't imagine how Glimmer was feeling…

And her coronation; she had delayed it until the trials finished, which was estimated to be in about three months.

She was the Queen, acted as such, was recognized as such, but the formal ceremony had yet to take place.

Oh, and there was also her marriage.

She didn’t want the coronation to happen until they both could be crowned.

Catra could understand that, but she couldn’t help feeling a bit guilty about it all.

She wasn’t to blame, and yet she felt like it had been her fault.

—Hey— Adora gently called her. —You alright?

—Ye-yeah— Catra stammered. —It’s been a while since the last time.

—I know— she sighed. —But there’s… no danger now, Glimmer needs us… I’m sure we’ll have a great time with our friends, alright?

—I hope so.

With a sad smile, Catra pressed on and they reached the palace entrance.

Food was ready soon enough, but since arriving, the four friends had been talking non-stop about absolutely trivial matters.

They were all… dodging the important subjects…

Namely, the coronation. And the wedding…

But everyone knew it'd be inevitable.

—So, you know… I've been thinking about it, and I think- Well, *we* have been thinking and decided we'll be marrying next month, or the next one… but like, privately.

—Oh, really?— Adora reacted, surprised.

—We won't be doing any grand party or anything. It'll be just a gathering with close friends and family… I just- It's too difficult to think about doing anything else without Mom and Dad— Glimmer explained. —I mean- You remember Mom wanted to plan my wedding…

—Yeah…— Catra nodded. —So you'll marry but keep it low-profile?

—Exactly.

—Well, it's your decision, guys. No one can force you to do anything grandiose if you don't want to, nor feel like it— Adora assured them. —But we'll be there— she smiled.

—Thanks, guys.

—Yeah, thanks— Bow added, with a sad smile. —And sorry for all the trouble.

—There's nothing to apologize for— Catra assured him. —You, least of all. You've been doing a lot we should thank you for— she insisted.

—Yeah, but… I shouldn't- I never should have agreed to join the hunters in the first place.

—It was not your fault that Micah was basically blackmailing you!— Adora scoffed, indignant.

—Yeah. I've told you before; I know you did it all for me, and it's probably for the best that you just went along with Dad's requests— Glimmer assured him. —I know- I know you did it out of love for me, not out of desire to kill vampires— she went on. —And much as I'm conflicted about Mom and Dad, I'm far from conflicted about you, Bow— she smiled, taking his hand.

—Thank you, Glim— he uttered, ashamed.

—Come on, don't make that face…— she giggled, pecking him on the cheek. —Food's coming, we shouldn't let it go cold!

After finishing their meal, the four spent some extra time sitting around the table, now drinking some coffee, and discussed a few more matters.

—So, you want to… make vampires, what? Legal citizens?— Catra asked.

—That's a way to put it. I-I mean, I want you all to be legally recognized as members of the kingdom and to be protected by the law— Glimmer explained.

—Which also means having to register as vampires.

—Yes. I know it sounds a bit uncomfortable, but for the law to protect you, you *need* to be recognized first, and registry is the only way. It wouldn't be mandatory, I think it's better to leave it as something voluntary, and of course there would be no punishments for not registering. The problem there would be that if anyone attempted against an unregistered vampire's life, there wouldn't be much the Court can do.

—Oh, I know that very well— Catra admitted. —I think it's a good idea, but you need to frame it carefully so it won't make vampires feel even more alien than we already feel.

—Of course! I actually wanted to discuss this with Judge Hordak if possible. Not only because he's a vulture and leader of the Horde, but also because, as a judge, I think he'll be well suited to polish this idea.

—Oh, that's… a good plan, yes.

—Is there anything wrong, Love?— Adora asked, concerned.

—No, no. I just… *Wow*. I never thought this day would come— she admitted.

—I'm actually so glad this will happen— Bow sighed. —I think it will be the final nail in the coffin for the hunters. It will protect everyone, not just vampires— he reflected.

—That's the intention, yes— Glimmer confirmed.

—I like it— Catra smirked. —If you have any drafts ready, I can take it to Hordak. But, if it's easier, maybe I can arrange a meeting for you two— she offered.

—Both work. I have been mapping a few points I think are important, but I certainly need another set of eyes, especially from within the vampire community, to make sure I cover all relevant aspects— she smiled.

—It's a deal, Sparkles. I'll help you— Catra promised.

Within a few months, the trial finally reached a conclusion, the hunters and the former regents got their formal sentences to be served in jail for a *very* long time, and the new regents were finaly crowned.

As they wanted, their wedding took place around three weeks before the final verdict and, since being private, it was only made public when the coronation was announced.

Right after, Glimmer's first resolution as crowned Queen was the recognition of the vampire community, along with the banning of the hunters' alliance.

And, of course, as expected, vampire registration was slow at first.

It took a few weeks for the first vampires to finally dare go public; namely, Catra and Shadow Weaver. The revelation was quite the news, of course, and made it to the front page of the newspapers, the prime time of the radios, and revived the interest on the hunters' trial. The public opinion on Shadow Weaver, that had been so bad, became just slightly better.

Not much tho.

And then Catra was surprised to know most of the Court's vampires were encouraged by her registration to do it too.

Hordak's registration, however, was private.

The public wouldn't learn of his true nature unless explicitly requesting the information.

But things actually improved for them.

It was… like a brand-new world for Catra and her fellow vampires.

Maybe, just maybe, the incident that night was only fate.

Unfortunately, it wasn't long before the cruelty of reality returned.

Despite the ban on hunter activities, despite the public opinion mostly agreeing with the Queen and supporting the right of vampires to live in peace, there were… dissidents.

And such people, while not exactly numerous, were far from harmless.

Catra arrived home one night, after following Castaspella all day, and flopped down on the couch, wanting to cry.

The last two weeks, almost every day, Mystacor's Health Institution had been receiving victims of brutal attacks.

She couldn't believe it.

Vampires and mortals alike kept being targeted.

In fact, she knew Adora would arrive late that night, again, due to how many reports of these attacks flooded her desk.

But she was so tired, drained, she really needed her now.

After a while of doing absolutely nothing, she finally pushed herself up from the couch and went to prepare dinner so Adora would have something when she arrived.

As anticipated, that happened well past midnight…

—Home at last— she sighed, as soon as she closed the door.

—Hey, Dor— Catra greeted her, approaching to help her out of her jacket. —How was your day?

—Like yesterday, an absolute nightmare.

—I imagined…

—It's really getting worse— she lamented. —There are so many cases, and…

—I know, I saw many of the victims the past few days.

—Right— she realized. —I'm so sorry.

—I don't understand how this is happening.

—Well, I can explain a bit— Adora offered. —Apparently, there’s a group of anti-vampire individuals who… have been attacking all these people, both vampires and mortals they believed to be vampires too.

—I gathered as much.

—Well, they seem to be organizing, which is a problem. And… I think it’s getting worse lately because another group is raising to counter them. They support vampires, most seem to be relatives or friends of people who have been turned, which may have only provoked those anti-vampires.

—So… why do they…

—The few anti-vampires we've managed to arrest all seemed paranoid. Like, awfully scared and convinced that you're a threat and that a vampire might attack them at any moment— Adora explained, groaning a bit. —Some even said there must be vampires in my Station, waiting to kill them.

—Oh, so they go and attack anyone they suspect!? Hunter's rebranded!— she scoffed, rolling her eyes.

—Yeah…— she sighed. —I'm actually scared of how things are escalating, and while the group of supporters are mainly helping victims get medical attention and fill in the reports, there are also some… uh, armed members who insist they must do anything in their power to protect their loved ones.

—Which is as extremist as the hunters, yeah— Catra concluded. —I'm sorry you're having to deal with this— she added, embracing her fiancée.

—I think Glimmer did the right thing, though— Adora smiled, hugging her back. —So many vampires ended up registering, they trust us, and their families all seemed relieved… Until this started happening, of course, but… now they can at least resort to us, get help— she pointed out.

—I'm glad, trust me, but… I guess I'm afraid.

—And that's reasonable— she assured her. —Just- Let's trust we can solve this by the right means — she told her, releasing her to look her in the eyes.

—I just hope it won't spiral out of control— Catra uttered, glancing away.

—I won't let that happen— Adora insisted, holding her hands. She then leant forward, touching their foreheads together. —I promise.

Shadow Weaver

After being healed by Adora's power, Castaspella returned to work as soon as the following day.

She didn't want to wait any longer since learning she'd been out for *days*.

Shadow Weaver could understand that, but she also needed to talk with her, tell her what she… was going to do. So she convinced her of taking a day to rest the following week, at least.

Castaspella promised to do as much, and the old vampire mentally prepared to be honest with her.

Yet the week was too busy to "take a day", and the physician delayed her day off for another week.

Fine, fine. She could wait.

Maybe…

However, when the physician had a second ultra-busy week, Shadow Weaver began to consider she maybe couldn't.

Fortunately, after only two weeks and a half, Castaspella finally took a day off.

The day had come, and the old vampire was *not* ready at all.

Just great.

After hardly any sleep through the night, Shadow Weaver got up early and prepared breakfast as quietly as possible to take it to bed. Some coffee, a bowl of congee that Castaspella loved so much, toasts, fruits, cheese… and back to the bedroom she went.

—Good morning…— she smiled, seeing Castaspella awake already.

—Good mor- Did you just… smile and say *good* morning!?

—I did…

—Oh my Stars, Bea. What's wrong?

—Wrong?

—You've been strange the past few weeks, and I supposed it was because I- Well, because you didn't know if I would wake up again. But… now it's been weeks!— Castaspella argued, sitting up.

Shadow Weaver left the tray at the feet of the bed, sat next to her, but couldn't hold her sight.

—What if I said… I have something to tell you, related to what happened, that I should have told you right away?

—Bea, you-you're scaring me. What happened? Breakfast can wait, just *talk to me*.

—Yes, we have to talk.

—What happened?

—Remember how… uh… that Chief Adora and Catra simply showed up here wanting to try She-Ra's healing power and that saved you?

—Yes?

—Well, I never had a chance to tell you… what happened right before they decided to show up. What-what I would have done if they hadn't…

—What do you mean?

—A-are you sure you don't want to eat first?

—Bea…

—Alright— she sighed. —I'll quit delaying it: I was giving up. I was- I had just taken off the catheter from your arm, and was putting everything in order to just… let things run its course, and… follow you afterwards.

—What do you- You… were going to- You…

—Would let you die and kill myself afterwards— Shadow Weaver confirmed, looking down.

Of course, Castaspella was understandably shocked.

The old vampire expected her to move away, disgusted, or to get angry and yell at her, to accuse her of being an awful partner or not loving her enough…

—Bea, why?— she sobbed.

—Nothing worked— she began, still looking down and sounding… weak. —No matter what I did, what I tried, nothing woke you up. I could hardly take it anymore. I felt like I was just… torturing you.

—No, wait… I meant, why were *you* going to…

—I thought about it a lot. I cannot continue my *eternal* existence without you. Not anymore— she sighed. —I used to have absolutely nothing tying me to life, just lived out of spite, for the most part. Then… Micah almost killed me, and I could only think about how I *didn't* want to die. *For you*. I wanted to stay alive *to keep you safe*.

—My love…— Castaspella uttered, reaching for her face and cupping her cheek tenderly. —You- Ah… You can't make me, or anyone other than yourself, your reason to live on— she told her, a single tear falling.

—I don't- You don't have to feel like you're responsible for me living on or not. Just… I never cared whether I lived or died, until you came around and I realized I couldn't keep you safe if I died— she smirked, with a hint of sorrow. —Even if we weren't a couple… I would still want to make sure you're alright. But without you in this world… Why would I want to stay?

—Bea— she sighed, unable to hold back a sob and pushing herself closer to the vampire. —Please, don't say that. Your life is worth living because it's yours. Not just for me— Castaspella insisted, hugging her tightly.

—I don't understand. Aren't you mad I was ready to let you die?

—I'm more concerned about you wanting to end your life!

—You're too nice for your own good— Shadow Weaver sighed. —You should hate me.

—Of course not. I don't- I wouldn't hate you. I'm *worried* for you. But I don't really know what to say…

—You don't have to say anything to comfort me. I just- I thought you should know— the vampire sighed.

—Thank you for telling me— Castaspella replied, gently turning Shadow Weaver's face to look at her. —I don't care about you being ready to let me die; it had been days, and you said you tried everything. You couldn't have known Adora had powers that could work too… I mean, all we knew about She-Ra was that she was a danger to vampires, not…

—You really don't… mind that?

—I told you, I'm more concerned about you— she insisted. After a brief kiss, she added —I wouldn't want you to give up on life if I were to die…

Now it was Shadow Weaver who didn't know what to say.

She should have expected this, but at the same time she simply had no reply.

She couldn't make promises.

—I thought my pride wouldn't let me end my life, but… my pride is *nothing* next to the sorrow of losing you. *I wish* I could simply pretend I don't care, but you- Ugh…

—I really appreciate you telling me all of this.

—You better never repeat it in front of anyone— Shadow Weaver warned her, serious.

—I swear I won't— Castaspella smiled back. —If you prefer, we can have breakfast now.

—Please— the vampire groaned, making her giggle.

—Oh! And I just remembered: I've asked Catra for help filling a petition to let you return to work — the physician happily announced.

—Really!?

—Yes! It might take a few months, but there are great chances it'll be granted! Although, well, you can't go anywhere other than to Mystacor and back home.

—I imagine it'll have a lot of conditions…

—Yeah, but, I hoped it'll help you avoid going insane from being in here all the time.

—Thank you— the vampire sighed.

—You're most welcome!

A few more months passed.

The trials were coming to an end, at long last.

The little bomb about Shadow Weaver being a vampire was never dropped, after all, but it turned out to be unnecessary.

And less than a month before the verdict was finally delivered, the uncrowned queen married her fiancé. Castaspella was invited to the private ceremony, while the old vampire only got an apology for being excluded, not because of the privacy, but rather because of her house arrest.

In any case, she didn't care. She had no interest in mingling, even if there weren't that many guests…

Only after the hunters were finally sentenced to prison, for a reasonably long time, was the marriage made public. The new regents were crowned, and Shadow Weaver was surprised by Queen Glimmer's first resolution: the legal recognition of vampires.

That was… unexpected.

It was, for the most part, an absolute improvement. Legal recognition meant *protection by the law*. However… the registration thing…

Shadow Weaver's first instinct was to convince Castaspella not to register. The physician felt like she had to, but her partner's hesitation made her uneasy. Hence, she agreed to wait a few weeks before making a decision.

She herself didn't want either, but it became a condition to return to work, so eventually, the old vampire registered.

The first one to do so… Along with Catra, much to her surprise.

While the news about it caused an uproar that Shadow Weaver *hated*, it was worth it after all.

She could finally return to work.

And right it time, it seemed, with how busy things became in the medical institution.

Mystacor receiving so many patients was never good but, this time, the reason was… even worse.

If Shadow Weaver was against Castaspella registering before, now she was determined to keep her from it.

—Casta, haven't you noticed?— she asked, indignant. Pacing around her former office, now Castaspella's, she had been arguing with her for a while. Now, she finally halted and turned to face her. —Most of these people are *vampires*. Registered! And the ones who aren't, they all mentioned being accused of being vampires!

—But…

—Just listen to me. If you register as lesser vampire and those nut-jobs learn about it, you'll be *at risk*!

—What if I get attacked without being registered? I won't have the protection of the law— Castaspella argued.

—It's not worth it— Shadow Weaver insisted, holding her arms. —Please…

The physician swallowed hard, looking away.

—What if my brother already spread the word about me?

—Something tells me he hasn't. He probably doesn't want to admit it to himself— she denied. —You haven't been a target despite your involvement in the fall of the hunters.

—It might be just because Catra is always around me when you aren't, and it's clear you're both feared by that… anti-vampire group.

—Maybe…

After a short silence, both looking down, Castaspella raised her head again.

—Bea, have you spoken to the patients?

—Not much.

—They have been mentioning there's also a pro-vampire movement. Family and friends of vampires who are organizing against the attackers— Castaspella told her.

—Organized by who?

—That's what I don't know yet.

—We should probably go to speak with anyone who's still awake.

—Yeah, I think that's a good idea— she agreed. —It's getting late, though, so I'll tell Catra to return home and let your police escort take us home.

—Fine by me.

The couple went one by one to talk with the victims recovering. Shadow Weaver let Castaspella handle the "interrogation" since she was more gentle, and silently listened to their testimonies.

Unfortunately, most had no idea who was leading the pro-vampire movement.

Until the last person.

—The pro-vampires? Yeah… We're- We *had* to organize— the patient began. —I'm a mortal, but my best friend was turned a few years ago. Keeping her safe from the hunters was always difficult, so I had to take the first chance I could to make it easier for us.

—You mentioned getting in the middle of an attack. Were you protecting her?

—Yeah… We were heading home when I got a message about a suspicious individual that had been stalking our place— they explained. —So I rushed to open the door, got her inside and blocked the blade just in time.

—Wait, you… got a message?

—I have one of those beepers the prison guards and police force use— they revealed.

—How did you get it and who warned you?— Shadow Weaver decided to ask, a bit severe.

—The one coordinating the pro-vampire movement is a prison guard. She's been providing those to many of us. She's making all kinds of efforts to coordinate people, to protect vampires and spot those anti-vampires before they attack.

—Sorry, I promise this is the last question: Do you know who that is?

—She won't get in trouble?

—Of course not— Castaspella promised.

—She's called Maria Suarez.

Chapter End Notes

And that's it for today!!

I feel like it's a bit short, but… well… Maybe I didn't calculate it properly <("^_^) oops

Aaaaaanyways! Again, sorry for the delay, I had a lot to do all morning and half the afternoon, but it's posted now!
I'll see you next week, hopefully in time with the full chapter lol

Many thanks for reading!! :D

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

SO!
I had to rush a lot to finish this in time, and now I'm rushing a bit to post it too since I have to return to work, and otherwise I'd have to wait until the afternoon to finally post, so… I really hope I didn't miss any mistakes lol

Also! This chapter ended up being quite long, I think it's the longest, AND it was quite difficult to finish, but I think I managed it :D

And uh, well, I apologize for the angst <("^_^)

Anyways! I won't hold u any longer
Please enjoy!! ^_^

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

The following day, when Catra went to accompany Castaspella as usual, she was surprised by the request of calling Adora to go with them to Mystacor.

—Wait, but, why…

—Please, trust me. We need the Chief— the physician insisted.

—Alright, I'll go for her and then we'll go to the medical institution.

—Yes, thank you.

With a nod, Catra stepped back from the door and sprinted to the police station.

It was still quite strange using that speed in broad daylight like that, but it also felt nice to be able to do it…

In any case, when she arrived, Adora was just as confused as her.

—I have a lot of work with the anti-vampires and pro-vampires, and…

—I know, Dor, but she insists you're needed.

—Ah… Alright— Adora sighed. —Just this once.

—Thank you, Love— Catra smiled.

—I'll go directly to Mystacor, so you go ahead with her.

—Alright. See you soon.

As soon as Adora arrived at the floating island, Castaspella took her to see a patient.

—What is this about?

—You know how there have been several victims of some anti-vampires group, right?

—Yes.

—And about the pro-vampire move?

—That too.

—Well…— Castaspella sighed. —This patient knows something about it, and I think it's important you speak to them.

—Are you sure they will… want to speak? To me?

—I think, if you and Catra can reassure them, they will trust you.

Oh…

That wasn't a bad idea.

—We lose nothing trying— Catra pointed out, giving Adora an encouraging look.

—Yeah, of course.

Right then, they arrived at a room and Castaspella carefully opened the door after knocking.

—I'm awake— a voice said from the inside, and only then did the physician walk in.

—Good morning— she began. —I'm sorry to bother you, but… I've brought someone I think you should speak to.

—Who… Chi-Chief Adora!?— they noticed, pushing themselves up, and wincing in pain. —Ugh, uh… I-I'm not sure…

—Please, don't worry, they are friends.

—I-I know the police helped with the hunters' arrest, but… I told you, I don't want to get *her* in trouble.

—Her?— Adora asked, looking at Castaspella.

—She won't. But- Listen, they can help you deal with the anti-vampires better if you tell them about the pro-vampire movement. Otherwise, more people might get hurt— the physician insisted.

—It's just to defend vampires- I-it wouldn't be necessary if the police were enough— the patient replied, still refusing to speak.

—If things continue to escalate, we'll have to take action, and it… might be against both groups— Adora decided to intercede.

—You wouldn't want to act like the hunters— Catra joined. —If you keep everything under wraps and it gets discovered, if someone *dies*…

—I… understand— they nodded, looking down. —We have no intention of hurting anyone, we're just… looking out for our friends and family— the patient began, letting out a long sigh. —We have- We're provided with beepers. Like-like the ones you have— they admitted, looking at Adora. —That lets us warn anyone if we see someone stalking a place of registered vampires, or following someone, or… anything. They are set in an unused frequency, of course.

—Functional beepers? And you *know* the police frequency?— Catra highlighted.

—Some officer must be helping— Adora nodded, confirming her thoughts.

—I insist: I don't want to get her in trouble for-for organizing us and giving us the beepers. We needed this.

—It's alright. It's not illegal to distribute beepers— the Chief confirmed. —But, I'm guessing they aren't registered— she then added. —That *can* be illegal if it isn't fixed soon.

—But- We'd need to disclose a lot of information that could put vampires in danger— they argued.

—It can be confidential— Catra assured them. —If the one organizing you is willing to cooperate, we can do that.

—But… that would be *only* if she's not providing you with weapons too— Adora warned them.

—N-no, no! Only the beepers.

—Then you have nothing to fear. You can tell us who she is— the Chief assured them.

—Ca-can I instead contact her and tell her this? I wouldn't want to betray her trust after all the help. A-and my friend still needs protection after the attempt I foiled.

Adora gave Catra a look, she nodded in reply, and so she accepted —Tell her to go to the station and I'll receive her.

Once Castaspella confirmed that they were allowed to leave and rest at home as soon as their friend came for them, the three left the room. Walking down the hall, they went in the direction of the Head Physician's office, Catra recognized.

—You know who that woman is, right?— she asked.

—Yes, but I can't say it— Castaspella replied.

—I imagined.

—So, I'll go back to the station now, and hopefully she will show up— Adora decided to say. —I'll let you know if the court needs to get involved.

—Of course— Catra nodded. —Bye.

—See you later— her fiancée smiled, after a quick kiss.

As she walked away, the young vampire realized —Hey, where the heck is Shadow Weaver? You said she came here earlier.

—Yes, the influx of patients lately has us all very busy— Castaspella sighed. —I'll check the schedule to see where she's assigned now.

—Sure.

Humming, she went over the schedule fixed on the wall and then told the vampire to follow her.

—How are things going here?

—Ah, Casta, you're here— Shadow Weaver noticed, glancing briefly at Catra. —We're finally done with the last few admissions.

—That's good. How many?

—Another three this last hour.

—Oh my Stars— Castaspella sighed. —Do you need help?

—No need, you can stick to the paperwork. It's pilling up…

—I know.

—Catra, one of the patients mentioned something concerning— she then said, surprising the young vampire when she called her name.

—A-about?

—His attacker pretty much threatened to come looking for him here— she explained, serious. —I'll trust you'll protect Casta?

—You have my word— she nodded, matching her expression. —It's my duty, but she's also my friend— she added.

—Thank you— the physician smiled, placing a hand on her shoulder.

A few days passed, there was only a minor incident at the medical institution with an intruder one night, but Shadow Weaver made sure they would never try again, so things were quite calm afterwards.

And finally, around a week passed before Adora returned home with news about the leader of the pro-vampire move.

—So… She's a prison guard— her fiancée began, sitting at the table with a drink in hand while they waited for the food to be ready. —Her name's Maria Suarez, and…

—Oh, I *know* her!— Catra reacted, almost spitting her drink. —She was- Oh, damn, it makes so much sense!

—Wait, you- How do you know her?

—I think I never mentioned her by name but, well, she's the prison receptionist that thanked Castaspella for putting the hunters in jail— she began. —Remember I told you we were getting the copy of the file about her brother from the evidence?

—Oh, yeah! I didn't know that was her!

—Well, she looked really… I don't know, she seemed to feel guilty when Angella blasted Casta, so it's really far from surprising she'd be the one organizing the movement— she sighed with a sad smile.

—Hmm, yes, she sounded quite genuine in her intention to protect vampires— Adora nodded, taking a sip. —She agreed to register all the beepers and the frequency, and I'm preparing the paperwork to submit a petition to make it confidential— she went on. —I told her she had to make sure none of her people arm themselves, even those with a license, because then it would get them all into trouble.

—Makes sense. They would end up behaving exactly like the hunters…

—That's what she said too— Adora smirked. —Which reassures me about her, you know? But, well, I don't know whether she'll be able to keep everyone in check. Some might still arm themselves and *not* tell her.

Both let out a sigh, sipped their drinks in silence for a moment, and then checked on the food.

It was ready; time for dinner.

A few weeks went by with what felt like peace and tranquility.

The remaining hunters were… strangely quiet.

That made Adora more nervous that anything, Catra could feel it.

She tried her best to soothe her, but it was impossible. And even harder when Catra herself was starting to feel uneasy.

Why would they make no move in weeks if not because they planned something big?

So what should they do? Prepare?

How!?

They couldn't make any preemptive moves, they were *not* going to act like the hunters…

But if they had to keep waiting… they would simply *implode*.

Catra had a pretty fair understanding of everything going on, both among vampires and among pro-vampire mortals, since they seemed to have taken Mystacor as their safe-haven.

Being there so many hours, guarding Castaspella for the most part, it was easy to catch fragments of conversations and little by little piece together a whole picture.

But Catra couldn't really do much with that.

There was restlessness among vampires, fear among the pro-vampire movement members, and… there was the subject of their leader.

Okay, their "organizer".

She had been visiting the medical institution a few times, and every time it was more and more obvious who she was.

So… how could they be sure the hunters hadn't noticed it was her?

They couldn't.

So when it happened, it was far from surprising…

Maria Suarez got targeted.

She was stabbed on her way out of the prison at the end of her shift.

Fellow pro-vampire members rushed her to Mystacor, the police detained the culprit…

Castaspella did her best to save her… But she failed.

Adora arrived little after she passed, ordered everyone to leave, and transformed into She-Ra.

Catra could see the light of her transformation through the cracks of the door.

But shortly after, she walked out, defeated.

How could it be that not even She-Ra could save her?

The atmosphere was grim the next few days, and many still wondered what had happened.

It had all been just… *so fast*. Catra needed to take a moment to recap.

However, she then remembered Adora had invited her that day to witness as the caught hunter was interrogated, so Catra pushed aside her tumultuous thoughts and went to the station.

She arrived just a bit after it began.

—I don't think you understand the gravity of your situation— Detective Trouble began.

—I just did what I had to— the guy replied, ignoring his lawyer trying to speak.

—Kill a woman?

—Kill a *traitor*! And I have many more I should dispose of!— he insisted.

His lawyer all but gave up by this point.

—So you're purposely targeting those you think traitors… to whom?

—To the kingdom! To the people! The *real* people! The mortals!

—I don't think you're sane…— the detective scoffed.

—Sane!? I'm not crazy! I'm far more saner than any of you!

—Are you?

—Yes!

—Who gave you the order to kill Maria Suarez?— another officer asked.

—No one! I knew I had to!

—Why?

—She was helping the vampires! Those *monsters*!

—Who taught you that?

—Who else!? Our Queen! Our *legitimate* Queen!

—Angella?

—*The* Queen!

—Alright, calm down— the officer told him.

—I won't! You've betrayed her too! You discarded her like some old senile woman, when she's our saviour!

—Saviour? From what?

—The menace of the vampires!

—Why do you think vampires are a menace?— Detective Trouble asked.

—They are! They kill people, suck their blood, turn our loved ones in to the same undead monsters as they are… They are a *threat*!

—Have you *ever* seen a vampire kill an innocent civilian?

—They have killed my friends!

—Hunters?

—Yes!

—Any non-hunters?

—That-that doesn't matter!

—It does…— Double Trouble insisted, smirking. —Since you hunt them, you're far from being "innocent civilians".

—No! They kill, they are- they are dangerous! It's their *nature*!

—What if I told you that's not true?

—How wouldn't it be!? Why would our Queen lie to us!?

—What if she thought it was true, but it wasn't?— the officer suggested, between indignant and disbelieving.

—No, no! You're *lying*!

—I am not, Son…

—Don't-don't call me that!

—Listen: you have two options here— the prosecutor finally decided to intercede. Catra hadn't even noticed she was in the room. —Either you plead guilty and get a deal to reduce your sentence a bit or get some… accommodations so your time in prison won't be that terrible, or you plead innocent and let the deliberative council decide your fate.

—I am not guilty of anything that didn't have to be done!

—I see… Alright, you're on your own, Kid— Netossa sighed.

—I am not! I am *never* on my own! The Queen is all that matters! Listen to her or you all will be doomed! *Doomed*!

Well, shit, that was… something.

—Okay, can we leave already? This guy is giving me the creeps— Catra admitted, looking back at Adora.

—Yeah, let's get going. Don't worry— she nodded. —We're done here, open please— she requested.

—Alright.

On their way back home, Catra and Adora couldn't talk. They were both too… shaken still.

When had Angella's influence become so… maddening?

—I think I want to talk to her.

—Huh?

—I want to speak with Angella— Adora repeated.

—Why!?

—Because I want to understand. How did she manage to get the loyalty of people like that guy!?

—Dor, are you insane!? Remember what she did to Casta!?

—Yes, but I have She-Ra. I'm sure I'll be alright.

—I-I know, but…

—Look, I… just want to understand. Don't worry about me. Just focus on the upcoming trial— her fiancée suggested. —Netossa said you'll be called as witness, so… just focus on that.

—How can I do that if I know you'll be risking yourself visiting Angella!?

—I won't be risking myself, Catra, please! Trust me!

—I trust you— she nodded, letting out a long sigh.

The following day arrived too soon for Catra, despite being the one who pushed for the trial to be as soon as possible.

She couldn't even sleep, and now there she was, sitting at the witness stand.

Her testimony until then had been pretty messy, and she apologized several times, getting increasingly anxious. Hence, they took a short break for her to calm down and were now back.

—Okay, start from the beginning again— the Prosecutor requested.

—Yeah, of-of course. So, uh… it was late already. I think- No, yeah, it was about to be the end of Casta's shift— Catra hesitated, making an effort to focus. —Shadow Weaver had a while more to go, so we were talking with Casta about whether she'd return with the old hag or not, and then…

—Then?

—Then, about four people rushed into the facility, carrying a bleeding woman. I recognized her a second too late, but I did.

—Officer Suarez?

—Yeah…

—And?

—I told Casta, who hadn't noticed, and she rushed to help. They were like, three physicians trying to stop the bleeding, clean around… Uh, I-I don't know. They were doing *a lot* of things.

—And?

—A-and then just- Well, like, I-I don't know what exactly happened in there, but Casta walked out crying, said she lost her.

—How long after did Chief Adora arrive?

—Right that moment, as if on cue.

—And?

—Look, I know- I know it will sound insane, but she has… She can… heal people. But she couldn't this time— Catra tried to explain.

—Heal people, how?

—How? Uh, with-with magic? I don't know what you want me to tell you.

—Just the truth.

—*That's the truth*. Adora has always had these powers, this kind of ancient magic, and she recently learnt how to heal people. The few times she's done it, it always worked. I don't know why she couldn't this time.

—And what about the murderer?

—I heard he was caught. I don't know much about that. I didn't witness it. I was only told a few things about it by some people who arrived a bit later to Mystacor.

—Alright, I see— the Prosecutor nodded. —That's enough.

—Thank you.

Catra stepped down from the witness stand and returned to her usual spot during trials, but could hardly control her anxiety again. Judge Hordak gave her a look, she made a subtle gesture to reassure him she's fine, and he continued the session.

—Having heard everything, are we ready to move on to the deliberation?

This trial, different from the one the former regents had, included a little… deliberative council. They were all civilians picked from among a wide group to witness the hearings and then discuss among themselves about who they thought was in the right and who in the wrong.

The final decision was still Hordak's, or whatever Judge was in charge, but their opinions and their reasoning was always helpful for the verdict to be imparted.

Hence, they now had to wait for said council to discuss and then they could decide whether the accused should go to prison.

That same afternoon, Catra returned home feeling dizzy. She really wanted to rest.

She needed it…

But she couldn't, unfortunately, since Maria's funeral would take place in a few hours, and Castaspella would attend.

Well, she *also* wanted to attend, if she was fully honest.

And Adora had promised to go too after her visit to Angella. So, hopefully, she'd see her there.

In any case, she had to prepare now and couldn't go to sleep…

Hence, she took a bath, put on her suit, and promptly left her home while trying to empty her head and remain calm.

Fortunately, the afternoon was cloudy, so there would be no issue for the vampires to be outdoors…

Catra and Castaspella soon arrived at the funeral, only exchanging a few words on the way there about how Shadow Weaver couldn't get permission to attend yet probably had no interest anyways.

And once there, they were surprised to find Glimmer in attendance.

The Queen's presence was, obviously, a sign of her support for vampires.

Yet it was also dangerous for her.

In fact, Catra couldn't shake the feeling that this huge gathering of vampires, and mortals related to them, was possibly a bad idea.

—Hey, are you okay?— Glimmer suddenly asked, extracting her from those thoughts.

—Ye-yeah, don't worry.

—Why don't we take a seat?

—Sure.

—Auntie, you coming with us?

—Of course— she nodded, gentle.

Many people were already sitting in the rows of chairs set in front of the coffin, but noticeably separated by groups.

Despite sitting away from everyone, Catra could hear the different groups muttering but tried to ignore it; they deserved their privacy.

However, the fact that everyone was sitting with certain space between each group made it quite suspicious when some random guy went to sit right behind them.

Catra gave him a questioning look, but he didn't look back, so she decided to ignore him and return her attention to Glimmer.

—Bow felt it'd be disrespectful from him to come, but I wanted to attend because, well… the damage my parents caused is… just so much. I feel like I *must* make up for this.

—It's not your fault, Sparkles.

—She's right. Don't feel that pressure, alright?— Castaspella seconded her.

—But…

—No buts. I'm sure your presence here is appreciated, of course. So, please, don't think anyone blames you for what *they* did.

—Yeah— she smiled, looking a bit better. —I…

A scoff interrupted Glimmer and her expression went dark as they heard a voice behind incredulously say —You believe them?

The three turned to look at the guy that Catra had noticed before, now smirking mockingly.

—Pardon!?— Castaspella let out, indignant.

—She's her mother's daughter. She's *meant* to kill vampires. Aren't you, *your Majesty*?

—N-no, no!— she stammered, shaking.

—Hey, dude! What's your problem!?— Catra snapped.

—My problem? I am merely pointing out a fact.

—Of course not!— the physician rebuked. —Who even are you!?

—Does it matter? Who I am doesn't change the facts: you are no different from the former Queen, your Majesty. It's only a matter of time until you accept it.

—Stop! No!— Glimmer yelled, hunching over and covering her face as she began gasping.

—Alright, that's enough— Catra decided, standing from her chair. —Leave us alone.

—Or what?

—Haven't you seen the cops? I can call them over. So better leave by your own means.

—So you can keep lying to her? *Tame* her?— he insisted, nonchalant.

—Tame!?— Castaspella reacted, raising her sight from her niece to him.

—You're afraid of her powers. If she turns against you, you'll be helpless— he smirked. —So you need her under control.

—That's not true!— Catra roared, itching to jump him. —Shut up!

—You know I'm right, your Majesty.

—Stop!— Castaspella yelled, before kneeling in front of Glimmer. —Listen to me, Dear. Ignore him. You're *not* your mother.

—I-I… don't- I don't… want to… hurt… anyone— she sobbed, sounding increasingly anxious.

That wasn't good.

Catra saw everyone around them staring, mostly afraid or concerned, and finally waved at the first police officer she could make eye-contact with.

—I'm not letting you upset her any further— she growled.

And then she felt it.

The heat.

It reminded her of what happened the last time Glimmer got like this.

—Catra! Stay away! Everyone!— Castaspella warned her that same moment, snapping her out of her shock. —Glim, Dear, please, listen to me…

—I'm sorry… I'm so sorry— she kept sobbing, breathless.

—Don't be, don't be. Just ignore him— her aunt pleaded, tears falling down her cheeks too. —Just calm down, please…

Catra knew she could do nothing now, she couldn't even get close, so she only looked back at the guy to make sure he wouldn't further feed Glimmer's anxiety, and saw the officer was already trying to convince him to leave on his own.

—Just take him!— she yelled. —He's done enough damage.

—Come with me, Sir.

—Sure, I'm done here— he smirked.

Hunter.

She wasn't sure how, but she just *knew it*.

—Listen, Glim. He was just trying to provoke you— she began, as both the Queen and her aunt cried in silence. —He's a hunter, I'm sure. He-he wants your powers to get out of control— she

explained, swallowing hard, trying to stay calm. —Don't let him win. You're *not* what he said— she went on, on the verge of tears. —You're my friend. You're compassionate and loving, not hateful like your mother. She doesn't define you.

—But my powers— she sobbed, still emitting a faint heat. —I can only hurt you… I hurt Auntie.

—It's your choice. You won't if you don't want to— Catra replied. —I trust you, Sparkles— she affirmed, taking a step forward. —You'd never hurt anyone on purpose.

She took a deep breath and placed a hand on Glimmer's back.

The heat was receding.

And now she noticed, Castaspella's crying was out of pain, yet she never let go of her niece.

She kept holding her hands despite them burning her.

—I know you didn't mean to hurt me— the physician told her, voice broken. —I'm here with you, Dear.

Slowly, Glimmer began taking deep breaths and little by little raised her head.

—I'm sorry— she muttered. —Maybe I should leave.

—Don't worry, Sparkles. The guy's gone— Catra assured her. —You'll be fine.

—I could have hurt everyone here— she lamented, brushing away her tears.

—That's what they wanted, but you're stronger than the hunters think— Castaspella told her. —Much stronger.

—Thank you for… helping me.

—I'll let everyone know it's all fine now— Catra said, squeezing Glimmer's shoulder comfortingly. —I'll be right back.

She took a deep breath and approached the middle of the area, looking all around.

—What happened?— some muttered.

—Are we safe?

—Please, don't worry, everyone— Catra began. —I promise everything's alright now.

—Are you sure we can still hold the funeral?— a man inquired, worried.

—Of course— she nodded. —If the officiant is ready to begin…

—That's me— the man replied. —I'll trust you, then— he accepted.

With that, the people in attendance little by little took a seat, although some remained wary, and the ceremony began, right as a hand tapped on Catra's shoulder.

Adora had arrived.

Shadow Weaver

That morning, Shadow Weaver had left her home early while Castaspella waited for Catra to arrive.

She had a lot to do, she couldn't waste time.

Specially not since she wasn't Head Physician anymore.

Now she had a *schedule* to follow!

Fun…

Especially this particular day.

Three new admissions in a single hour!? Good thing she was here then…

But, of course, it couldn't be just the average patient, no. They were *all* victims of attacks from those self-nominated anti-vampires, which are *obviously* just former hunters…

Clearly, those poor bastards have no purpose in life without Angella giving them orders.

Pathetic…

As if reading her thoughts, the last admitted patient called her attention and prompted her to approach.

How annoying.

—What is it?— she briskly asked, once she was close enough.

—Listen…— he began, voice hoarse. —The-the one who… attacked me. The-they said… they'd come here… to finish the job— he explained, starting to cough.

—Alright. No more talking. Rest. I'll handle it— she promised him, severe.

She'd probably have to call Castaspella now; better to warn her as soon as possible.

However, right as she was about to head for the office, she heard a crashing sound and regretted ever looking away from those dimwits.

Oh, how she hated being a mere physician again… Stuck babysitting those idiots when she could be sitting comfortably doing paperwork…

A while later, fortunately after everything was handled, Castaspella herself went to find Shadow Weaver.

Good, saved her the trip.

—How are things going here?— she asked.

—Ah, Casta, you're here— the old vampire replied, barely glancing at Catra. —We're finally done with the last few admissions.

—That's good. How many?

—Another three this last hour— she sighed.

—Oh my Stars. Do you need help?

—No need, you can stick to the paperwork. It's pilling up…— she pointed out, hiding her envy.

—I know.

—Catra, one of the patients mentioned something concerning— she then said, feeling as if she were mentally slapping herself.

—A-about?— she stammered, probably caught by surprise.

Scaredy-cat…

—His attacker pretty much threatened to come looking for him here— she explained, serious. —I'll trust you'll protect Casta?

—You have my word— she nodded, matching her expression. Good. —It's my duty, but she's also my friend— she added.

Sappy…

—Thank you— Castaspella smiled, placing a hand on her shoulder.

Sappy!

Seriously, why does she even- Ah… never mind.

Shadow Weaver pretended she wasn't absolutely *sick* of the fluffiness display, and simply turned around to return to work.

She had gotten the confirmation she needed.

As expected, merely a few days passed before the hunter's threat was fulfilled.

It was late when she heard a strange noise in the Intensive Care Unit, and she just *knew it*. Castaspella was *fortunately* back home already, so Shadow Weaver didn't have to worry about her getting hurt, and didn't hesitate to ditch everything and check on the patients.

And she caught the intruder sneaking into a room.

—*Fool*— she sneered, making the hunter jump and knock down a few things from the cabinet behind them. —Couldn't even pick an occupied room. You must be one of those pathetic trainees

who never got the official title, aren't you?— she mocked them, slowly stepping closer.

Threateningly.

—Yo-you're… You betrayed us!

—Betrayed? Yes, I did. What will you do about it? *Kill me*?— she asked, cackling wickedly right after.

She could see them go pale.

—Do-don't step any closer!

—You're history, Kid— she smirked.

The hunter clearly panicked, because they threw their silver blade with the worst aim and bolted out of the room, running down the hall.

How pitiful.

Shadow Weaver gave them a minute before catching up with her supernatural speed, and grabbed them by the back of their cloak.

She could go feral, she could tore them apart… she could make a bloody mess in the hall.

But then she recalled the anklet she wore, and decided to be smarter about it.

—Let me go!— they screamed.

—Oh, I will— she confirmed, her tone suspicious. Then, she pulled them closer to growl in their ear —You are free to go, and *warn* your friends. The next one will *not* return, and you'll have to search for the pieces of their body all over the kingdom.

She let them fall to the ground and joined her hands behind her back as she watched them scamper away.

Part of her regretted letting them go at first, but since there were no further attempts from the hunters, she finally accepted it had been the right move.

However, the hunters' inactivity turned out to be absolute.

It wasn't just Mystacor being safe from attacks… And *that* was suspicious.

She'd *love it* if her threat had scared them all, but she knew those imbeciles wouldn't give up easily.

Which meant they were planning something.

Just *great*.

But the worst was yet to come.

With how many vampires and relatives of them were still in Intensive Care, it was no surprise to see so many pro-vampires visiting Mystacor every day. And that included their cherished leader: Maria Suarez.

Her experience as a hunter let Shadow Weaver guess what would happen, yet even when she warned the officer several times, it was all for naught.

The old vampire was handling another patient when it all began, but as soon as she was done, she went to the Emergency Room. Right that moment, Castaspella walked out with her hands full of blood, crying.

Several people were standing there, among them, Catra, seemingly in shock. The rest were probably those who brought the officer. She recognized some faces. A woman began crying and stumbled back to the wall, the man closest to her helped her sit, and the other two seemed about to hyperventilate.

—I lost her— Castaspella finally muttered, looking at her hands.

She'd be damned.

Shadow Weaver closed her eyes a second, then approached her partner, helped her take off the bloodied gloves, and held her tightly, letting her cry.

And then Adora arrived running.

—I just heard…— she began, but trailed off. She must have realized what happened. —No, no, wait, let me…— she uttered, out of breath, before rushing into the Emergency Room.

As soon as all the remaining physicians walked out, Shadow Weaver saw the light of her transformation into She-Ra, and recognized the golden glow of her healing powers.

Castaspella looked back, hopeful for a moment, before the Chief walked back out, defeated.

It seemed to break her; the physician held onto the old vampire even tighter.

A bit after, a few more people arrived, and since it was clear that the officer hadn't survived, they didn't even ask.

—I'm sorry— Castaspella sobbed.

—You did what you could— Shadow Weaver reminded her.

—At least tell me the killer didn't escape.

—No. We kept him against a wall until police arrived and took him away— a vampire confirmed. —That's why… we just… I-I'm sorry, I need a moment— he then said, looking away as he started to cry.

—You're from the Court, right?— a woman then asked Catra, shaking her from her trance. —What can we do!?

—He has no chance with you as witnesses— she nodded, still out of sorts but seemingly anchored by Adora's hand on her shoulder. —Ju-just… fill a report at the-the Station and I'll make sure it's handled soon.

Shadow Weaver took a deep breath.

She wasn't expecting so many people to be this… shaken.

She lamented the officer's passing, of course, but she had warned her.

It didn't matter now.

She had to focus on keeping Castaspella out of the pit of guilt she was sure to fall into…

The next few days were… insufferable.

Shadow Weaver told her to take a rest, but the physician stubbornly kept going to work. That meant, constantly seeing the faces of that officer's friends. And her soft heart could hardly handle it.

It wasn't strange to find Castaspella crying alone in the break-room whenever it was empty, or sobbing quietly and trying to hide it every time Shadow Weaver stepped into her office.

At first, the old vampire simply refrained from making any comments that may sound shaming, which usually meant saying nothing at all, but then she realized this couldn't be the first person Castaspella lost in the job.

So there had to be something else.

—Casta?— she called, walking into her office immediately after knocking. —Do you have a moment?

—Of course— she nodded, sniffing slightly. —Take a seat.

—What is it?

—What is what?

—Why… Ugh, I'm not- I don't mean to dismiss the matter, but why are you still crying?

—I-I don't- How could I *not*? She died in my hands!— Castaspella reminded her, eyes watery.

—But it's not the first time it happened— Shadow Weaver pointed out. —I believe there's something else going on.

—You mean besides me feeling guilty?

—Why would you feel…

—I couldn't save her! And because of that, many vampires and their loved ones lost the one person who'd go to any lengths to keep them safe!

—Casta, that's not- Look, that officer *knew* she was in danger, and precisely because she wanted to keep them safe, she risked her life— Shadow Weaver began, trying to put things in perspective. —She knew what she was doing, she knew she could die, and wouldn't ever blame you for being unable to save her.

—But…

—I read the report, I spoke with the other physicians. The massive internal bleeding was already too much to handle, and with how much blood she lost until she arrived here, there was no way of saving her— she interrupted. —Stars! Even if someone tried to turn her that same moment, they wouldn't save her! Not even She-Ra's power could! How were *you* supposed to!?

—I know, I know! It's just… I can't stop thinking… Di-did you know she had no family left? There was no one to notify. The only ones who knew her were the people who brought her, those who arrived later, and almost every patient we have here.

—I understand what you mean, Casta. But as you would put it, the people you just mentioned were her family. Those she looked out for— Shadow Weaver reminded her, feeling a bit… strange. —And you said she was the only one protecting them, but you know she wasn't. You've been speaking non-stop about everything that officer- Maria managed to do: get help from the police, craft a system to monitor suspicious activity and warn vampires, organize them effectively to help and protect each other… Why would all of that be erased with her death?

—You're right…— the physician sighed. —I hadn't… thought about it.

—I realize— the old vampire smirked. —Look what you're making me say— she joked, managing to get a chuckle from Castaspella. —Now, I think you need to rest. I mean it. Clear your head, take the day off tomorrow, and let me handle things here.

—Are you sure? I'm already taking the afternoon…

—I've done it enough times. I don't mind— she assured her. —Besides, I heard tomorrow morning is the trial of that bastard who attacked her. I recommended you to write the pertinent report for it instead of declaring as witness, but… I imagine you'd like to hear it, right?

Castaspella took a deep breath and sighed, nodding as she admitted —That would help me, I think. I want to hear the verdict, at least.

—Then leave this to me.

—Oh, but… tomorrow afternoon is the funeral too.

—I am aware. Which is also why I told you to take the *whole* day off, otherwise you wouldn't have time to rest.

—Right, right…— she nodded. —Thank you.

—Don't mention it.

—But, really, I-I appreciate the effort you made.

—Is it that obvious?

—I believe I know you enough by now— Castaspella smiled, albeit with a shadow of sadness. — Let's just wrap things up and leave. The night shift is already beginning.

—You can go ahead without me.

—No, no. I told Catra I'd return with you so she could go to see the interrogation of that hunter.

—I see. Then I'll be back in a bit once I'm done.

She wouldn't admit it, but Shadow Weaver noticed her view of everyone in the hospital was completely different after leaving the office.

She returned home deep in thought and, thankfully, Castaspella didn't question her about it.

The truth was, she was once again shifting her mindset because she had seen things through her partner's eyes.

Part of her was disgusted, but… there was this tiny bit of *something* that reminded her Castaspella's heart was in the right place, and hating this new perspective would be like hating *hers*.

Why could she recognize and respect that behaviour on the physician but not on herself? Why was it so *terrible* to be gentle and understanding?

No one said she had to be naïve or soft all the time, but… maybe sometimes, and especially for Castaspella, it was the right choice instead of her usual nastiness.

Ugh… her head hurt now.

The following day, morning was fleeting.

Shadow Weaver handled all the paperwork, organized shifts, helped with a few patients, and finally decided to return home before Castaspella left for the funeral. It was also a slow day, so there wasn't really much to do after lunch…

Hence, she was soon escorted back home by her assigned officers, and arrived just in time to hear the verdict.

Life sentence.

He got even more time than the regents themselves.

Bittersweet, for sure, but expected since they had been condemned for leading an illegal organization with murderous intent, yet not for their direct involvement in any murder.

This guy was surely insane to still follow their "philosophy", so to speak.

Well, at least some justice was served, even if it didn't bring back the officer.

And, fortunately, Castaspella looked relieved, much better than the past few days.

Soon, she had to get ready to leave, and Shadow Weaver was left alone after Catra arrived to accompany her.

About an hour passed in silence while the old vampire read a book, until she heard the door.

They couldn't be back already, obviously, so this had to be a visitor.

Curiously enough, it was Judge Hordak.

—Afternoon.

—What are you doing here, *Judge*?— she scoffed, in absolute disbelief.

—Pleased to see you too— he mocked her. —I came to speak to you about something important. May I come in?

—Sure— she sighed, rolling her eyes and moving aside.

—I must begin with the matter of Officer Suarez.

—Was her movement that important?

—It *is*. It has set the foundation for a better future for us— he clarified. —I don't believe that has escaped you…

—Of course I know— she scoffed again. —But the hunters that aren't in prison are getting bolder. They are clearly insane, and a bold nut-job is the most dangerous kind of hunter.

—I know. I imagine they will be targeting anyone who helps vampires, completely forfeiting their supposed intention to protect mortals— he nodded. —Which means everyone is in danger.

—So?

—So, I came to give you a new task: track down those hunters, report their moves, and assist my people to refine our strategy— he said, hands joined behind his back as he stood proudly in front of her.

—How am I supposed to track them down if I can't leave this place without police escort?— she questioned him, raising a brow.

—We both know your magical talents are enough to manage that without having to leave the safety of your… *home*— he pointed out, looking around before pronouncing the last word with a hint of mockery.

—So you know about my shadow spies— she realized. He only smirked in reply. —Fine, I'll do it. *But*, you better keep Casta out of this. If she learns about it, she'll surely want to stalk them, and I refuse to allow it.

—Consider it done— he promised, raising a hand in front of her as if to show his sincerity.

Around two more hours passed before Castaspella returned from the funeral… along with her niece, Chief Adora, and of course, Catra.

She *really* needed to get used to her presence at some point since her partner was so fond of her now…

—You look terrible— Shadow Weaver commented, as soon as the door was closed. —Tea or coffee?

—I'd prefer alcohol, but for my own sake, just coffee— Castaspella sighed, flopping onto the sofa.

—Yes, please some coffee— Catra seconded.

—I'd prefer tea— Glimmer replied.

—Alright. Chief?— she then asked.

—Water is fine.

—I'll be right back.

—Do you need help?— her partner then asked, sounding quite tired.

—No need— she replied from the kitchen. —I can handle it.

Once again, she only wanted her to rest; it was clear she needed it.

Besides, with a bit of magic, it wasn't difficult to do everything at once.

Soon, she was back in the lounge with a tray full of cups and a glass.

She gave each their drink, and sat down next to Castaspella.

—Yours is especial— she whispered with a smirk.

—Much appreciated— the physician sighed, taking a sip with her eyes closed.

—Alright. May I ask now why you've all come?

—Ah, yes— Adora began, putting down her glass. —I went to speak with Angella before the funeral and wanted to let you all know how it went. Including you, so we *had* to gather here for that.

—Of course— Shadow Weaver sighed.

—So, uh.. she claims she has no contact with any hunters. Apparently, I could meet her only because of who I am. Everyone else trying to visit her gets rejected.

—Ah, yeah, Hordak made sure of it, mainly to keep hunters from visiting and getting orders or relaying any information to her— Catra explained. —That's also why the hunter processed this

morning will be kept away from both Angella and Micah.

—That explains why she knew nothing about Officer Suarez murder— Adora realized. —I first thought she knew something because she asked why the receptionist had changed.

—You- Wait, you saw her in the common visit area?— Castaspella then asked.

—Yes?

—At least tell me she was restrained or something.

—Oh, yeah, she was in handcuffs. I think the prison doesn't have any other monitored area for visits, so…

—She's proved to be dangerous, but the handcuffs at least should work— Catra pointed out. —I don't think she has the strength to break free, right?

—Or didn't want to— Adora commented. —I could have handled her, in any case, as there was no one else in the room other than guards.

—Does that mean everything went fine?— Shadow Weaver inquired.

—In that sense, yes.

—But?— Glimmer hesitantly asked.

—But… interrogating her was quite unnerving. She's convinced we made the wrong choice; she kept saying vampires will undermine and take over the kingdom and then all of Etheria. She thinks this is just a different form of the same war she fought back in Mara's time.

—So there's no way she'll ever change her mind— the Queen lamented.

—Not yet, at least— Castaspella commented, sounding slightly hopeful. —I want to believe that, with time, she'll eventually realize her fears are unfounded. That vampires and mortals can coexist in peace without one trying to take over the other.

—I *know* for a fact that Hordak has no intentions to overthrow the legitimate rulers of any kingdom. The power he has as judge, he got it by rightful means, and he honors his deal with Mara— Adora nodded. —I reminded Angella of that deal, without mentioning it was Hordak, of course, but she…

—Doesn't believe it— Shadow Weaver completed.

—At all. She thinks that Mara's passing eventually gave vampires enough sense of safety to restart the war, and then of course, accused me of being the cause of it because I rejected the mantle of She-Ra— she then explained, rolling her eyes at the end.

—Hordak once told me Mara herself hoped there would not be another She-Ra— Catra revealed. —In fact, learning that *you* inherited it was what first made him believe that prophecy thing would repeat.

—Well, in a way, you could say the hunters revival is what started the war again, just, as Angella put it, in a different form.

—She herself made her fears a reality— Shadow Weaver scoffed, disbelieving.

—Pretty much— Adora nodded. —I tried to point that out, I even told her my powers could heal vampires and that it means She-Ra is not the vampire killer she thinks, but… she didn't believe me.

—She won't believe anything that contradicts her mindset— the old vampire assured her, frowning. —And she's clearly *too good* at imposing that mindset on others— she added. —I won't lie and say she manipulated me, of course, but it still took a lot of time for me to stop hating my own nature— she admitted.

Right after, Castaspella put down her empty mug and took her hand, giving her a gentle look.

—At least you *did* change your mind— Catra scoffed, shaking her head.

—Surprisingly— Shadow Weaver smirked. —It was all because of Casta, but even her infinite patience won't have any effect on the hundreds of years of deeply rooted fear that Angella feels.

—That much I know— Castaspella nodded, looking down.

—Then what are we supposed to do?— Glimmer decided to ask. —I mean, we can't chase down the remaining hunters, and only Mom would be able to stop them if she ordered as much.

—We can't chase them down but, now, they are just like any regular criminal— Adora reminded her. —In fact, we *shouldn't* do that, lest we fall into hunters' ways.

—True— Catra nodded. —We've always had to monitor and avoid hunters at all costs, only confront them if there was no other choice, so we'll keep doing that, and trying to protect mortals too. That part is more difficult, but…

—I could help to keep track of them— Castaspella proposed.

—No, you won't— the vampires immediately replied in unison.

Both Shadow Weaver and Catra seemed shocked for a moment having agreed like that, but quickly shook it off.

—You're my responsibility. I can't let you do it.

—I wasn't going to tell you, but since you know now… I made a deal with Hordak to *keep you out* of that.

—What!? Come on! You know I'm good at it!

—Technically speaking, you're good at *stalking*, and while not exactly illegal, it's still frown upon. And if they catch you…— Adora reminded her.

—Fine, fine!— Castaspella finally gave up, folding her arms. —I won't.

—Good. With that sorted out, I believe the matter is concluded.

—Yes, uh, I suppose that's our cue to leave— Glimmer nodded.

—You don't have to, *right*?— Castaspella interceded, side-eying Shadow Weaver.

—No, of course…— the old vampire sighed.

—It's fine, Auntie. Don't worry.

—Yeah, we wouldn't want to overstay our welcome— Catra agreed, with half a smile.

As the three girls stood up, Castaspella reluctantly followed and went to open the door for them.

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver busied herself picking up all the mugs to take them back to the kitchen.

Soon enough, her partner approached her while she washed everything.

—What is it?— she asked.

—What do you mean?

—I don't believe it just upset you that I invited them… Or rather, that I invited Catra, whom you seem to hate so much.

—I don't hate her— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —I don't like her either.

—Alright, then you agree with me. That's not what upset you. So what is it?

—I'm not upset.

—Okay, but something is *bothering* you!

—I- No. I'm fine.

—Bullshit.

With that, Shadow Weaver left the mug she was washing and slammed her hands on the edge of the basin, looking down with a frown.

—What do you want me to say?

—Just let me know how you're feeling and why!

—I don't know what I'm feeling, much less the *cause*!

She was simply… generally angry! Angry with life itself!

She hated everything that was going on, the looming possibility of Castaspella being attacked, the crippling fear of losing her for real this time…

She hated feeling so *soft*!

As she shut her eyes tightly, clutching the edge of the basin, she felt the physician's hand on her shoulder.

—Then talk to me. We can figure it out together. And it may make you feel better… That is, if you trust me.

—Of course I do! But it's… Ugh, it's so disgusting. The feeling of powerlessness and despair.

—Come on, leave that and let's seat— Castaspella exhorted her, gentle. —Where does that despair come from?

—The situation. I clearly can't handle it— she growled, frustrated. —I can't do anything to ensure your safety. I can't do anything that will guarantee I won't lose you.

—You're doing what you can— the physician reminded her, taking her hands and holding them together. —You can't be in control of everything, but you're not powerless for it. Just a person with limits.

—What if I don't like having limits!? What if I definitely lose you because of those limits!?

—Bea, please. You do everything you can. And that's enough for me, alright?

—I… understand— she sighed. —And, I guess, if you still want to register as vampire, in case you're ever attacked… I won't oppose it anymore.

—Thank you— Castaspella smiled, raising her hands to kiss them. —I promise it's the right choice.

—I can't see anything but a grim future ahead of us, but…

—*But* we can't just give up without *trying* to make it better.

—You're still a naïve fool…— Shadow Weaver began, smirking as she stood up. Immediately, she went on —However, that's exactly what my pessimism needs.

—Agreed— Castaspella giggled, standing too and stepping closer.

As they hugged, the old vampire felt some of her anguish lessen.

Her concerns about the future remained, but now it felt less catastrophic.

Strangely enough, she realized she held hope for an utopic future; for Castaspella, not for herself, of course. Such hopes *were* stupid, yes, because that's unrealistic… However, now she realized hope itself wasn't the problem.

After all, wanting justice and reason to lead the world is nothing but the bare minimum…

Chapter End Notes

HEHE!!

Yes, this is the end! (for now? Maybe)

And just in case, yes! the final sentence is a reference to this fic's title!!! :D
(well, kinda. Like, "judgement" is the action of serving justice, technically? Well, whatever XD)

Ahem, so… Yeah, I think there isn't much more to say, but I'll gladly answer any questions u may have in the comments!!

Many thanks for reading (#^_^#) Hope to see you again, here or in another fic!! <3

End Notes

Art Gallery

More coming soon



Feel free to find the artists here!

- Isle of Lesbos Resident
- Kuurankaiho
  - Hordak art

Go give ‘em love!

> Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!